

ENTRENCHED

A body-horror tabletop roleplaying game of mud, memory, and the long war

THE 187TH ALLIED SAPPER REGIMENT



*You are not sent forward because you are expendable.
You are sent forward because you can be repaired.*

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Entrenched License

FIELD ORDERS

Entrenched

Entrenched is a brutal body-horror tabletop RPG set in 1951, thirty-seven years after the Great War began. The nations of western Europe have calcified into authoritarian military coalitions that fight for inches across a landscape made from mud, ruins, machinery, and the repeatedly reconstructed dead.

The players are fresh recruits assigned to the [187th Sappers Regiment](#). They cross [No-Man's-Land](#), discover and mark routes on a shared physical map, complete an impossible military objective, die, and return altered by donor flesh and memories that do not belong to them.

Death makes a sapper more capable. It also consumes Humanity. Battleborn bodies eventually become Burn-Listed, drawing specialist enemy sections whose orders are to pin the remains and erase every recoverable trace.

Choose a Route

The links in these routes are the main way through the manual. The alphabetical table of contents is a shelf for finding a specific record, not a required reading order.

First Session: Read and Play

1. Agree on boundaries in [Safety and Tone](#).
2. Read [Your First Orders](#) aloud and create the unit as the recruits arrive. Open [Character Creation](#) when a choice needs its full rule, or use [Example Sappers](#).
3. The referee briefs [Raise the Red Flag](#). Keep [Quick Reference](#) and the [Run Cycle Checklist](#) beside the map.

You can begin play here. Follow the rules links when a situation calls for them.

Complete Player Rules

Read [Character Creation](#) (including [Field Doctrines](#)) → [Core Game Loop](#) → [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) → [Combat and Movement](#) → [Equipment](#) → [Death and Revival](#) → [Humanity and Battleborn](#) → [Replacements and Memories](#). Finish with [Quick Reference](#) as a table aid, not another chapter.

Referee Preparation

Read [Referee Guide](#) → [Mission Construction](#) → [Raise the Red Flag](#). Use [Referee Lore Guide](#) to seed discoveries and [Changing Ground](#) when the map changes. Keep [Retaliation Tables](#), [Enemies and Monsters](#), [Stationary Defenses](#), [Combat Checklist](#), and [Movement and Exploration Checklist](#) available for live play.

Setting Dossiers

The setting records are for referee preparation and for players who enjoy browsing revealed lore. They are not prerequisites for the first operation. A natural route is [The Long War](#) → [The Allied Trench](#) → [187th Sappers Regiment](#) → [No-Man's-Land](#) → [The Shifting Front](#) → [The First Sappers](#) → [Project Eisensee](#) → [The Butchers](#) → [Corpse Hounds and Handlers](#) → [Faith of the Final Trench](#) → [The Enemy](#).

Vault Structure

- **00 Start Here:** Safety, induction, and quick-reference material
- **01 Core Rules:** Player rules, character rules, death, repair, scars, and equipment
- **02 Referee:** Procedures for running operations, retaliation, and horror
- **03 Operations:** Ready-to-run operations
- **04 Setting:** The Long War, factions, institutions, and battlefield lore
- **05 Bestiary:** Enemy profiles and monsters
- **06 Play Aids:** Pregenerated characters and printable checklists for live play

The Referee's Central Principle

DESIGN TEST Every death should make a sapper more useful, more visibly inhuman, and meaningfully closer to permanent destruction. The setting should answer practical questions while leaving its cosmology unstable. The sappers can learn how revival works without ever proving what returns.

Safety and Tone

Entrenched is built around war, repeated death, surgery, bodily alteration, stolen memories, coercive authority, and loss of identity. These subjects should be intense for the characters without becoming harmful to the people playing them.

Referees should carry these boundaries into the descriptions and procedures in the [Referee Guide](#) and [Referee Lore Guide](#).

Before Play

Tell everyone what the game contains. Discuss boundaries before characters or maps are prepared.

Use two lists:

- **Lines:** Content that will not appear at all.
- **Veils:** Content that may exist but will happen off-screen or without detailed description.

Ask specifically about:

- Surgical detail and medical trauma
- Eye, tooth, skin, limb, and organ horror
- Animal grafts and transformation
- Memory loss, dementia-like imagery, and identity erasure
- Cremation and permanent destruction
- Religious coercion and authoritarian punishment
- Harm involving children, civilians, or animals
- Starvation, gas, drowning, burial, and confinement

Nobody needs to explain a boundary.

During Play

Any player may say **Pause** or make an agreed hand signal. Stop the description immediately. The group may revise the detail, veil the remainder of the scene, or move past it. Do not ask the player to defend the request.

Anyone may step away and return when ready. The game does not require a character explanation for a player's absence.

VEIL THE IMAGE, KEEP THE CONSEQUENCE The referee can keep every mechanical consequence while veiling imagery. A reconstruction may still cost Humanity, alter the body record, and damage identity without describing a particular procedure.

Character Control

THE PLAYER RETAINS CONTROL Donor memories and impulses are optional roleplay aids. The player decides whether and how they appear, and may ignore a prompt without cost. They never grant bonuses, impose penalties, force actions, change loyalties, erase written memories, or cost Humanity. Identity changes at Humanity thresholds remain part of the rules, subject to the group's agreed boundaries.

Identity fields are physically obscured because Humanity is being lost. A player may choose how to mark the sheet and may use removable overlays, sticky notes, or a photocopy if permanent alteration of the original sheet would be uncomfortable.

Horror, Not Humiliation

Describe bodies as altered, functional, intimate, and wrong. Do not treat disability, disfigurement, mental illness, nationality, or real-world ethnicity as shorthand for monstrosity. The horror comes from involuntary reconstruction, institutional exploitation, and foreign memories—not from a body failing to look ordinary.

The enemy may mirror the Allies without using real-world slurs or asking players to reproduce historical hatred.

After Play

Take a few minutes to leave the trench behind. Ask:

- Is there imagery we should reduce or veil next time?
- Is there a moment whose consequences we want to preserve?
- Does anyone want a boundary changed?

Boundaries may change between or during sessions. Agreement at the beginning is not permanent consent.

Continue: [Your First Orders](#) introduces the unit in play. [Return to the reading routes](#).

Your First Orders

Read this aloud together before creating sappers. When the text asks you to record something, pause and write it on the character sheet. By the time the truck reaches the 187th, the person on the sheet will be under military authority.

BEFORE INDUCTION Agree on boundaries using Safety and Tone before beginning. You may describe your sapper briefly, draw a veil over an image, or answer a prompt without explaining it. The induction establishes a character; it does not overrule anyone's limits.

The Transport

You share a packed transport truck with a dozen other recruits. The benches tremble beneath you.

The canvas roof traps the smell of damp wool, old tobacco, and the sour antiseptic painted along the benches. Rifles knock together whenever the wheels enter a shell hole. Nobody acknowledges the sickly sweet smell of burnt flesh. Everyone holds their papers inside their coat as though the rain might dissolve their names before command has finished using them.

Beyond the canvas, western Europe passes in fragments: roofless villages, chalk roads, fields furrowed by artillery, and columns of soldiers moving toward a horizon that has flashed without pause since before you were born.

Someone near the tailgate asks how old you are. Before you answer, the truck stops.

Record your sapper's **name, date of birth, height and weight**, and one **identifying mark**. These details belong to the body that enlisted. Write them in ink. Do not leave room for corrections.

What You Carried Here

The truck begins moving again.

You have been told not to bring personal effects. Nearly everyone has disobeyed. A recruit across from you holds a house key to a building that may no longer exist. Another wears a wedding ring on a cord because the proper finger was taken during a training incident. One has brought nothing and keeps checking their pockets anyway.

You try to remember the last place where the ground did not shake.

Record one **memory from before you joined the war**. Make it small enough to belong to one person: the color of a kitchen wall, somebody laughing with food in their mouth, wet shoes beside a stove, a particular hand resting on your shoulder. Do not write a history. Write something that would hurt to lose.

Then record one **person, place, or belief you must not forget**. This is not protection. It is the first entry the reconstruction clerks will compare against what returns.

The Buried Regiment

Night has fallen when the truck enters the communications trench. There is no gate and no sign. The road simply sinks between walls of wet timber until the sky becomes a narrow black strip overhead.

Soldiers watch from firing steps as you pass. Some are bandaged. Some have shapes beneath their uniforms that no bandage would explain. A corporal raises a hand to stop the convoy, and the hand continues unfolding after an ordinary wrist should have ended.

Painted on the wall behind them is a plain red flag.

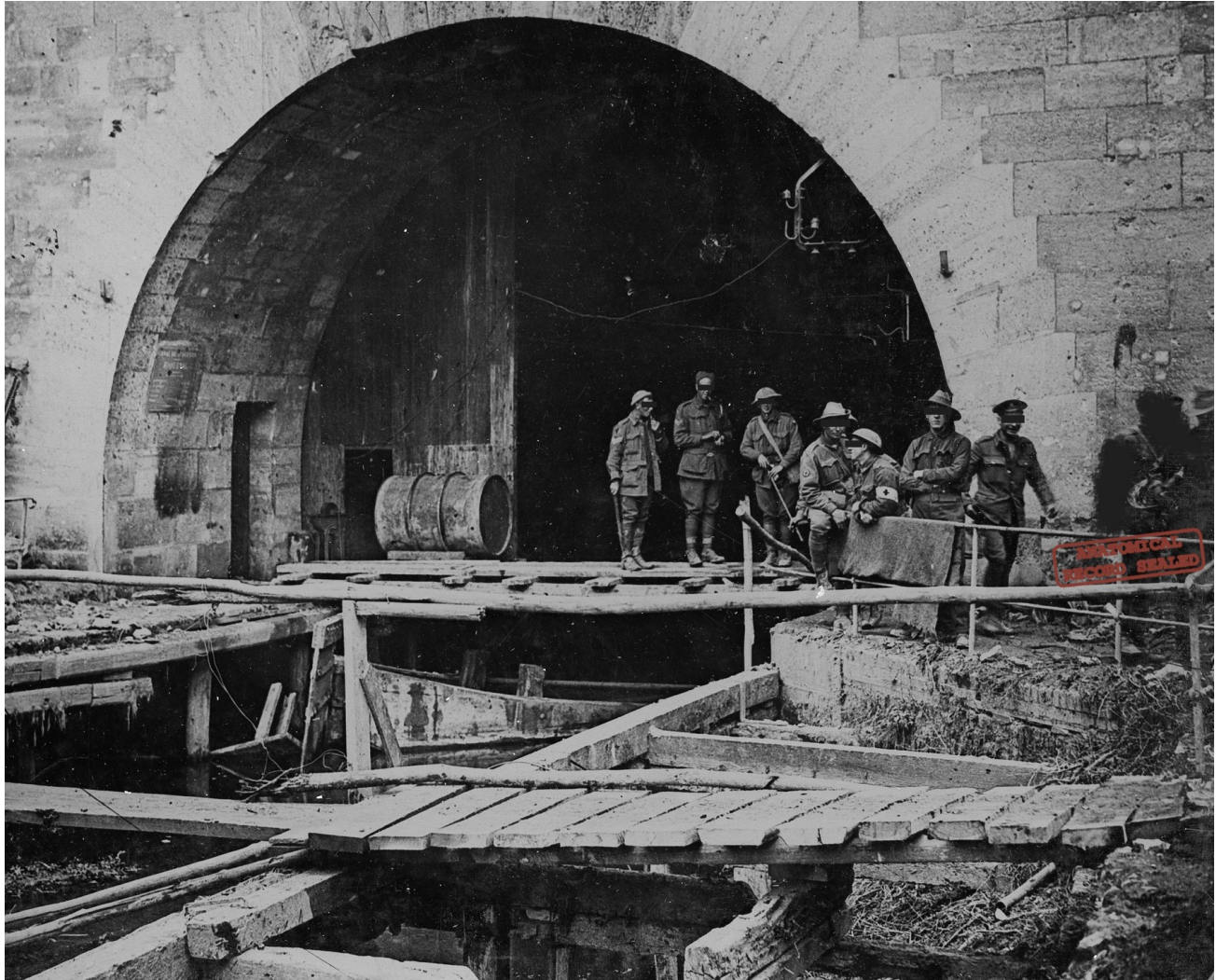
You have been assigned to the **187th Sapper Regiment**, formally recorded as the Royal 187th Regiment for Penetration, Recovery, and Fortification. Nobody says the full name. Here it is called the Buried Regiment, the Returned, or simply the One-Eighty-Seventh.

Its sections go where ordinary infantry cannot be spent efficiently. They locate mines, cross open ground, break fortifications, recover bodies, and prepare the route for everyone waiting behind them.

The regiment does not promise that you will survive. It promises that your service will continue.

Classification

You leave the truck beneath a corrugated roof. A clerk takes your papers without looking at your face. Behind the desk, six boards list the work for which recruits are still required.



The entrance to the buried regiment

Choose one **Specialty**:

- **Scout:** You notice routes, movement, hidden positions, and danger before it reaches the section. Begin with Awareness 2.
- **Demolitionist:** You understand charges, blast direction, and which part of a structure must fail first. Begin with Demolitions 2.
- **Mine-Clearer:** You read disturbed earth, wire, mechanisms, and unexploded ordnance. Begin with Engineering 2.
- **Trench Fighter:** You clear confined positions and keep violence away from the sapper beside you. Begin with Close Quarters 2.
- **Runner:** You cross exposed ground, carry orders, and reach bodies while recovery is still possible. Begin with Mobility 2.
- **Rifleman:** You wait for a visible opening and kill at distance. Begin with Ranged 2.

Your Specialty grants its Field Doctrine from [Field Doctrines](#). It is the work command assigns you first, not the limit of what your body may eventually learn.

The clerk directs you to three testing stations. Nobody asks what you enjoy. They ask what you can already do while frightened, exhausted, and observed.

Assign **five additional skill ranks** among Ranged, Close Quarters, Awareness, Stealth, Engineering, Demolitions, Strength, and Mobility. Your Specialty already provides two ranks, giving you seven total. No skill may begin above rank 3. Check one box for each starting rank; later ranks fill more boxes on the same rows.

When you finish, the clerk stamps the page:

PRIVATE — *HUMANITY 100* — *DEFENSE 1* — *WOUNDS 0*

You are still entirely human. The regiment therefore expects a bullet to kill you quickly.

Issue

The quartermaster works behind a mesh screen. Equipment hangs on numbered hooks. Every item is cleaner than the hands passing it to you.

You receive a steel helmet and quilted armor. The armor is meant to keep a body identifiable and prevent loose portions from being lost during transport. It does not raise your starting Defense above 1.

Choose **three level 1 items** from Equipment. A useful recruit normally carries:

- A weapon appropriate to their assigned work
- A tool that helps the section overcome an obstacle
- A second weapon, supply, explosive, or protective item

The quartermaster records each item's bearer. Command cares who was issued a thing because bodies return incomplete and expensive equipment does not always return with them.

The Demonstration

Before you can leave, an orderly leads the recruits to a tiled room below the trench.

A dead sapper lies on the central table. Their tunic has been cut away. One boot is laced loosely around a leg that ends above the knee. A Butcher washes their hands in a metal basin and asks the orderly for a replacement by weight.

Nobody tells you to remain. The orderly waits beside the open door while the Butcher works.

The Butcher fits the replacement into the body, tests the new joint, and closes the seam with black cord. At a soft utterance from the Butcher, the corpse begins breathing. The recruits nearest the table step back into the crowded room.

The revived sapper opens unmatching eyes and asks whether the red flag has risen.

The Butcher answers, "Not yet."

This is what command means by recovery. When you die and enough of you remains, another sapper may perform a field revival under fire, or the Butchers may reconstruct you after the corpse hounds bring you home. You will return with every Wound box cleared. You will also lose Humanity, replace parts of your body, gain two skill ranks, and perhaps remember something from the donor's life. Black Matter grants a third rank and costs 2 extra Humanity.

LOSS ON THE BATTLEFIELD Nothing is erased neatly. Your sheet will be crossed out, overwritten, and drawn upon as your sapper changes. The body diagram is not decoration. It is the service record command trusts most.

Section Assignment

An officer divides the recruits into sections of three to six. You are placed with the other players.

Look at the sappers beside you. Say your sapper's name, Specialty, and the ordinary memory they wrote down. You do not need to trust one another yet. You need to know what voice to follow through smoke and which body must not be left for the enemy.

Together, confirm that every sheet has:

- A name and enlistment details
- One memory from before the war
- One person, place, or belief that must not be forgotten
- One Specialty and its Field Doctrine
- Exactly seven starting skill ranks, with no skill above 3
- Humanity 100, Defense 1, and no Wound boxes
- Three level 1 items, plus issued helmet, armor, respirator, map case, and grease pencil
- An untouched body diagram and empty replacement record

If anything is missing, the clerk returns the page without comment, a cold look behind their eyes.

The First Briefing

Your section is taken to a dugout where a paper map has been pinned beneath cracked glass. Most of no-man's-land is blank. Command has drawn the Allied trench, several distant landmarks, and the approximate location of an objective it considers essential.

Everything between those marks is your responsibility.

You will cross the parapet, discover what command does not know, and mark it on the shared map. Routes will remain useful. Destroyed positions will remain destroyed. Mines, shelters, patrols, bodies, and mistakes will accumulate in ink. The map may outlive every sapper who contributes to it.

Outside, infantry gather in the communications trenches. Gun crews wait beside loaded guns and equipment stained brown and stitched together by unseen maintenance teams. Stretcher bearers arrange empty litters against the wall. None of them know when they will advance. They are waiting for your section to make the assault possible.

The officer folds a plain red flag and places it on the table.

"Your lives are replaceable," the officer says. "The operation is not."

Read [Quick Reference](#) or begin the briefing for [Raise the Red Flag](#). When the Referee asks what your sapper does, answer in the first person if that feels natural.

You are no longer riding toward the Front.

You are part of it.

Continue: [Core Game Loop](#) explains what happens after deployment. The referee can open [Raise the Red Flag](#) for the first operation.

Quick Reference

Before the Operation

- Three to six players create sappers using [Character Creation](#).
- The referee prepares an objective and persistent map using [Mission Construction](#).
- Agree on boundaries using [Safety and Tone](#).
- Each sapper begins at 100 Humanity, Defense 1, no Wound boxes, and three level 1 equipment slots.
- Each sapper has one [Field Doctrine](#). All except **Wait for the Opening** may be used once per run.

Checks

1. Roll **checked skill ranks + equipment + modifiers** in d6s. A skill has at most 12 checked ranks.
2. A sapper with no checked ranks in that skill starts with 1 die before equipment.
3. Count every 6 as one success.
4. Meet or exceed Resistance to succeed.
5. Failure at Resistance 1 or higher does not complete the action. Outside combat it triggers immediate retaliation; during combat the enemy turn is the retaliation unless a specific rule says otherwise.

Resistance 0 checks automatically succeed and never retaliate. Give the basic result, then add one useful detail, option, or resource for each success rolled.

Bought Knowledge: After a failed Resistance 1+ check outside combat, resolve one retaliation and reveal one useful truth exposed by the failure. Mark it on the map. The action still fails, and the truth points toward another decision rather than solving the obstacle.

During combat, failure does not create an extra immediate retaliation unless a specific action, item, hazard, or operation says it does. The enemy turn is the retaliation.

Resistance	Meaning
0	Minor and safe; automatically succeeds, with extra yield per rolled success
1	Dangerous; suited to a trained sapper
2	Severe; requires a strong, well-equipped sapper
3	Extreme; normally requires equipment and cooperation
4+	Operation-level; requires preparation or progress across runs

For cooperation, the leader rolls their normal pool. Every trained helper adds only their checked skill ranks, not the untrained fallback or equipment. Everyone involved is exposed if the check fails. During combat, leading or helping consumes that sapper's action.

Resistance 4+ is reduced through discoveries, sabotage, supplies, and completed sub-objectives rather than repeated rolls that accumulate successes.

Combat Round

1. **Sapper turn:** Every living sapper takes one action in any order.
2. **Enemy turn:** Every formation, independent enemy, and monster takes one action.

An action can attack, move, use equipment, attempt a task, cooperate, begin revival, or retreat.

During danger, movement is **2 + checked Mobility ranks**, maximum 12 squares. Outside danger, move between meaningful locations without counting every square.

- Melee: adjacent
- Close: 2–6 squares
- Far: 7 or more squares

A weapon adds its level only at its listed range. A target that cannot be seen cannot be attacked.

If one side has not detected the other when combat begins, the unaware side is Surprised for the first round: –1 Defense, minimum 1. The Choir Gun protects its bearer from this penalty against a visible Far enemy.

Attacks, Defense, and Wounds

Roll combat skill + weapon. If successes meet Defense, inflict a **lethal hit**. Base Defense is 1 at 100–75 Humanity and 2 at 74–0; improved armor sets a minimum Defense.

- If the target has an empty Wound box, mark it.
- If no Wound box is empty, a sapper becomes **Dying**. On their next turn they take one Last Action, then die.
- Every marked Wound box imposes –1 die to all checks and attacks.
- An effect that explicitly says **killed** bypasses Wound boxes.

At the table: Each red paper clip on the sheet edge is one marked Wound box and a –1 die wound. Use only the boxes granted by Humanity (none above 75, one at 75, two at 25). Remove clips when treatment or revival clears wounds; leave the printed Wound spaces unerased. See [Tracking Wounds at the Table](#).

Ordinary enemies have no Wound boxes.

Attacks normally select one target. When a rule lets one attack threaten several targets, roll once and compare the successes separately with each target's Defense.

An enemy formation makes one attack using the lead soldier's pool, adding +1 die per supporting soldier, maximum +3.

Revival

Field revival requires no check and takes one full turn in the same or an adjacent square to an identifiable body. The reviver must remain there through the enemy turn; the sapper returns at the beginning of the next sapper turn.

1. Choose the part from the fatal injury and the donor from available material. Roll only if the scene and a quick table choice cannot settle a detail.
2. Lose 1d6 + 2 Humanity in the field or 2d6 + 2 with the Butchers. Black Matter adds **2 Humanity** to that revival's cost, outside the incidental-loss limit.
3. Clear all Wounds and note the replacement plus **2 ranks owed**, or **3 total with Black Matter**. Assign ranks among any skills between runs, maximum 12 per skill. Drawings and optional donor memories can wait.

One revival grants one package of ranks even if several parts need replacing. Black Matter must be available, and using more of it does not multiply the bonus or cost. Do not also charge incidental Black Matter contact for the same graft.

A death staged solely to gain ranks grants none, including no Black Matter bonus; replacement and Humanity loss still apply. See [Replacements and Memories](#).

Humanity

Humanity	Condition
100–76	Human; Private; level 1 gear; 3 slots
75–51	Pain-Dead; Corporal; 1 Wound box; level 2 gear; 4 slots
50–26	Borrowed Reflex; one half-pool reroll each run
25–1	Redundant Anatomy; Sergeant; 2 Wound boxes; level 3 gear; 6 slots
0	Battleborn; Burn boxes; Burn-Listed after the third later death

Apply identity erasure immediately when crossing a threshold. At 0 Humanity, replace the original name with a battlefield name.

Memories and Battleborn

Donor memories are optional roleplay prompts. They grant no bonuses, impose no penalties or forced actions, and never cost Humanity or erase written memories. Humanity thresholds still alter the identity record.

Every death suffered after awakening at 0 Humanity marks one Burn box. The death whose revival first reaches 0 marks none. The death that marks the third Burn box makes the body Burn-Listed and draws an anti-Battleborn extermination section. Every death afterward draws another section. A Battleborn may revive unaided over three complete turns, but must do so before the hunters pin and incinerate the remains. Capture fills all remaining Burn boxes and draws an extermination section. The sapper remains recoverable until completely incinerated or otherwise made permanently unrecoverable.

The enemy normally attempts capture for study only when a sapper has 25 Humanity or less, extensive visible reconstruction, or level 3 equipment. Mark captives and likely routes on the map and provide a rescue opportunity whenever possible. A permanently lost sapper may be replaced by a new Private at the next trench return.

Run Cycle

Briefing → Outfitting → Deployment → Discovery → Retaliation → Recovery → Reconstruction → Return

The operation ends when the objective is completed or the entire unit is permanently destroyed.

Referee Play Aids

- [Combat Checklist](#)
- [Movement and Exploration Checklist](#)
- [Run Cycle Checklist](#)

THE SAPPER'S HANDBOOK

Character Creation

Sappers begin as recruits: hastily trained, minimally equipped, and expected to learn their trade by dying. Every sapper begins as a Private with one specialty, seven total skill ranks, basic armor, and three equipment slots.

PRINTABLE CHARACTER SHEET Open or download the printable character sheet before beginning. Record every starting detail in ink. Keep a dark marker nearby; revival will overwrite the sapper's memories and alter the body diagram permanently.

Starting Profile

- **Rank:** Private
- **Humanity:** 100
- **Specialty:** One
- **Skill ranks:** Seven total
- **Defense:** 1
- **Equipment slots:** Three, plus issued helmet and basic armor
- **Wound boxes:** None until Humanity falls to 75

1. Record Enlistment Details

Record the person who entered service:

- Name
- Specialty
- Height and weight
- Date of birth
- Identifying marks
- A memory of life before the war
- A person, place, or belief they must not forget

Use ink, or the overlays, sticky notes, or photocopies described in [Safety and Tone](#). During play, Humanity rules require the player to obscure and overwrite this information. Preserve traces of the earlier record rather than erasing it cleanly.

2. Choose a Specialty

A specialty is a starting package and guideline, not a permanent class. Choose one, gain 2 ranks in its listed skill, and learn its [Field Doctrine](#).

Specialty	Starting Skill	Role in the Unit
Scout	Awareness 2	Finds routes, hidden positions, movement, and danger before it finds the unit
Demolitionist	Demolitions 2	Places charges and destroys structures, machines, and fortifications
Mine-Clearer	Engineering 2	Identifies and neutralizes mines, traps, wire, and unexploded ordnance
Trench Fighter	Close Quarters 2	Clears confined positions and protects the unit at arm's reach
Runner	Mobility 2	Crosses exposed ground, carries orders, and reaches fallen sappers quickly
Rifleman	Ranged 2	Engages distant threats before they can close on the unit

The specialty name may be changed to fit the sapper. Its starting skill and Field Doctrine remain the same. A sapper keeps that doctrine even when later repairs and experience carry them far beyond their original role.

Field Doctrines

The chosen specialty grants one Field Doctrine. It remains available as the sapper's skills and body change; it is learned training, not a permanent class restriction.

Unless a doctrine says otherwise:

- A doctrine may be used once per run.
- Using a doctrine is part of the action or event that triggers it and does not cost another action.
- A doctrine cannot make an impossible action possible, reveal information the sapper could not perceive, attack an unseen target, or bypass the Protection of a [stationary defense](#).
- A use is spent when its effect is declared. If it modifies a check, it is spent whether that check succeeds or fails.
- A doctrine refreshes at the beginning of the next run.

Scout: Read the Ground

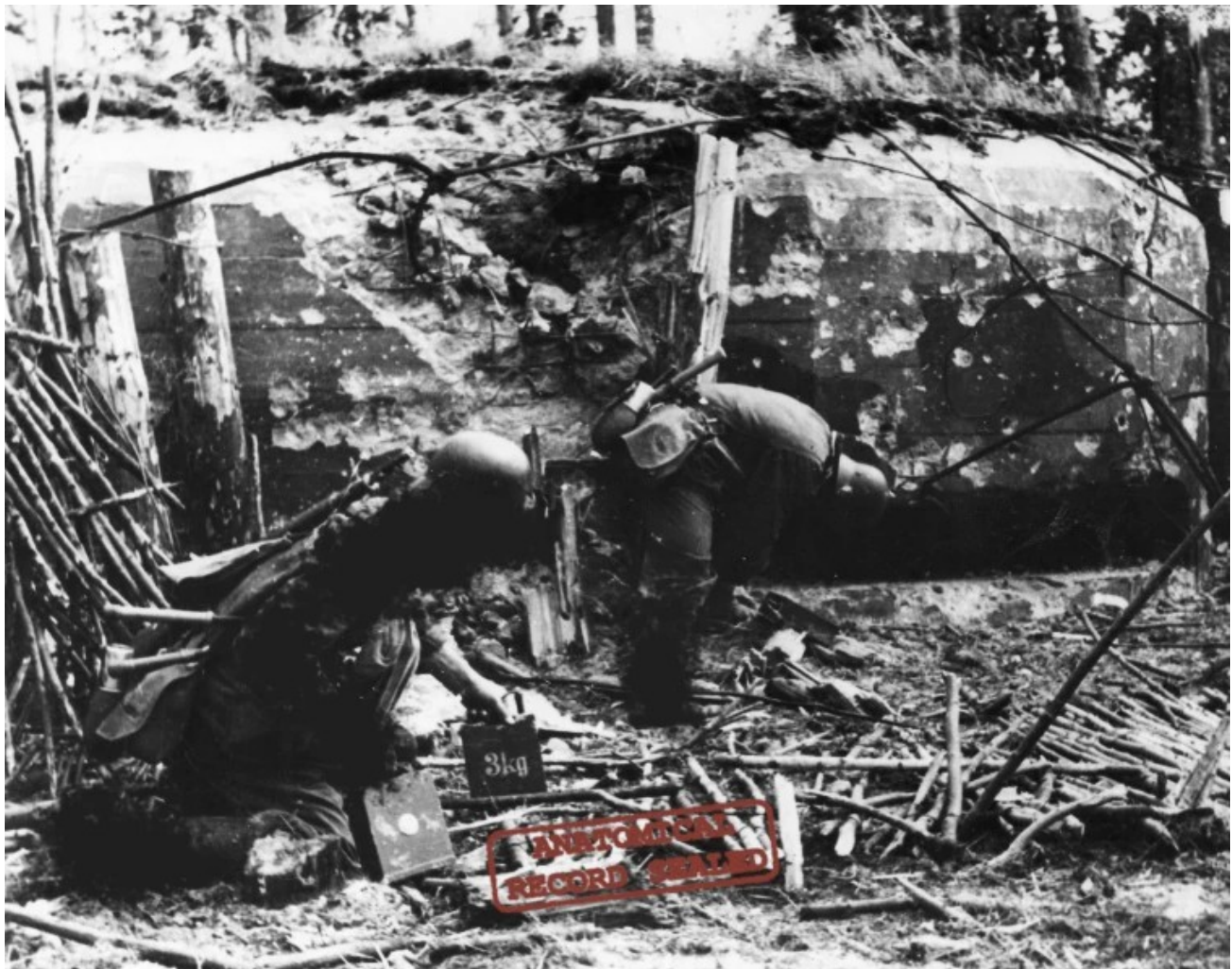
Once per run, before the unit enters a visible area, the Scout may study it and ask the referee one question:

- What is watching this area?
- What is the safest visible approach?
- What here has changed since the map was made?
- Where could one sapper remain unseen?

REFeree ANSWER Answer honestly with what the Scout can reasonably infer from their position. The answer may reveal a danger, firing lane, sign, or opportunity without explaining everything concealed there or how it must be defeated. Asking the question requires enough time and visibility to examine the area; it cannot interrupt an attack or other retaliation already being resolved.

Demolitionist: Leave the Right Ruin

Once per run, after succeeding on a Demolitions check, the Demolitionist chooses one additional benefit that follows from the blast:



A Demolitionist and partner are seen setting breaching charges on an enemy bunker

- One named nearby person, route, or object is spared.
- The wreckage creates useful cover.
- The destruction appears accidental until closely inspected.
- One useful piece of salvage survives and can be recovered.

The choice cannot contradict the declared purpose of the charge. A blast intended to collapse the only bridge cannot also preserve that bridge, and controlled destruction cannot overcome a fortification that has not yet been made vulnerable.

Mine-Clearer: Follow My Steps

Once per run, after identifying a trapped, mined, wired, or unstable route, the Mine-Clearer may lead the unit through it. Make one Engineering check for the crossing.

On a success, every sapper who follows the Mine-Clearer's exact path as part of the same crossing passes through safely. On a failure, the crossing does not succeed and the referee makes one primary retaliation against the exposed unit rather than calling for a separate check or retaliation for every sapper.

This doctrine does not disarm the hazard or make the route permanently safe. Mark it as known but still dangerous on the shared map. Anyone who leaves the path or crosses it later faces the hazard normally.

Trench Fighter: Behind Me

Once per run, when an adjacent sapper is selected as the target of an attack, the Trench Fighter may intervene before the attack is rolled.

If the attack has only one target, the Trench Fighter becomes its target. If the same attack already threatens both sappers, the protected sapper instead gains +1 Defense against that attack; the Trench Fighter gains no Defense. Resolve every other target normally.

The Trench Fighter must be able to perceive the attack and physically place their body between it and the protected sapper. This doctrine cannot intercept gas filling an area, collapsing ground, or another effect for which one body provides no protection.

Runner: No One Left

Once per run, when another sapper becomes Dying, the Runner may immediately move up to their normal movement toward that sapper. Resolve this movement after the effect that made the sapper Dying and before play continues.

Every square crossed must bring the Runner closer by a viable route, and the movement must end closer to the fallen sapper. Dangerous ground still requires the normal check and may stop the Runner or provoke retaliation. Reaching the sapper does not include treatment, revival, an attack, or another free action.

Rifleman: Wait for the Opening

The Rifleman may spend an action aiming at one visible position, route, or opening. Mark the Rifleman as **Aimed**. Their next Ranged attack against a target in that position reduces that target's Defense by 1, to a minimum of 1. After resolving that attack, remove Aimed whether it succeeds or fails.

Unlike other doctrines, Wait for the Opening has no per-run limit because aiming costs an action. The Rifleman ceases to be Aimed if they move, attack another target, lose sight of the chosen position, or become Dying. The doctrine cannot attack an unseen target, ignore range, or bypass the Protection of a stationary defense. It may exploit an Opening that the unit has already created.

Changing a Specialty Name

The player may rename a specialty to fit the sapper's history while retaining its skill and doctrine. A Scout might be called an Observer, a Runner a Stretcher-Bearer, or a Trench Fighter a Raider. The title changes; the rules do not.

3. Assign Recruit Training

Assign 5 additional skill ranks among any skills. Each rank is one checked box on that skill's row. Combined with the 2 ranks from specialty, every recruit begins with 7 checked boxes total. No skill may begin above rank 3; over a sapper's lifetime, no skill may exceed rank 12.

Sappers gain additional **skill ranks** through revival. Check one more box in the chosen skill for each rank gained. The number of checked boxes is the skill's current rank and the number of skill dice it contributes. Each eligible revival

grants 2 ranks, or 3 with Black Matter, divided among any skills. Equipment and chosen skills define the sapper's capabilities; replacement descriptions and donor memories are roleplay aids.

Skills

Combat Skills

- **Ranged:** Rifles, pistols, machine guns, grenades, thrown equipment, and attacks beyond arm's reach.
- **Close Quarters:** Knives, clubs, bayonets, grappling, and fighting at Melee range.

Field Skills

- **Awareness:** Finding enemies, hidden routes, mines, traps, distant movement, and battlefield changes.
- **Stealth:** Moving, hiding, and concealing bodies, equipment, or signs of passage.
- **Engineering:** Disarming mines and traps, cutting wire, sabotaging machines, repairing equipment, and building or placing traps.
- **Demolitions:** Placing explosives and controlling what their detonation destroys.

Physical Skills

- **Strength:** Lifting, forcing, climbing, breaking, and other feats of power.
- **Mobility:** Running, balance, agility, reflexes, and escaping artillery, collapsing ground, fire, and shrapnel.

When an action is not clearly covered, the referee chooses the closest skill based on the sapper's approach. Rules for checks are in [Skill Checks and Exploration](#).

4. Determine Rank

Rank follows Humanity. Command promotes reconstructed soldiers because their altered bodies can operate valuable equipment and because few will survive long enough to threaten the hierarchy.

Rank	Humanity	Equipment Access	Equipment Slots
Private	100–76	Level 1	3
Corporal	75–26	Levels 1–2	4
Sergeant	25–1	Levels 1–3	6
Battleborn	0	Levels 1–3	6

Promotion occurs immediately when Humanity crosses a threshold. New equipment access and slots become available when the unit returns to the Allied trench before its next run. Rank never falls and Humanity cannot be restored.

Checked skill ranks show both the recruit's training and what the body learned after enlistment. Military rank shows how close that body is to being expended.

5. Determine Defense and Wounds

Every new sapper has **Defense 1**, even in an issued helmet and basic armor. At 75 Humanity the body can survive one lethal hit through Wounds, but its Defense remains 1. Once Humanity falls below 75, accumulated reconstruction, scar tissue, and altered reflexes raise the sapper's base Defense to 2.

Basic armor does not consume an equipment slot and is already included in the starting profile. Improved armor replaces the issued protection and modifies Defense as described in [Equipment](#) rather than adding to it.

This change is not promotion armor. It is the body's growing difficulty in accepting a clean death. At 75 Humanity a sapper gains one Wound box, and at 25 Humanity they gain a second. A lethal hit marks an empty Wound box and wounds the sapper. If none remain empty, the sapper becomes Dying, takes one Last Action on their next turn, and then dies.

Use the sheet's Wound spaces to show how many boxes the sapper has gained, and red paper clips on the sheet edge to show which boxes are currently marked by wounds. See [Tracking Wounds at the Table](#).

6. Choose Equipment

Choose items from [Equipment](#). A sapper may choose items up to their rank's equipment level and may carry no more items than their available slots.

Armor, weapons, tools, explosives, and specialized supplies normally consume one slot each unless their description says otherwise. The issued helmet and basic armor do not consume slots.

7. Record Humanity

Every new sapper begins with 100 Humanity. Mark each threshold when crossed:

- 100–76: Human
- 75–51: Pain-Dead; Corporal; one Wound box
- 50–26: Borrowed Reflex; one reroll each run
- 25–1: Redundant Anatomy; Sergeant; two Wound boxes
- 0: Battleborn; three Burn boxes before becoming Burn-Listed

Revival and recovery are in [Death and Revival](#). Identity loss, thresholds, and Burn are in [Humanity and Battleborn](#).

Ready for Deployment

Before play, confirm that the sheet shows:

- Enlistment details and two anchors to the sapper's former life
- One specialty and exactly seven total skill ranks
- Private rank, 100 Humanity, and Defense 1
- Three level 1 equipment choices
- Issued helmet, basic armor, respirator, map case, and grease pencil, which use no equipment slots
- No Wound or Burn boxes marked

Leave all ten zones of the body diagram and the replacement record untouched. They belong to the sapper's deaths, not their creation.

Continue: [Core Game Loop](#) shows what this sapper will do on a run.

Core Game Loop

Use [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) and [Combat and Movement](#) when danger requires exact actions or a safe analysis check measures what the unit learns, [Retaliation Tables](#) when dangerous failure changes the battlefield, and [Death and Revival](#) when a sapper falls.

The Shape of a Run

Entrenched follows one sapper unit through a single operation on the Western Front. The unit has been given an objective somewhere beyond its own trench: seize an enemy position, destroy a fortification, recover intelligence, collapse a tunnel network, or complete some other task that command considers worth any number of lives.

Entrenched lasts until the sappers complete their objective or the entire unit is permanently destroyed. Most operations should take two to four sessions.

The same players may begin a later operation as a new sapper unit with a new mission and a new stretch of no-man's-land to learn.

Runs Into No-Man's-Land

Play is divided into **runs**. Every run begins in the Allied trench and sends the unit into no-man's-land. A run should take about thirty minutes of real time, allowing several attempts during a two- or three-hour session.

During a run, the sappers cross hostile ground, search for routes and shelter, overcome obstacles, and push toward their objective. They do not have the luxury of lengthy planning. Enemy fire, artillery, and the changing battlefield keep them moving. If the players spend too long debating, the battlefield acts against them just as it does after a failed check. The referee should make the approaching danger clear, demand an immediate decision, and retaliate if the unit still hesitates.

A run usually ends in one of three ways:

- The unit is killed and its bodies are recovered.
- The surviving sappers revive their fallen and retreat to the Allied trench. Unrevived bodies are abandoned to later recovery.
- The unit completes the operation.

Death does not reset the battlefield. Each run leaves the unit with new knowledge, altered bodies, and less of the people who first crossed the parapet.

The Shared Map

The players share a physical map of the operation area, normally 36 squares wide and between 84 and 144 squares long. At the beginning of the operation, it contains only what Allied command believes it knows. The players add to it as their sappers explore.

They may mark discoveries such as:

- Minefields and suspected mines
- Barbed wire and barricades
- Shelters and shell craters
- Enemy firing positions
- Patrol routes
- Tunnels and buried structures
- Supply caches
- Passable and impassable ground
- Safe, dangerous, and untested routes

Information survives even when the sappers who discovered it do not. The marked map is the unit's chief advantage over the battlefield. Every death should teach the unit something that may help during its next run.

Moving Across the Operation Map

The operation map records position and discovery; it is not a board on which every quiet step must be counted. Outside immediate danger, move the unit between meaningful locations, obstacles, and decisions. Crossing a known safe route needs no roll and may cover many squares at once.

Count exact squares only when position matters: during combat, pursuit, a timed hazard, or movement across dangerous ground. In those moments, use the movement rules in [Combat and Movement](#). When immediate danger ends, return to location-to-location movement.

This distinction keeps a long paper map useful without turning every crossing into dozens of movement actions.

All runs begin from the Allied trench. The unit may learn a faster or safer route, but it must cross no-man's-land again each time.

Most discoveries remain reliable for the entire operation. Cleared mines, destroyed barriers, tunnels, shelters, and major terrain stay marked unless something in the fiction changes them. Bodies may be recovered or moved, patrols may be reinforced, and enemy positions may shift in response to the unit's actions.

Failure Draws Fire

No-man's-land never waits quietly. Outside combat, when a sapper fails a Resistance 1 or higher check, the enemy retaliates or the battlefield turns against the unit. During combat, the enemy turn is the retaliation unless a specific rule says otherwise. A failed dangerous check should create immediate danger rather than halt progress. Resistance 0 checks automatically succeed and do not retaliate; they measure how much useful information or material a sapper extracts from a safe opportunity.

Failure also buys knowledge. After resolving non-combat retaliation, reveal one concrete truth exposed by the mistake and add it to the shared map. The unit pays in blood, position, or equipment, but the battlefield becomes more legible. See [Bought Knowledge](#) for the complete procedure.

Retaliation may include:

- Rifle or machine-gun fire
- An artillery or mortar strike
- An enemy patrol closing on the unit
- A mine or hidden trap detonating
- The loss or destruction of equipment
- The collapse of cover, a tunnel, or unstable ground
- The unit's position being revealed

Retaliation may threaten the sapper who failed, another exposed sapper, or the whole unit, depending on what is happening in the fiction.

Retaliation is intentionally lethal. Combat attacks that meet Defense inflict lethal hits, marking available Wound boxes before leaving a sapper Dying. Non-combat dangers may mark a Wound box or explicitly kill when the consequence is overwhelming. Careful choices, equipment, and accumulated knowledge improve the sappers' chances, but no route through no-man's-land is safe.

Death in the Field

If at least one sapper remains alive after a fight or disaster, that survivor can rebuild the fallen in the field. Field revival is crude, hurried work performed with nearby remains and whatever tools the unit carried. It returns the fallen sapper during the same run with every Wound box cleared. Choose the replacement part from the fatal injury and its source from nearby remains; roll only if the scene and a quick choice cannot settle a detail. Each revival grants 2 ranks, or 3

with Black Matter at a cost of 2 additional Humanity. Note the part and donor now; drawings, rank allocation, and optional donor memories can wait until between runs.

The unit succeeds and fails together. Ordinary retreat does not include carrying fallen sappers back to the trench. Equipment and specific recovery actions may reposition bodies as described. Survivors must field-revive a fallen sapper before retreating with them. Any body left behind is abandoned to corpse hounds, enemy recovery, or the battlefield and is resolved after the run. When a fallen or captured sapper can still be recovered, their location or route remains on the map and the unit receives a dangerous opportunity to bring them back. No sapper is left in no-man's-land lightly.

If the entire unit dies and no Battleborn can still attempt unaided revival, corpse hounds or recovery details eventually return the bodies to the Allied trench. The Butchers rebuild them there, and the next run begins after their revival. See [Death and Revival](#) for both recovery paths.

Humanity in War

Every sapper tracks Humanity separately, beginning at 100. Revival costs Humanity. A typical sapper is expected to die and return three to five times during each session.

As Humanity falls, the sapper becomes more capable and less recognizably human. Their replacements, memories, and altered behavior record the price of every run. This transformation is useful to the mission: the sappers most suited to the worst dangers are those closest to losing themselves.

At 0 Humanity, a sapper becomes **Battleborn**. The player retains control of them. Their durability and accumulated skill make them the natural choice for the operation's most dangerous work, but every death suffered after awakening at 0 Humanity marks one of three Burn boxes. The death whose revival first reduces them to 0 marks none. The death that marks the third Burn box makes the body Burn-Listed and draws an anti-Battleborn section carrying restraints, phosphorus, and orders to leave no recoverable tissue. Every death afterward draws another section. See [Humanity and Battleborn](#) for the thresholds and full Burn procedure.

The operation has no arbitrary deadline. Its pressure is visible instead: Allied assault troops gather behind the parapet, guns register their targets, stretchers are stacked, and officers wait for the unit's signal. The Referee shows that readiness after every cycle. The soldiers may wait for the red flag, but the waiting must feel expensive.

The Cycle

Each run repeats the following cycle:

1. **Briefing:** Command assigns the operation and gives the unit its incomplete map.
2. **Outfitting:** The sappers select the limited equipment they will carry.
3. **Deployment:** The unit leaves the Allied trench and begins a run.
4. **Discovery:** The sappers explore, mark the map, and learn how the battlefield works.
5. **Retaliation:** Outside combat, failed Resistance 1 or higher checks provoke immediate and often lethal consequences, then leave Bought Knowledge. During combat, the enemy turn is the retaliation unless a specific rule says otherwise. Resistance 0 discoveries do not retaliate.
6. **Recovery:** Survivors revive the fallen, retreat without bodies they could not repair, or die beside them.
7. **Reconstruction:** The Butchers rebuild recovered dead, Humanity is lost, and replacement parts and ranks owed are recorded.
8. **Return:** The altered unit chooses equipment using what it has learned and enters no-man's-land again.

Showing Allied Readiness

At every Return, add one concrete sign that the larger assault is ready and waiting. These signs do not impose a hidden countdown or end the operation by themselves.

- Fresh infantry crowd communications trenches that were empty on the previous run.
- Artillery crews hold loaded guns on coordinates supplied by the unit.

- Medical stations lay out numbered cots before casualties exist.
- Officers repeatedly ask whether the red flag will rise on the next attempt.
- Troops at the parapet stop talking when the reconstructed sappers pass.
- Runners carry revised orders whose only missing entry is the time of advance.

Readiness creates obligation, not a timer. Do not punish deliberate reconnaissance merely because another cycle passed. Show instead how many living people have placed their weight upon the unit's unfinished work.

Between-Runs Checklist

1. Preserve discoveries, cleared obstacles, destroyed positions, and abandoned equipment on the map.
2. Remove temporary smoke, fire, and other short-lived effects.
3. Resolve abandoned bodies and every Butcher reconstruction.
4. Record Humanity loss, repairs, newly checked skill ranks, promotions, Wounds, and Burn.
5. Decide what the enemy observed and choose one or two logical responses.
6. Replace and refill level 1 gear, account for scarce level 2 and priority level 3 supplies, and outfit every sapper.
7. Refresh per-run abilities. Players may add an optional donor memory to a replacement; no memory bookkeeping is required.
8. Begin again from the Allied trench, crossing unchanged safe ground quickly.

The cycle ends only in mission success or the permanent destruction of the unit.

Principles of Play

- **Keep moving.** Hesitation gives the battlefield time to kill.
- **Failure changes the situation.** It never produces a harmless dead end.
- **Knowledge outlives the body.** Exploration and mapmaking make later runs possible.
- **Nobody is disposable.** Recovery keeps the unit together and preserves its accumulated experience.
- **Death under orders changes the body.** A genuine battlefield death may teach the reconstructed body new skill ranks. A staged death grants no ranks and still costs Humanity.
- **Power brings final death closer.** The most capable sapper is often the one with the fewest lives left.

Continue: Skill Checks and Exploration explains the dice and dangerous choices; Combat and Movement follows with position, wounds, and fighting.

Skill Checks and Exploration

Build sappers in [Character Creation](#), apply their [Field Doctrines](#), and choose the weapons and tools used here from [Equipment](#).

Skill checks and attacks use the same basic rule: gather a pool of six-sided dice, roll them, and count every 6.

Each 6 is a **success**. If the roll produces successes equal to or greater than the target number, the action succeeds. Otherwise, it fails. Entrenched does not use partial successes. War does not take half measures.

Building a Dice Pool

When a sapper attempts a dangerous action, build their dice pool from:

I *Checked skill ranks + relevant equipment + other modifiers*

A sapper with five Engineering boxes checked and a mine-clearance kit rated 2 rolls seven dice to disarm a mine. Each checked box is one rank and adds one skill die. A skill can have at most 12 checked boxes; equipment and other modifiers are added separately.

If a sapper has no checked boxes in the required skill, they may still attempt the action with one die. Equipment and other modifiers are then added to that die as normal.

Most checks are rolled only when failure would expose the unit to danger or change the situation. **Resistance 0 checks are the exception:** use them when the action is safe and certain to work, but the sapper's skill may reveal additional information or resources. Ordinary actions whose outcome and yield are both obvious require no roll.

Resistance

Tasks and battlefield hazards have **Resistance**. Resistance is the number of successes required to overcome them.

Resistance	Opposition	Example
0	Minor	Even an inexperienced sapper is unchallenged; analyze visible ground, identify obvious obstacles, or search a secured position for options
1	Dangerous	A trained sapper has a fair chance; cross open ground between bursts or notice a poorly concealed mine
2	Severe	Requires a strong, well-equipped sapper; defuse an unfamiliar mine or pass an alert patrol unseen
3	Extreme	Usually requires a strong sapper, proper equipment, and cooperation; breach a reinforced position under fire
4+	Operation	Cannot normally be overcome in one unsupported roll; requires preparation, several sappers, or progress across earlier runs

Because only sixes count, each increase in Resistance is substantial. Do not use Resistance 2 for routine professional work or Resistance 3 merely because something sounds difficult. Resistance 3 is a unit problem.

Resistance 0: Safe Analysis

A Resistance 0 check automatically succeeds and never causes retaliation. Build and roll the normal dice pool. The sapper receives the basic result they attempted even if no 6s are rolled. Each success rolled provides one additional useful detail, option, or resource appropriate to the approach.

Use Resistance 0 when the uncertainty is **how much the sapper learns or finds**, not whether they can act safely. A sapper studying visible ground might automatically identify the obvious wire and mine craters; successes could reveal a firing lane, a covered approach, recent footprints, or the tool most likely to open a route.

Do not require a Resistance 0 check merely to make the players notice information needed to understand the scene. State essential facts freely. Do not use Resistance 0 while the sapper is exposed to immediate danger, racing a threat, reaching into a possible trap, or searching where discovery carries a consequence; those are Resistance 1 or higher. Resolve one Resistance 0 check for each distinct question or search area rather than allowing every sapper to repeat the same search for more successes.

The referee tells the players the Resistance before they commit to an action whenever the danger would be apparent to their sappers. Hidden threats may conceal their Resistance until discovered.

If the roll meets or exceeds the Resistance, the sapper accomplishes what they attempted. Extra successes do not normally create a greater effect unless a rule or piece of equipment says otherwise.

Outside combat, if a Resistance 1 or higher roll fails, the enemy or battlefield immediately retaliates. During combat, the enemy acts on its normal turn unless a specific rule calls for an additional retaliation. The action does not succeed, and the referee introduces a consequence that follows from the danger: incoming fire, a mine detonation, an alerted patrol, lost equipment, collapsing cover, or another lethal development. Resistance 0 checks cannot fail and never retaliate.

Retaliation may threaten the acting sapper, another exposed sapper, or the entire unit. The fiction determines who is in danger.

Bought Knowledge

Every failed Resistance 1 or higher check outside combat leaves the unit one useful truth about the battlefield. Resolve the retaliation first, then reveal something the failure exposed: a danger's position, trigger, coverage, timing, supporting force, vulnerable part, safer route, needed tool, or another possible approach. Mark it on the shared map.

Bought Knowledge does not make the attempted action succeed and never cancels its retaliation. It reveals the next decision rather than the complete solution. A mine may detonate and expose the edge of its field; a machine gun may fire and reveal its lane; a failed breach may show hollow earth beneath the bunker without opening it.

After resolving the consequence, the referee may ask the acting player, **“What did your sapper understand a moment too late?”** The player proposes an observation and the referee turns it into one concrete fact consistent with the prepared battlefield. The referee may supply the fact directly when the answer is already established or when a player would prefer not to invent it.

During combat, a failed attack or check does not create an extra immediate retaliation unless the action, item, hazard, or operation explicitly says it does. The action still fails, and the enemy acts on its normal turn. This prevents one failed action from giving the enemy both an interruption and its full turn.

Working Together

Two or more sappers may work together when they can meaningfully contribute to the same action. Choose one sapper to lead. The leader builds the normal pool from skill, one relevant item, and other modifiers. Every helper must have at least one checked rank in the required skill and adds only those skill dice. The one-die untrained fallback does not qualify a helper. Helpers do not add equipment or other modifiers.

Roll all contributed dice together and compare the combined successes to the task's Resistance. One item cannot benefit several participants in the same check.

Cooperation commits everyone involved. If the check fails, every participating sapper is exposed to the resulting retaliation when the fiction allows it.

During combat, leading or helping with a cooperative check consumes that sapper's action for the turn. A helper cannot contribute skill dice and then take another action in the same sapper turn.

Resistance 2 example: A mine-clearer leads with Engineering and a mine detector while another trained sapper adds only their checked Engineering ranks to hold exposed wiring steady.

Resistance 3 example: A demolitionist leads a breach with Demolitions and shaped charges while two trained sappers contribute their Demolitions skill dice to brace the charge and identify the bunker supports.

Operation-Level Resistance

Resistance 4 or higher represents a problem that cannot normally be solved by accumulating successes on repeated rolls. Discoveries, sabotage, equipment, and completed sub-objectives reduce its Resistance or remove a prerequisite before the decisive check.

For example, a bunker begins at Resistance 4 and cannot be breached directly. Cutting its reinforcement tunnel reduces it to 3; detonating its ammunition cache reduces it to 2. Failed preparation checks still provoke retaliation, but another route or later run remains possible.

When one tool or non-combat action tries to affect several targets or a much larger area, the referee may increase its Resistance when the wider effect is genuinely harder. Do not increase Resistance merely because several people benefit from one successful action.

Continue: Combat and Movement covers wounds, turns, movement, attacks, and revival under fire.

Combat and Movement

Use [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) for dice pools, Resistance, safe analysis, cooperation, and Bought Knowledge. This chapter applies those checks when time and position matter.

Wounds

[Humanity](#) determines how many **Wound boxes** a sapper has: none above 75 Humanity, one at 75, and two at 25. When an attack meets the sapper's Defense, it inflicts a lethal hit. If the sapper has an empty Wound box, mark it and the sapper becomes Wounded. If no empty box remains, the sapper becomes **Dying**.

A Dying sapper is down but not out. They remain where they fell. On their next sapper turn, they may take one **Last Action**, applying all penalties from marked Wound boxes, and then die immediately. The Last Action may be any action that can be completed at once, but it cannot begin field revival. A Dying sapper cannot be treated or returned to ordinary Wounded status. Another lethal hit or an effect that explicitly kills them ends them immediately, before their Last Action.

If a sapper becomes Dying during the sapper turn, their Last Action occurs on the following round's sapper turn. If they become Dying during the enemy turn, it occurs on the immediately following sapper turn. Becoming Dying while resolving an action does not grant a second action in the same turn.

Non-combat retaliation may also mark a Wound box. If the sapper has no empty box, the retaliation leaves them Dying unless it explicitly says they are killed.

Every marked Wound box removes 1 die from every check and attack. Dice pools cannot be reduced below one die from wounds. Treatment clears one marked box. Reconstruction clears every marked box, but never gives more boxes than current Humanity allows.

Rules use two distinct terms:

- A **lethal hit** marks an empty Wound box; when none remains, it leaves the sapper Dying.
- An effect that says a sapper is **killed** causes immediate death, bypassing Wound boxes and the Last Action. Whether the remains can be revived depends on the effect; being killed does not by itself mean permanent destruction.

TELEGRAPH CERTAIN DEATH The referee should make an obvious killing danger clear before it is resolved. Do not replace ordinary attacks with automatic killing effects.

Conditions

- **Exposed:** Visible and reachable by the current attack or danger. Cover matters by preventing exposure, not by raising Defense.
- **Wounded:** Alive with one or more marked Wound boxes. Each marked box removes 1 die from checks and attacks.
- **Dying:** Out of ordinary action after suffering a lethal hit with no empty Wound box. The sapper receives one Last Action on their next turn, then dies.
- **Fallen:** Dead, present on the battlefield, and potentially recoverable.
- **Destroyed:** Dead with too little intact material for immediate revival. Recovery requires whatever remains or a specific fictional solution.
- **Captured:** Held or carried away by the enemy. The enemy normally studies only sappers at 25 Humanity or less, visibly extensive reconstructions, or bearers of level 3 equipment. A captured Battleborn marks every remaining Burn box and draws an anti-Battleborn section, but may still be rescued before incineration is completed.
- **Surprised:** Unaware when combat begins. Defense is reduced by 1, to a minimum of 1, through the first round.
- **Permanently dead:** Unable to return because the body is unrecoverable, completely incinerated, transported beyond rescue, or affected by a rule that explicitly prevents reconstruction. A third marked Burn box makes a Battleborn Burn-Listed but does not destroy it by itself.

Resolution Order

When several effects follow one roll, resolve them in this order:

1. Determine success or failure, including any allowed reroll.
2. Apply the action's effect on a success or the primary retaliation on a failure.
3. Resolve attacks, marked Wound boxes, Dying, or explicit killing.
4. Damage, destroy, or separate equipment when the consequence calls for it.
5. Apply Humanity loss and immediately resolve any threshold crossed.
6. Update positions, bodies, hazards, and discoveries on the map, including Bought Knowledge after a failed non-combat check.

One failed check outside combat normally creates one primary retaliation and one instance of Bought Knowledge. An item or named hazard may add its stated consequence, but failure is not permission to pile on unrelated punishments. During combat, the enemy turn is the retaliation and Bought Knowledge is granted only when a specific rule says so. A successful check accomplishes its declared purpose before any stated cost is applied.

Combat

Combat is divided into rounds. Each round has two turns:

1. **Sapper Turn:** Every living sapper may act once, in any order the players choose.
2. **Enemy Turn:** Every formation, independent enemy, and monster may act once, in any order chosen by the referee.

After the enemy turn, begin a new round. Continue until one side is dead, retreats, surrenders, or is otherwise unable to fight.

Failed attacks and checks do not cause an additional immediate retaliation during combat unless a specific rule says otherwise. Once combat begins, the enemy turn is the retaliation. Enemies act every round whether the sappers' actions succeed or fail.

Surprise

If combat begins before one side detects the other, the unaware side is **Surprised** for the first round. A Surprised combatant has -1 Defense, to a minimum of Defense 1, until the end of that round. The Surprised side still acts on its normal turn. Once any member of a formation detects the attack, the whole formation is no longer Surprised after the first round.

Concealment, a silent approach, a prepared ambush, or a scenario rule may create Surprise. Merely acting first does not. State who is Surprised before the first attack is rolled.

Position and Range

Combat uses squares on the operation map or a quickly sketched local map. Count each orthogonal or diagonal step as one square; movement cannot cut diagonally through a solid corner. Occupants of the same square are within Melee range. Distance is divided into three practical ranges:

- **Melee:** An adjacent square.
- **Close:** From 2 to 6 squares away, suited to pistols, shotguns, thrown weapons, and other short-ranged attacks.
- **Far:** 7 or more squares away, suited to rifles, machine guns, and other long-ranged attacks.

Partial cover does not increase Defense against direct attacks; it changes whether the target can be seen and exposed. Complete cover prevents the attack entirely. Substantial shelter such as a bunker, deep crater, or burnt-out tank may also protect a sapper from mortar and artillery retaliation when the fiction supports it.

A target that cannot be seen cannot be attacked. Smoke, darkness, solid barriers, and terrain can therefore prevent an attack without increasing Defense. A successful Awareness check may reveal a concealed target until it moves or concealment changes.

Movement

Every sapper has a **Mobility** skill. When a sapper uses their action to move, they may cross a number of squares equal to:

■ *2 + checked Mobility ranks, to a maximum of 12 squares*

A sapper with Mobility 0 moves 2 squares. A sapper with Mobility 3 moves 5 squares.

Use exact movement only during combat, pursuit, timed danger, or another scene where each square changes who is exposed. During ordinary exploration, move between meaningful locations on the operation map and roll only when crossing danger. Familiar safe ground may be crossed without counting squares or making checks.

Crossing mines, wire, unstable earth, open firing lanes, or other dangerous ground may require a skill check. Failure triggers retaliation as normal.

Sapper Actions

On the sapper turn, each sapper may perform one significant action. Common actions include:

- Attack with a ranged or close-quarters weapon
- Move to a new position
- Use a tool or piece of equipment
- Attempt a battlefield task
- Help another sapper
- Begin reviving a fallen sapper
- Retreat toward safety

Simple movement or handling that does not expose the sapper to danger may be included with another action at the referee's discretion. Crossing exposed ground, climbing through wire, or moving under fire requires the sapper's action and may require a skill check.

Attacking

To attack, build a dice pool using the relevant combat skill and weapon:

■ *Combat skill + weapon rating + other modifiers*

Roll the pool and count successes. If the number of successes equals or exceeds the target's **Defense**, the attack inflicts a lethal hit. A target with an empty Wound box marks it and becomes Wounded. A sapper without an empty Wound box becomes Dying. Most ordinary enemies have no Wound boxes and are killed immediately.

An attack normally selects one target. When a weapon, hazard, or operation explicitly allows one attack to threaten several targets, make one attack roll and compare its successes separately with each target's Defense. Apply one lethal hit to every target whose Defense is met. Effects that automatically mark a Wound box or kill say so explicitly and require no attack roll.

Weapons are designed for a particular range. A weapon adds its equipment rating to the attack only when the target is within that weapon's listed range. At another range, the sapper rolls only their combat skill and other applicable modifiers. A level 2 rifle, for example, adds two dice against a target at Far range but adds no weapon dice against a target at Close range. An attack must still be physically possible: range bonuses do not let a blade strike a distant target or a thrown weapon reach beyond the sapper's throwing distance. Use Ranged to fire a weapon, even at Melee range, and Close Quarters to strike with it.

Defense is the combat counterpart to Resistance. It represents armor, unnatural durability, and the difficulty of landing a lethal blow. An unarmored human has Defense 1.

Every sapper begins at Defense 1 in issued protection. At 75 Humanity they gain a Wound box but remain Defense 1; below 75 Humanity, accumulated reconstruction raises their base Defense to 2. Improved armor sets a minimum

Defense rather than adding to the body's rating. Only equipment and effects that explicitly name Defense can raise it further.

Revival Under Fire

Field revival takes a sapper's full turn and leaves them exposed. Choose one fallen sapper in the same square or an adjacent square. Enough of the body must remain to identify and rebuild the sapper. Nearby donor material is assumed unless the fiction has explicitly removed or destroyed it. Field revival requires no roll. The reviving sapper can do nothing else that turn. The enemy then receives its full turn, giving it an opportunity to attack the survivor, seize the body, or force the unit away.

If the reviving sapper remains beside the body through the enemy turn, the fallen sapper returns at the beginning of the next sapper turn. If the reviver is killed or forced away, the revival fails and must be started again. Becoming Dying does not interrupt a revival already underway: it completes at the beginning of the next sapper turn, before the reviver's Last Action. Each fallen sapper must be revived separately.

A field-revived sapper returns with every Wound box cleared and may act normally on the turn in which they return. Choose the replacement from the fatal injury and available donor material. Apply the full Humanity loss, including 2 extra for Black Matter, and every threshold crossed immediately. Any Wound box gained by crossing a threshold begins empty. Record a short note and 2 ranks owed, or 3 if Black Matter is used. Use fallback dice only when the scene and a quick choice cannot settle a detail. Drawings, optional memories, and skill allocation can wait until between runs. Equipment still present on the body remains with its bearer.

The detailed timing and requirements for completing a field revival are covered in [Death and Revival](#).

Enemy Actions and Formations

Ordinary enemy soldiers act in **formations** rather than taking separate turns. A formation contains two to six similar soldiers in the same area. It moves together and performs one action on the enemy turn. Named enemies, Sergeants, Battleborn, monsters, and soldiers separated from their formation act individually.

When a formation attacks, use the lead soldier's listed attack pool and add 1 die for every additional soldier contributing, to a maximum of +3 dice. The formation attacks one target unless a weapon or rule explicitly threatens several. Every killed or separated soldier immediately reduces the formation's possible bonus.

Enemy attacks follow the same rule as sapper attacks. If the enemy meets or exceeds Defense, it inflicts a lethal hit. The sapper marks an empty Wound box and becomes Wounded, or becomes Dying if no empty box remains.

Formations keep ordinary firefights fast while making groups more dangerous than individuals. Split a formation only when its members take genuinely different positions or objectives.

Enemies should act according to their training, fear, and objectives. They may concentrate fire, retreat to fortified positions, attempt to capture bodies, or call for artillery rather than merely attacking the nearest sapper.

Hesitation

The battlefield does not pause while the players debate. When discussion begins to drag, the referee describes an approaching threat and asks the unit for an immediate decision. If the players still hesitate, the threat occurs as retaliation without requiring a failed check.

This pressure should force decisions, not punish reasonable questions or prevent players from understanding the scene. Make the danger clear before it strikes.

Retreat and Pursuit

Retreat is an action when exact movement matters. Combat ends when every surviving sapper reaches a known route, shelter, map edge, or other position from which the enemy cannot immediately attack them. If the enemy can pursue, continue exact movement or let the withdrawing unit attempt one appropriate cooperative check against a Resistance

set by the pursuers and terrain. Success ends the pursuit. Failure changes position or costs something and the enemy acts on its normal turn; it does not create an extra combat retaliation unless a specific danger says otherwise.

Continue: Equipment gives those actions tools, weapons, and supplies.

Equipment

Choose starting gear during [Character Creation](#). Equipment contributes to the dice pools and attacks described in [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) and [Combat and Movement](#).

Equipment is issued between runs according to rank. Privates may choose level 1 equipment, Corporals may choose levels 1–2, and Sergeants may choose levels 1–3.

Level 1 equipment resembles the weapons and tools carried during the early years of the Great War. Level 2 equipment reflects thirty-seven years of uninterrupted industrial warfare. Level 3 equipment incorporates the discoveries of Project Eisenseele: bone, preserved nerves, donor organs, and materials that are not entirely dead.

Equipment Rules

- Each item normally occupies one equipment slot.
- An item adds dice equal to its level when used for its listed skill or purpose.
- A weapon adds its dice only when attacking at its listed range.
- Firearm ammunition is not tracked. Sappers rarely live long enough to exhaust a proper combat load.
- Tools are reusable unless retaliation destroys or takes them.
- One slot of grenades or other small consumables contains three uses. Mark off one circle after each use: ○ ○ ○.
- Armor replaces issued armor rather than stacking with it.
- Unless an item says otherwise, it follows the normal rules in [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) and [Combat and Movement](#).

Issuing and Handling Items

Every item is issued to one sapper during outfitting. Only that bearer receives its dice, uses, armor, or special effect during the run. Another sapper may pick it up, carry it, hide it, or return it to the trench, but cannot gain its mechanical benefit until it is formally reissued between runs. Passing or picking up an item during combat is an action unless it is already in the same square and the referee rules that no immediate danger interferes.

Only one item may reduce the Humanity cost of a revival; use the largest reduction. These reductions never remove the additional Black Matter cost.

The leader of a cooperative check may use one relevant item. Helpers contribute only skill dice; their equipment does not add to the group pool.

Level 1 gear is replaced freely. Level 2 gear is scarce. Level 3 gear is classified as a strategic organism or weapon and command values its recovery above the life or body of its bearer. If a sapper and a level 3 item cannot both be recovered, official orders require the item. Leaving it behind should change enemy behavior and usually makes its recovery an immediate objective.

Per-run abilities refresh automatically when a new run begins. Consumable circles do not all refresh automatically: level 1 consumables are refilled freely during outfitting; level 2 consumables are refilled only when command can replace or service the item; level 3 consumables follow the mission's prepared supply and the demands of their handler. The referee states the available supply before equipment is chosen.

Level 3 equipment does not cost Humanity merely because it is grotesque. Humanity is lost only when an item's rule explicitly states a cost or when using it causes another listed Humanity-loss event. Description creates horror; explicit rules create loss.

Issued Equipment

These items are given to every sapper and do not consume equipment slots.

Item	Effect
Steel helmet and quilted armor	Issued protection. It is already included in the sapper's starting Defense 1 and occupies no slot.
Respirator	Allows the sapper to attempt Mobility checks against ordinary battlefield gas. It provides no bonus dice.
Map case and grease pencil	Used to record discoveries on the unit's shared map.

Level 1 Equipment

Level 1 equipment is dependable, replaceable, and recognizable to soldiers from the war's first years.

Level 1 Weapons

Item	Skill	Range	Effect
Trench knife	Close Quarters	Melee	Adds 1 die to attacks.
Entrenching tool	Close Quarters	Melee	Adds 1 die to attacks. It may instead add 1 die to Strength when digging or forcing earth.
Service revolver	Ranged	Close	Adds 1 die to attacks.
Trench shotgun	Ranged	Close	Adds 1 die to attacks.
Bolt-action rifle	Ranged	Far	Adds 1 die to attacks.

Level 1 Tools

Item	Skill	Effect
Mine probe and marking flags	Engineering	Adds 1 die when locating, marking, or neutralizing mines.
Wire cutters	Engineering	Adds 1 die when cutting wire, fencing, or light metal obstacles.
Field glasses	Awareness	Adds 1 die when observing Far areas from a stable position.
Camouflage sheet	Stealth	Adds 1 die when hiding a stationary sapper, body, or small cache.
Rope and climbing hooks	Strength	Adds 1 die when climbing, hauling, or lowering bodies and equipment.
Trapmaker's roll	Engineering	Adds 1 die when constructing or concealing a trap.

Level 1 Explosives and Supplies

Item	Skill	Range	Uses	Effect
Fragmentation grenades	Ranged	Close	3	Adds 1 die to an attack. Affected targets standing together may each be threatened by the same blast at the referee's discretion.
Smoke grenades	Ranged	Close	3	Adds 1 die when placing

Item	Skill	Range	Uses	Effect
				smoke accurately. A target hidden by smoke cannot be attacked until revealed by Awareness.
Satchel charges	Demolitions	Melee	3	Adds 1 die when destroying structures, equipment, or fortifications. Must be placed by hand.
Bangalore section	Demolitions	Melee	1	Adds 1 die when clearing wire, mines, or a narrow path through an obstacle. On success, the cleared path remains marked on the map.
Tripwire mines	Engineering	Placed	3	Adds 1 die when placing or concealing a mine. Once placed, it makes a 4-dice attack against the first suitable target to trigger it.
Field dressings	Mobility	Self or adjacent	3	Spend an action and pass a Resistance 1 Mobility check to clear one marked Wound box. A use is consumed whether treatment succeeds or fails. Failure follows normal retaliation rules; it does not cause an extra retaliation during combat.
Dog Food	Ranged or Stealth	Placed or Close	3	Can be hidden or thrown to attract animals that would be drawn to the foul stench within.

Level 2 Equipment

Level 2 equipment is expensive machinery produced by a civilization that has forgotten how to manufacture for peace.

Level 2 Weapons

Item	Skill	Range	Effect
Machine pistol	Ranged	Close	Adds 2 dice to attacks.
Automatic trench gun	Ranged	Close	Adds 2 dice to attacks.
Marksman's rifle	Ranged	Far	The Marksman's rifle is equipped with a bayonet. Adds 2 dice to attacks either at far range, or in melee range.
Pneumatic pile-driver	Close Quarters	Melee	Adds 2 dice to attacks and to Strength checks made to breach doors or light barriers.
Man-portable flamethrower	Ranged	Close	Adds 2 dice to attacks. A target killed by it, including one who

Item	Skill	Range	Effect
			dies after a Last Action caused by its hit, cannot be revived unless enough unburned material can be recovered. The fuel apparatus occupies a second equipment slot.
Smoke Launcher	Ranged	Far	Three uses. Spend an action and one use to place smoke in a visible 4-by-4-square area at Far range. Roll Ranged + 1 die against Resistance 1; this is an exception to the usual level 2 bonus. Success blocks sight through the area until the end of the fifth sapper turn, counting the current sapper turn as the first, or the next sapper turn if used outside combat. Wind or ventilation may clear it sooner. Failure places no useful smoke and follows normal retaliation rules. This is a placement check, not a damaging attack.

Level 2 Tools

Item	Skill	Effect
Induction mine detector	Awareness or Engineering	Adds 2 dice when locating or neutralizing metallic mines and buried mechanisms.
Motorized wire saw	Engineering	Adds 2 dice when cutting metal, armor plate, or reinforced obstacles. Its noise may reveal the unit even on a success.
Sound-ranging headset	Awareness	Adds 2 dice when locating artillery, engines, tunneling, or movement through obscured ground.
Reactive camouflage mantle	Stealth	Adds 2 dice while moving slowly or remaining still.
Powered breaching frame	Strength	Adds 2 dice when lifting, breaking, or forcing. The wearer cannot be moved by ordinary environmental retaliation while braced.
Mechanical revival frame	Special	While its bearer is braced beside the body during field revival, ordinary environmental retaliation cannot force the bearer away. Enemy attacks and deliberate forced movement can still interrupt the attempt. Revival takes the normal full turn; choose the replacement from the injury and available material.

Level 2 Explosives and Armor

Item	Skill	Range	Uses	Effect
Shaped charges	Demolitions	Melee	3	Adds 2 dice against armor, bunkers, engines, and reinforced structures.

Item	Skill	Range	Uses	Effect
Incendiary bombs	Ranged	Close	3	Adds 2 dice to attacks. Bodies destroyed by the fire cannot be revived without recoverable remains.
Concussion mines	Engineering	Placed	3	Adds 2 dice when placing the mine. Once placed, it makes a 7-dice attack against the first suitable target to trigger it.
Composite trench armor	—	Worn	—	Sets the wearer's Defense to at least 2. Replaces issued armor and occupies one slot.
Artillery radio	Ranged	Far	1	Spend one use outside combat to call an immediate strike on one visible square at Far range. Roll Ranged + 6 dice once against the Defense of every exposed combatant in that square, including allies; each target whose Defense is met suffers one lethal hit. This attack does not automatically destroy bodies, equipment, or fortifications. It may start combat, but cannot be called once combat has begun.

Level 3 Equipment

Level 3 equipment is never truly issued. It is introduced to its new bearer by a Butcher, handler, or chaplain. Most pieces must be fed, grafted, calmed, or reminded which side they serve.

Level 3 Weapons

Item	Skill	Range	Effect
Marrow rifle	Ranged	Far	Adds 3 dice to attacks. The stock tightens around the shooter's replacement parts; after it kills, the sapper may immediately move 2 squares toward the body.
Sinew repeater	Ranged	Close	Adds 3 dice to attacks. Once per sapper turn, if the attack kills, the weapon may lash at a second target in Close range using only its 3 equipment dice.
Ossuary cleaver	Close Quarters	Melee	Adds 3 dice to attacks. After killing at Melee range, the cleaver roots into the body; the wielder immediately learns whether it carries usable

Item	Skill	Range	Effect
			human, animal, enemy, or Black Matter material.
Choir gun	Ranged	Far	Adds 3 dice to attacks. Its preserved throats scream the instant they sense a visible target at Far range; its bearer does not suffer the –1 Defense from Surprise against that enemy during the first round. The weapon always reveals the unit's position when fired.
Burnt Bolt	Ranged	Far	Adds 3 dice to attacks. Its toothy maw barks with a harsh report. A successful shot at an exposed flammable or explosive object ignites it; worn or carried objects cannot be ignited with this effect. Use the normal task or stationary-defense rules for machinery and structures; the weapon grants no additional damage or automatic breach.
Bone Shredder	Ranged or Close Quarters	Close/Melee	Adds 3 dice to attacks. Its fragmented, bony frame shudders with each shot, spraying bone chips. Use Ranged at Close range or Close Quarters at Melee range. A Melee attack may threaten every visible combatant, including allies, in two squares that are adjacent to each other and to the wielder. Roll once and compare the successes with each target's Defense.

Level 3 Tools

Item	Skill	Effect
Seer's cluster	Awareness	Adds 3 dice. A jar of linked eyes can look around corners and through smoke, but it also shows the sapper brief images of the other side. After a failed check with this item, lose 1 Humanity, subject to the normal one-incidental-loss-per-run limit.
Parasite shroud	Stealth	Adds 3 dice. Once per run, when a Stealth check fails, the shroud may tear away a layer of the wearer's skin to turn the failure into a success; mark an empty Wound box; if none is empty, the wearer becomes Dying.
Tendon winch	Strength	Adds 3 dice. The grafted cable may pull a sapper or body up to the user's full movement instead of the user moving.
Listening root	Awareness	Adds 3 dice when pressed into earth, wood, or flesh. On a success,

Item	Skill	Effect
		it also reveals whether something living has crossed or touched the surface recently.
Black-vein infiltrator	Engineering	Adds 3 dice. The organism crawls inside a machine and learns its shape; after a successful sabotage, it can restore the machine to working order once for Allied use.
Lazarus satchel	Special	When its bearer performs a field revival, reduce the normal Humanity loss by 2. Any Black Matter replacement still adds its full 2 Humanity cost. The satchel whispers with the voices of those repaired by it; these are optional roleplay prompts.

Level 3 Explosives and Armor

Item	Skill	Range	Uses	Effect
Blackblood charges	Demolitions	Melee	3	Adds 3 dice. The charge grows tendrils through cracks before detonating, allowing it to attack internal supports or machinery without first breaching the exterior.
Boneburst grenades	Ranged	Close	3	Adds 3 dice to attacks. On a success, the blast leaves a field of growing splinters that becomes dangerous ground.
Crawling mines	Engineering	Placed	3	Adds 3 dice when deployed and make a 10-dice attack when detonated. After being placed, one may move 2 squares at the beginning of each sapper turn until ordered to wait or detonate. Crawling Mines have defense 1 when targeted.
Ossuary harness	—	Worn	—	Sets the wearer's Defense to at least 3. Once per run, it may prevent one non-combat Wound box from being marked; afterward its bone plates remain open and loudly grind until the unit returns to the trench. Replaces issued armor.

Losing Equipment

Retaliation may damage, destroy, bury, or separate a sapper from equipment when that consequence follows from the action. Equipment lost in no-man's-land remains where it fell and may be marked on the shared map. If recovered during a later run, it can be used normally unless the referee has established that it was destroyed.

The Allied trench replaces level 1 equipment freely between runs. Level 2 items are scarce and may not be immediately replaced. A lost level 3 item outranks personnel recovery: command demands its return, and the enemy treats its capture as a major victory. Mark every lost item on the shared map.

Recovered equipment returns to its assigned bearer if that sapper is present. Another sapper may carry it, but gains no mechanical benefit until it is formally reissued during outfitting. Recovery does not refill spent consumable uses unless the appropriate supply is available.

Continue: Death and Revival explains recovery when those tools are not enough; Humanity and Battleborn tracks its lasting cost.

Death and Revival

See [Combat and Movement](#) for lethal hits, Wounds, and Dying, and [Replacements and Memories](#) for choosing replacement parts, donors, and optional roleplay prompts.

For a sapper, death is not the end of service. Bodies can be recovered, repaired, and sent back across no-man's-land. Something is lost during every death, however, and no reconstruction returns exactly the person who fell. Track that loss in [Humanity and Battleborn](#).

Death and Wounds

Combat is lethal, but repeated reconstruction teaches a body to remain alive after wounds that should kill it. When an attack meets a sapper's Defense, it inflicts a **lethal hit**. Mark an empty Wound box and become Wounded. If no empty box remains, the sapper becomes **Dying** instead.

A Dying sapper remains alive until their next sapper turn. They take one Last Action with every penalty from marked Wound boxes, then die. They cannot be treated out of this state or begin a field revival. Another lethal hit or an effect that explicitly kills them ends them immediately.

Non-combat retaliation may instead leave a sapper **Wounded** when immediate death does not fit the danger. Wounds represent injuries that remain survivable only because the sapper is still moving: shattered bones, torn muscle, burns, embedded shrapnel, damaged organs, or similar trauma.

A wounded sapper is alive and may continue the run, but every marked Wound box reduces their checks and attacks by 1 die. Environmental retaliation can also mark a Wound box. If there is no empty box when an effect would mark one, the sapper becomes Dying unless the effect explicitly kills them. Treatment can clear marked boxes but cannot give a sapper more boxes than their current Humanity allows. The exact effects and condition definitions are covered in [Combat and Movement](#).

Tracking Wounds at the Table

The printed Wound spaces show **capacity**, not permanent injuries: none at 100–76 Humanity, one at 75–26, and two at 25–0. Label two spots on the edge of the character sheet **Wound 1** and **Wound 2**. Put a red paper clip at an available spot whenever a Wound box is marked; each clip is one current wound and costs 1 die. Remove a clip when treatment clears that wound or when revival clears all Wound boxes. Do not write on or erase the printed Wound spaces to track temporary wounds. A printed space that the sapper has not yet gained from Humanity cannot absorb a hit.

Field Revival

If at least one member of the unit survives a fight or disaster, the survivors may revive their fallen comrades in the field. They stitch together damaged bodies with nearby remains, spare parts, and whatever equipment they carried into no-man's-land.

Enough of the body must remain to identify and rebuild the sapper. The reviver must be in the same or an adjacent square. Nearby donor material is assumed unless the fiction has explicitly removed or destroyed it. Revival requires no check.

Reviving one body takes the sapper's full turn. The reviver must remain beside the fallen sapper through the following enemy turn and can do nothing else. If the reviver survives and is not forced away, the fallen sapper returns at the beginning of the next sapper turn. Becoming Dying does not interrupt a revival already underway: it completes before the reviver's Last Action on the next sapper turn. Every fallen sapper requires a separate revival.

The revived sapper returns with every Wound box cleared. They may act normally during the sapper turn in which they return. Choose the replacement part from the fatal injury and its source from available material. Apply the full Humanity loss, including 2 extra for Black Matter, and every threshold crossed immediately; a Wound box gained at a new threshold begins empty. Note those two details and the ranks owed; drawings, skill allocation, and optional donor memories can wait until between runs. Equipment still present on the body remains with its bearer.

A field-revived sapper:

- Returns during the current run.
- Loses 1d6 + 2 Humanity.
- Uses the fatal injury to choose the replacement part and available material to choose its donor. Use the [fallback tables](#) only when neither the scene nor a quick choice supplies an answer.
- Gains 2 skill ranks total to assign before the next run, or 3 total if Black Matter is used.
- Loses 2 additional Humanity if Black Matter is used: 1d6 + 4 total. This is part of the revival cost, outside the incidental-loss limit.

Field revival costs less Humanity than reconstruction by the Butchers. The sapper spends less time dead, less time witnessing the other side, and less time forgetting the person they were before death. The price is an improvised body assembled under fire.

A replacement may bring a donor memory or habit. These are optional roleplay aids, with no bonuses, penalties, forced actions, or Humanity costs. Offer a brief detail when it fits; do not stop combat to invent one. See [Borrowed Memories](#).

Recovery by the Butchers

If nobody remains to recover and revive the unit, [corpse hounds](#) or another sapper detail eventually bring the bodies back to the Allied trench. There, the [The Butchers](#) reconstruct the fallen with proper tools and the best available parts.



A corpse hound and its handler ready for a recovery mission

A sapper revived by the Butchers:

- Returns before the next run.
- Loses $2d6 + 2$ Humanity.
- Uses the fatal injury to choose the replacement part and workshop stock to choose its donor. Roll only if neither supplies an answer and the table cannot make a quick choice.
- Gains 2 skill ranks total to assign before the next run, or 3 total if Black Matter is used.
- Loses 2 additional Humanity if Black Matter is used: $2d6 + 4$ total. This is part of the revival cost, outside the incidental-loss limit.

The Butchers produce cleaner joins, but the longer death takes a greater portion of the sapper's Humanity. They use the same replacement and rank rules as field revival. Keep the workshop procedure below brief.

The Butcher's Procedure

Resolve the mechanics first. One brief image can establish the workshop; a longer memory scene is optional.

1. Name the part ruined by the fatal injury and choose a donor from workshop stock. Use fallback dice only for a detail the scene and a quick choice cannot settle.
2. Apply 2d6 + 2 Humanity loss, or 2d6 + 4 with Black Matter. Resolve crossed thresholds, clear Wounds, and record 2 ranks, or 3 with Black Matter, for allocation before the next run.
3. Note the replacement. The player may answer **What do you still remember?** with one brief memory, or leave the scene there.

Keep this scene short. One sharp sensory detail and one damaged memory are more effective than a long surgical account. Players may draw a veil over specific imagery while still applying every mechanical and character-sheet consequence.

Death Under Orders

The body learns only from a death suffered while pursuing the operation under genuine threat. A death deliberately arranged to obtain replacement material or skill ranks grants **no skill ranks, including no Black Matter bonus**. Execution by an ally, controlled self-destruction, and a revival staged safely behind the line are not training.

REFEREE JUDGMENT: STAGED DEATH The revival, replacement, and full Humanity loss, including any Black Matter cost, still occur. Invoke this rule only when gaining ranks was plainly the purpose of the death. Desperate sacrifices, failed plans, and calculated battlefield risks remain legitimate service.

No Sapper Left Behind

The unit's objectives demand cohesion. Ordinary retreat does not include carrying fallen sappers back to the trench. Equipment and specific recovery actions may reposition bodies as described. Survivors must field-revive a fallen sapper before retreating together. A body left behind is abandoned and resolved after the run: Allied corpse hounds may recover it for Butcher reconstruction, the enemy may capture it, or an established battlefield threat may destroy or transform it.

Abandoning a recoverable Allied body costs Humanity as listed in [Losing Humanity in No-Man's-Land](#). The referee states the body's likely fate before the survivors commit to retreat whenever their sappers could judge it.

The enemy normally kills, burns, strips, or ignores human-looking prisoners. It attempts capture for study when a sapper has **25 Humanity or less**, visibly carries extensive reconstruction, or possesses a level 3 item. A mission may establish another specific reason for capture. Captured Battleborn suffer the [Burn rule](#).

Capture is not immediate permanent death. Whenever a rescue is still possible, mark the captive's location or likely route and give the unit a concrete chance to recover them during the current or next run. A captive remains that player's sapper while rescue is possible, though the player may temporarily portray an Allied recruit, corpse hound, or another willing player's intrusive memory. If the rescue window closes and the captive is destroyed, transported beyond the operation, or otherwise made unrecoverable, resolve permanent death.

Leaving a fallen or captured sapper behind should always be a last resort. The referee should show the cost, the likely enemy route, and at least one dangerous recovery opportunity when the fiction permits it. Recovery can become a sub-objective that competes with the primary mission rather than being erased between runs.

Permanent Death and Replacement Recruits

When one sapper dies permanently but the unit remains in the operation, that player may create a new Private at the next return to the Allied trench. The recruit begins with the normal starting profile and inherits the unit's shared map, but none of the dead sapper's Humanity, skill ranks, repairs, memories, military rank, or claim to scarce equipment.

A replacement recruit keeps the player in the operation without making permanent death cheap. The empty bunk, overwritten sheet, unrecovered body, and knowledge preserved on the map remain evidence of the sapper who was lost.

The operation ends when the unit completes its mission or every remaining sapper is permanently destroyed.

Continue: Humanity and Battleborn tracks what each return costs; Replacements and Memories supplies the physical results.

Humanity and Battleborn

Humanity measures what repeated reconstruction removes from a sapper. Use [Death and Revival](#) for recovery and revival timing, and [Replacements and Memories](#) for the body changes that follow.

Humanity

Humanity begins at 100 and is tracked separately for every sapper. It measures their connection to their memories, former identity, and life beyond the battlefield. It is also the clock counting down toward their final deployments.

Humanity cannot be restored. When Humanity loss would reduce it below 0, it stops at 0.

If one loss crosses several thresholds, resolve every crossed threshold in descending order and complete every required character-sheet alteration. Every eligible revival grants 2 skill ranks total, or 3 if Black Matter is used, divided among any skills. Check one box for each rank. See [Skill Ranks](#). No skill can have more than 12 checked boxes. Assign all new ranks during the next between-runs step; unassigned ranks cannot be saved beyond that step.

As a sapper crosses the following thresholds, they gain the listed changes. Humanity thresholds also determine military rank and equipment access as described in [Character Creation](#).

75 Humanity: Pain-Dead

The sapper gains **1 Wound box**. The first lethal hit or wound they suffer before that box is marked leaves them Wounded instead of Dying.

Using a dark marker, obscure the sapper's original identifying marks. Write or draw what the unit now uses to recognize them.

50 Humanity: Borrowed Reflex

Once per run, immediately after rolling their check or attack and before resolving its result, the sapper may reroll up to half the dice, rounding down. The new results replace the old results of those dice. This may be used on a successful roll, including a Resistance 0 check.

Using a dark marker, obscure one important word or name in the sapper's memory before the war. Replace it with a detail from a donor memory.

25 Humanity: Redundant Anatomy

The sapper gains a second **Wound box**. They can now endure two marked wounds; the next lethal hit or wound leaves them Dying.

Using a dark marker, obscure what the sapper swore must not be forgotten. Replace it with a short donor impulse, military order, or battlefield need.

0 Humanity: Battleborn

The sapper has forgotten their life before the battlefield. They remain under the control of their player and gain the following changes:

1. Unless completely unable to move, a Battleborn can crawl, scratch, or dig toward nearby remains and revive without help over three complete turns.
2. The Battleborn retains both Wound boxes, but can never clear its three Burn boxes.
3. Using a dark marker, obscure the sapper's name, date of birth, height, and weight. The other players give the Battleborn a battlefield name and write it over the old record.



An unknown Battleborn officer, taken before he was lost to the enemy.

Burn Boxes

Every Battleborn has three Burn boxes: ○ ○ ○.

Whenever a Battleborn dies, mark one Burn box. The Battleborn may revive normally after the first and second boxes are marked. When the third box is marked, the body is **Burn-Listed**. It may still begin revival, but the enemy immediately dispatches an anti-Battleborn section to identify, pin, and completely incinerate it.

A Burn-Listed sapper is not automatically destroyed. From that death onward, recovery becomes an urgent battlefield problem. The Referee marks the body's position and shows the approaching hunters through intercepted orders, phosphorus teams, corpse-recognition equipment, circling aircraft, or enemy movement toward the site. If the unit recovers and revives the sapper before the hunters finish their work, the Battleborn returns with all three boxes still marked. Every later death leaves it Burn-Listed again and draws another extermination response.

Anti-Battleborn sections do not arrive by magic and should not erase a rescue already in progress. They follow known routes, require time, and can be distracted, ambushed, or cut off. Their arrival turns every later death into a race over the body.

THE EDGE OF HUMANITY The death whose revival reduces a sapper to 0 Humanity does not mark a Burn box. The sapper died before they became Battleborn. Burn begins with deaths suffered after they awaken at 0 Humanity.

Unaided revival begins on a Battleborn's next sapper turn. Count that turn as the first of three; the Battleborn returns at the beginning of the fourth sapper turn with every Wound box cleared. Each turn should show the corpse rebuilding itself: fingers dragging loose meat closer, ribs levering the torso from the mud, teeth fastening tendons, and borrowed limbs remembering how to stand. The Battleborn cannot act before the revival is complete. Moving, scattering, immobilizing, or burning the remains interrupts the count. An ally may instead perform normal field revival. Unaided revival uses the normal field-revival consequences: choose the replacement from the injury and available material, record 2 ranks or 3 with Black Matter for assignment between runs, and clear all Wound boxes. Humanity remains at 0. Do not end the run solely because everyone is dead while a Battleborn can still attempt unaided revival.

Ordinary burning does not add Burn beyond the box marked for death unless an effect says it does. An effect that explicitly **completely incinerates** a body causes permanent destruction. If the enemy captures a helpless Battleborn, mark every remaining Burn box and dispatch an anti-Battleborn section. The captive remains recoverable until the section completes its incineration procedure.

Battleborn are still useful to the operation and often volunteer for its most dangerous work. Their power does not mark victory. It means that capture, defeat, and final death are now much closer.

Losing Humanity in No-Man's-Land

Death is the largest loss of Humanity, but it is not the only way the battlefield erodes a sapper. The following costs require no additional check:

Experience	Humanity Lost
Hear or see the other side clearly; touch an active Black Matter phenomenon	2
Commit or witness an act that deliberately destroys a person's identity	2
Pay an explicit Humanity cost listed by a level 3 living item	As listed
Remain conscious while the battlefield alters the sapper's body	1d6
Deliberately abandon an Allied body that could still be recovered	1d6
Witness an Allied sapper suffer permanent incineration	1d6
Be incorporated into, digested by, or revived from a battlefield monstrosity	1d6 + 2

Use these losses when the event truly occurs; do not charge Humanity merely for seeing something unpleasant. A sapper normally suffers only one incidental Humanity-loss event during a run. Optional donor memories never cause Humanity loss. Revival costs, including the additional 2 Humanity for a Black Matter replacement, and losses explicitly stated to ignore the limit still apply. Do not also charge incidental Black Matter contact for the same graft. Tell the player what slips away, then apply every crossed threshold immediately.

Continue: [Replacements and Memories](#) covers replacement choices and optional donor memories; [Quick Reference](#) summarizes the rules during play.

Replacements and Memories

Revival replaces the parts ruined by the fatal injury, using material the unit can actually recover. **Choose the body part from the fatal injury and the source from the available remains. Roll only when neither the scene nor a quick table decision can settle the missing detail.** See [Death and Revival](#) for revival timing and recovery.

Resolve a Replacement

1. **Name the damage.** Identify the part the fatal injury destroyed or made unusable.
2. **Name the donor.** Use suitable remains or supplies already present. The player chooses among available sources; the referee confirms what can be used.
3. **Pay and record.** Apply the normal revival Humanity loss, plus 2 if Black Matter replaces the part. Note the part, source, and ranks owed, clear Wounds, and resume play.

A short note is enough during danger: **“Right hand, corpse hound; 2 ranks.”** Finish the drawing and assign the ranks. A borrowed memory is optional and can be added later without delaying revival.

Skill Ranks

Every eligible revival grants **2 skill ranks total**, divided among any skills. If the replacement uses Black Matter, gain **1 additional rank, for 3 total**.

One revival grants one package of ranks, even if the injury requires rebuilding several parts or using several donors. Any Black Matter replacement makes that package 3 ranks; it never adds more than one bonus rank.

Assign ranks during the next between-runs step. Each rank checks one box; no skill may exceed 12 checked boxes. Choose other skills if needed, and discard ranks only if every skill is full. A death staged solely to gain ranks grants none, including no Black Matter bonus. All revival costs still apply.

Black Matter

Black Matter must be present in recoverable material, carried supplies, or an established workshop stock. Wanting its bonus does not make it available. Tell the player before they choose it: **3 ranks total and 2 extra Humanity lost**.

Add the 2 Humanity to that revival's cost before applying thresholds: **field revival costs 1d6 + 4; Butcher revival costs 2d6 + 4**. This extra loss applies every time Black Matter is used, outside the incidental Humanity-loss limit. Do not also charge the incidental Black Matter-contact cost for the same graft.

Trace Black Matter involved in ordinary reconstruction does not count. The bonus and extra loss apply only when Black Matter is used as the replacement material. Using several Black Matter parts in one revival still adds only 1 rank and 2 Humanity loss.

The Body

Let the death determine the replacement. A crushed hand needs a new hand; a shot through the chest needs new chest tissue or organs. Do not roll a leg merely because a table is available when the sapper died from a head wound.

For a blast, fire, drowning, or another death with several plausible injuries, briefly choose the damaged part that best fits what happened. Follow an established left or right injury; if the side is unknown, the player chooses. Internal damage can be recorded in the corresponding body zone.

Choose the source separately from the injury. A sapper killed by a wolf does not automatically receive wolf tissue unless the wolf's remains are available. A dead corpse hound beside the body, a fallen soldier, or a workshop's donor stock supplies an immediate answer.

Repair Table

These are **last-resort tables**, not a step in every revival. If the part is known, do not roll for it. If the source is known or the players can choose among usable donors, do not roll for it. Roll only the detail nobody can otherwise establish.

Fallback Body Parts

Roll one d6 only when the fatal injury and a quick choice leave the damaged part unresolved.

d6	Replaced part
1	Head or neck
2	Chest and abdomen, including internal organs
3	Right arm, upper or lower
4	Left arm, upper or lower
5	Right leg, upper or lower
6	Left leg, upper or lower

Fallback Sources

If ordinary donor material is assumed but nobody can identify it, roll one d6. This establishes what the reviver finds among otherwise unspecified remains.

d6	Source
1	Draft animal
2	Hunting or pack animal
3	Human, unknown
4	Human, Allied
5	Human, enemy or civilian
6	Black Matter, if its presence is plausible and has not been ruled out; otherwise human, unknown

A fallback result cannot create material the scene explicitly lacks. If no usable donor material remains, the unit must obtain it or recover the sapper for the Butchers; rolling cannot bypass that obstacle.

Recording the Body

Record the replaced zone, donor source, and one visible alteration. Use stitches, donor markings, mismatched proportions, fur, or Black Matter to show what changed. Detailed drawing can wait until between runs.

Keep the earlier alterations visible when a part is replaced again. If the body diagram fills, continue on the replacement record or a spare sheet. Recording a repair adds no separate bonus, penalty, or mandatory drawing procedure.

Repeated Replacement

A body zone may be replaced more than once. The new repair follows the new injury and available source. It grants the same 2 ranks, or 3 for Black Matter, as any other eligible revival.

For existing sappers, keep previously earned ranks and recorded alterations. Retire former adaptation bonuses and memory costs; do not recalculate ranks earned before this revision.

Borrowed Memories

A replacement may bring a smell, habit, image, or feeling from its donor. These are **optional roleplay aids**. The player may use, change, or ignore them. They never add dice, change Defense, clear wounds, force an action, erase a written memory, or cost Humanity.

The referee may offer a prompt when it fits a quiet moment. There are no triggers to track, no Active choices, and no required memory roll. Humanity thresholds still change the identity record as described in [Humanity and Battleborn](#); a roleplay prompt does not cause those changes.

Choose a detail from the donor, or use one of these twelve examples without rolling. Adapt any detail to suit the donor:

Source	Optional memory or habit
Draft animal	A warm palm resting between your eyes while someone loosens a muddy harness. You remember the touch, but not the face.
Draft animal	The sweet taste of an apple offered over a fence, and the sound of a child laughing when you take it.
Hunting or pack animal	Sleeping against the warm flank of another animal while rain drums on the kennel roof.
Hunting or pack animal	A two-note whistle across a field. You remember running toward it, certain someone would be waiting.
Human, unknown	A chipped blue cup on a kitchen table. You remember which way its handle faced, but nothing beyond the table.
Human, unknown	Someone braiding your hair before dawn. Their fingers pause whenever they laugh.
Human, Allied	Losing the same brass button in a card game three nights running. The winner always gave it back before inspection.
Human, Allied	A friend making up filthy words to a marching song. You remember the whole verse, but the friend's name is gone.
Human, enemy or civilian	Rocking a child to sleep with a lullaby in a language you cannot otherwise speak.
Human, enemy or civilian	Flour worked into the cracks of your hands, a hot oven at your back, and someone calling that the first customers have arrived.
Black Matter	Lying beneath the earth while roots grow through you. Whole seasons pass between the footsteps overhead.
Black Matter	Standing in a trench with no sky. Far away, someone calls your name in your own voice.

One brief detail is enough. A memory can return in conversation or color a decision without becoming another rule to resolve.

Example

A mine destroys Bell's left lower leg beside a dead corpse hound. The unit uses the hound's remains. No body-part or source roll is needed. Bell's field revival costs 1d6 + 2 Humanity, clears his Wounds, and grants 2 ranks to assign between runs. His player notes the graft and may later describe a remembered whistle.

If the only usable material is an established Black Matter seam, the same revival instead costs 1d6 + 4 Humanity and grants 3 ranks total. The injury still determines the replaced leg.

Continue: Use [Quick Reference](#) at the table, or [return to the reading routes](#).

THE REFEREE'S FILE

Referee Guide

RUN THE BATTLEFIELD, NOT AGAINST THE PLAYERS Present the battlefield honestly, keep it moving, and make every death teach the unit something. The referee is not trying to defeat the players. Give no-man's-land enough teeth that survival must be earned and enough consistency that knowledge can become a weapon.

Use [Referee Lore Guide](#) to reveal setting background through objects, repeated motifs, and consequences rather than exposition. The larger setting is indexed in [Entrenched](#).

The Sapper Unit

Entrenched is designed for **three to six sappers**. Three sappers create a desperate, fragile unit in which every death leaves the survivors exposed. Six give the unit more specialties and more hands for recovery, but allow the referee to use larger patrols, divided threats, and harder choices about who acts first.

Do not scale every danger directly to unit size. The Western Front is not a balanced contest. Instead, adjust how many problems overlap. A small unit might meet one patrol near a minefield; a large unit might face the patrol while artillery begins walking toward them. Run ordinary soldiers as formations from [Combat and Movement](#) so the larger fight remains quick.

Roll in the Open

Roll enemy attacks, retaliation, and random results where everyone can see them. State the enemy's dice pool and the sapper's Defense before rolling. Open rolls make the battlefield feel cruel rather than arbitrary and let the table understand exactly how narrow each escape was.

Do not conceal rules in order to create suspense. Conceal enemy positions, patrol timing, buried hazards, and the consequences of unfamiliar horrors. Once a threat acts, resolve it plainly.

Presenting No-Man's-Land

Describe immediate danger before distant detail. Tell the players what is about to kill them, what can be reached, and what might offer another route. A useful battlefield description answers three questions:

- What is threatening the unit now?
- What nearby features can the sappers act upon?
- What new information could they mark on the map?

Use Resistance 1 or higher only when failure can draw meaningful retaliation. Use Resistance 0 when a safe action is certain to work but the sapper's skill can determine how much more they learn or recover. Do not make the unit reroll a route it has already rendered safe unless something has changed.

Offering Resistance 0 Checks

Offer a Resistance 0 check when all three statements are true:

1. The sapper can complete the basic action without meaningful danger.
2. The scene contains useful information, options, or resources beyond the obvious result.
3. The number of additional findings can reasonably depend on the sapper's dice pool.

State everything the players need to understand the scene before the roll. Then name the skill, explain that the check cannot cause retaliation, and ask what the sapper is trying to learn or find. The check automatically provides the basic result. Each 6 rolled adds one concrete, actionable finding. A finding should point to a route, danger, tool, timing, shelter, salvage opportunity, or question worth pursuing rather than merely adding atmosphere.

Use one check for each distinct question or search area. Do not let every sapper roll the same safe search in sequence. If several sappers look together, choose the approach that best defines the search and resolve it once. Equipment may contribute when it genuinely improves what can be observed or recovered.

Examples:

- **Visible obstacles:** From safe cover, a sapper identifies the wire, churned mine craters, and exposed ground automatically. Awareness successes reveal the machine gun's likely traverse, a depression below its sightline, or fresh disturbance around a possible lane.
- **Reading shell damage:** A sapper analyzing a quiet crater field automatically finds the most stable nearby shelter. Engineering successes reveal connected subsidence, a buried structure, or ground likely to collapse under heavy movement.
- **Searching secured ground:** After a trench section is cleared, a sapper automatically finds its obvious stores. Awareness, Engineering, or another suitable skill can reveal one additional useful supply, document, concealed compartment, or sign of where the defenders withdrew per success.
- **Studying a known emplacement:** From outside its trigger and coverage, a sapper automatically identifies the visible obstacle. Successes reveal a tell, probable trigger, blind approach, service route, or tool that could create an opening.

Do not use Resistance 0 when a concealed mine may detonate, a patrol may hear the search, an emplacement is watching the position, time is running out, or failure would consume scarce equipment. That uncertainty has teeth and requires Resistance 1 or higher. If there is no danger and no variable yield, simply describe what happens without rolling.

Revealing the Shared Map

The referee knows more than the unit, but should help the players turn everything their sappers genuinely learn into a clear, useful map. The map is not a memory test and poor drawing is not a battlefield hazard. Preserve hidden positions and uncertain facts, but never hide information merely because a player did not phrase a question perfectly or draw a symbol precisely.

Reveal a feature in three layers:

1. **Spot it:** Draw or help the players place its visible location, footprint, and obvious effect on the ground.
2. **Understand it:** Add confirmed coverage, timing, supporting forces, triggers, routes, or relationships as the unit investigates.
3. **Exploit it:** Mark the cover, blind ground, required equipment, sabotage points, distractions, and other options the sappers discover.

When information is gained, pause long enough to put it on the shared map. The referee may draw it directly or tell a player exactly what to add. Use simple marks that remain readable across runs:

- Solid outlines for confirmed structures and obstacles
- Arrows or shaded lanes for known fire, movement, wind, or observation
- Dotted lines and question marks for suspected routes or uncertain positions
- Short labels for triggers, timings, required tools, and safe cover
- Crossed-out marks with a new note for changed terrain rather than erasing what the unit once knew

For example, when the unit spots a machine-gun bunker, place the bunker on the map immediately and show any obvious scar it has cut across the battlefield. A Resistance 0 check from safe observation might then add its firing lane, supporting troops, nearby cover, and visible approaches—one useful annotation for each success. Later infiltration might reveal its ammunition trench, reload interval, rear entrance, or a place to set a charge. Each discovery should leave the unit with a more complete diagram and at least one clearer decision.

Different approaches should reveal different truths. Awareness may establish coverage and patrol timing. Engineering may identify construction, power, or weak supports. Stealth may reveal dead ground and concealed approaches. A recovered document may add a route or designation without a roll. When two findings describe the same feature, connect them visibly instead of treating them as isolated clues.

Be exact about what is confirmed, what is inferred, and what remains unknown. If the sappers misinterpret evidence, mark the conclusion as uncertain rather than silently converting it into false fact. When the battlefield changes, show the cause and revise the map openly. The enemy may adapt, but the referee should not invalidate correct annotations simply to restore surprise.

COOPERATE THROUGH THE MAP The referee is a cooperative force for the unit even while controlling a hostile world. Help the players translate fictional observations into distances, firing lanes, routes, and actionable choices. Remind them of established map facts their sappers would recognize. Clarify the likely stakes of a plan before dice are rolled. The brutality should come from the battlefield's disclosed dangers and the consequences of chosen risks, not from the referee withholding usable information.

Turning Failure into Bought Knowledge

After a failed Resistance 1 or higher check outside combat, resolve one primary retaliation and then reveal one useful truth caused by that failure. This is **Bought Knowledge**. Put the truth on the shared map before play moves on.

Choose a truth that answers one immediate question:

- **Where is it?** Reveal a position, boundary, firing lane, route, or source.
- **What wakes it?** Reveal a trigger, tell, detection method, or timing.
- **What supports it?** Reveal nearby troops, ammunition, communication, power, or reinforcement.
- **What changes it?** Reveal useful cover, a vulnerable component, required tool, distraction, or alternate approach.

Tie the truth to the consequence. Gunfire reveals its direction. A mine blast shows the field's edge. Collapsing earth exposes buried masonry. Lost equipment catches on previously unseen wire. A patrol responding to noise reveals its route. The fiction should make it clear how the sappers learned what they now know.

Ask “**What did your sapper understand a moment too late?**” when the player would enjoy contributing. Accept an answer that fits the established ground, or reshape it into a narrower fact. Do not make the player responsible for inventing their own reward, and do not permit an answer that erases the obstacle, contradicts established facts, or avoids the retaliation already incurred.

Bought Knowledge should expose the next decision, not supply the whole plan. “The gun fires along this lane” is useful. “The gun can be defeated by cutting this exact cable, which is unguarded” is probably several discoveries compressed into one. When no new fact follows naturally, deepen or confirm an uncertain annotation instead: fix a suspected position, establish a timing, or rule out one approach.

Combat failures do not automatically grant Bought Knowledge. Combat already supplies information through visible enemy actions, changing positions, wounds, and the enemy turn. Grant it during combat only when an attack, hazard, emplacement, or operation explicitly says the failed action reveals something.

When the players hesitate, first show the pressure: a ranging shell lands closer, a patrol's lamp turns, or a machine gun begins traversing. Ask for a decision. If they continue debating, retaliate.

Running the Enemy

The enemy is as human and mechanically capable as the sappers, but war rarely gives either side a fair fight. Enemy soldiers use positions, numbers, prepared ground, and reinforcement. They recover and rebuild their dead when allowed to do so.

Play enemy knowledge honestly. A surviving sentry may report the unit's route. A stolen body may reveal its equipment and alterations. A destroyed patrol with no observer cannot warn anyone.

Between runs, choose one or two reactions based on what the enemy learned. Preserve patterns the players can exploit. Reinforcing a known patrol route creates a harder problem; moving every danger without cause makes the map meaningless.

Run pillboxes, gun rooms, projectors, and living fortifications using Stationary Defenses. They respond to explicit triggers instead of taking automatic enemy turns. Keep their firing lanes and behavior consistent so distraction, concealment, and sabotage can become learned solutions.

Death, Recovery, and Cohesion

Objectives should demand a cohesive unit. A sapper left behind may be stripped for parts, burned after becoming Battleborn, or captured for study when their Humanity is 25 or less, their reconstruction is visibly extensive, or they carry level 3 equipment. Human-looking prisoners are usually not worth the enemy's effort unless the operation establishes another reason.

Leaving a sapper behind is a last resort, not a routine between-run cleanup. If recovery remains possible, mark the body, captive, or enemy route and give the unit a dangerous opportunity to reclaim them during the current or next run. Make recovery compete with time, equipment, or the primary objective. Do not declare permanent death while a concrete rescue remains in reach.

KEEP THE DEAD PLAYER INVOLVED When a sapper dies, keep that player involved in decisions about recovery, the map, and the remaining unit. If anyone survives, field revival can return the dead after the required full round. If everyone dies, move quickly to body recovery and reconstruction in the trench.

Skill ranks gained through revival represent a body learning under genuine battlefield pressure. If the unit plainly arranges a safe death only to harvest replacement ranks, apply the revival, replacement, and full Humanity loss, including any Black Matter cost, but grant no skill ranks. Do not use this rule against desperate sacrifices or risky plans; it exists to prevent the war from becoming a training exercise conducted on cooperative corpses.

When a third Burn box is marked, announce that the body is Burn-Listed and show the anti-Battleborn response approaching. Give it a route, equipment, and enough time for the unit to attempt recovery. The hunters secure the corpse, prepare it, and then incinerate it; they do not erase it between sentences. Every death after the third draws the same response until the Battleborn is permanently destroyed.

If a sapper is permanently lost while the operation continues, their player may create a new Private at the next trench return. The recruit receives the normal starting profile and the unit's map knowledge, but inherits none of the lost sapper's earned ranks. Until then, invite the player to portray a temporary recruit, an Allied corpse hound, or another willing player's intrusive donor memory.

Trench Interludes

Scenes in the Allied trench should be **brief but rich**. Their purpose is to show what the sappers are protecting, what they are becoming, and how endless war has made horror routine. Most interludes need only a few minutes.

Choose one or two details each time:

- A Butcher recognizes a borrowed limb from an earlier patient.
- A cook serves the same thin meal beside a cart of covered bodies.
- Fresh recruits study the unit's marked map without meeting their eyes.
- An officer praises progress while misremembering which sappers died.
- A chaplain records names that no longer match the bodies wearing them.
- Corpse hounds return with pieces from both sides tangled together.
- Rain exposes old floorboards made from dismantled coffins.
- A familiar song awakens a replacement part's unfamiliar memory.

Let players pursue a trench scene when it matters to them, but return to outfitting and deployment before safety becomes comfortable.

Readiness Without a Deadline

Operations do not require a fixed number of runs unless a specific briefing says otherwise. After every cycle, show the larger force becoming more ready to advance: troops mass behind the parapet, artillery remains loaded on the unit's coordinates, casualty stations prepare empty beds, and officers leave the assault time blank while awaiting the signal.

This is pressure, not a concealed countdown. It should make the unit feel responsible for the lives waiting behind it without invalidating reconnaissance or ending an operation arbitrarily. Repeat details only after changing them: more

men, less room, quieter conversation, older orders, and a red flag that has been folded and unfolded until the cloth remembers the crease.

OPTIONAL BACKGROUND AMBIENCE Quiet environmental sound can help sustain the pressure of the Front, but it is not required. Keep it beneath the players' voices and favor rain, timber creaks, distant artillery, and sparse battlefield noise over heroic or cinematic music. Suggested starting points: - [8 Hours of WWI Trench Rain Ambience](#) for general play. - [Night in a Foggy Trench](#) for trench interludes and cautious exploration. - [No-Man's Land — Battlefield 1 Soundscape](#) for exposed crossings and active battlefields. Let the sound change with the fiction rather than switching to combat music. Raise the battlefield slightly as danger closes, then cut it completely during revival. The referee's voice, the dice, and the table's own noises make the procedure more intimate and unsettling. Restore the rain afterward, perhaps more quietly than before. Test videos before play because availability, advertisements, and volume can change.

Orders and Desertion

Command expects the operation to be completed. Orders may be interpreted, routes may change, and officers may be deceived, but open refusal is treated as desertion or treason.

The players may still refuse. Make the consequence a real part of the fiction rather than simply denying the choice. The unit may be forced at gunpoint into no-man's-land, stripped of rank and equipment, hunted through the trench, or executed and rebuilt for another attempt. A sapper who escapes has abandoned the operation and normally leaves play.

The unit should rarely want to desert. The objective, the people in the trench, and the certainty of military punishment should all make crossing the wire feel like the least impossible choice.

Ending a Run

A run ends when the objective is complete, the entire unit is dead with no Battleborn still able to attempt unaided revival, or the survivors retreat after reviving whom they can and abandoning the remaining bodies. Do not prolong an inevitable retreat with repeated checks over known ground. Focus on any pursuit, unrecovered body, or changed hazard that makes the return meaningfully different.

Afterward:

1. Resolve Butcher revival and Humanity loss.
2. Record repairs and donor sources, allocate 2 ranks per eligible revival or 3 with Black Matter, and record promotions.
3. Let the players update their map.
4. Decide what the enemy learned and how it reacts.
5. Present one brief trench detail.
6. Show one sign of Allied readiness or institutional pressure.
7. Offer an optional donor-memory prompt if a player wants one; skip it when the unit is ready to deploy.
8. Re-equip the unit and begin the next run.

Brutal, Not Arbitrary

- Telegraph dangers that explicitly kill before resolving them.
- Let a successful check accomplish its declared purpose; do not cancel it with an equivalent consequence.
- One failed check outside combat normally creates one primary retaliation and one Bought Knowledge truth. During combat, the enemy turn is the retaliation. Add another consequence only when an item, creature, hazard, or operation explicitly requires it.
- When several targets make equal sense, threaten the most exposed rather than automatically selecting the weakest sapper.
- Let learned routes, destroyed positions, and good preparation make later runs meaningfully safer.

- Make death reveal information, alter the map, consume a resource, or sharpen the horror. A death that changes nothing is wasted violence.

Use [Combat Checklist](#), [Movement and Exploration Checklist](#), and [Run Cycle Checklist](#) at the table.

Referee Principles

- **Be lethal, not arbitrary.** Foreshadow danger and honor preparation.
- **Roll openly.** Let the dice indict the war.
- **Keep the map true.** Change it only when the fiction changes it.
- **Make failure immediate.** Retaliation creates motion; Bought Knowledge creates the next decision.
- **Let knowledge matter.** A discovered route is progress even when everyone dies.
- **Keep trench interludes brief.** The trench offers recovery, not relief.
- **Show the cost.** Every new ability should leave something human behind.

Continue: [Mission Construction](#) turns these principles into a playable operation.

Mission Construction

Use [Enemies and Monsters](#) for mobile opposition, [Stationary Defenses](#) for puzzle-like emplacements, and [Retaliation Tables](#) for battlefield consequences.

An operation of **Entrenched** unfolds across a persistent map. The referee prepares most of no-man's-land before play, then changes enemy activity in response to what the sappers discover, destroy, and reveal.

The map is not a sequence of disposable encounters. It is hostile ground the players learn over repeated deaths. A good operation becomes more understandable with every run even as the enemy becomes more aware of the unit.

OPEN-ENDED OPERATIONS Do not assign a deadline merely to force motion. Let failed checks, enemy reactions, Humanity loss, and endangered bodies provide immediate pressure. Between runs, show Allied readiness building at the edge of the map: massed troops, registered guns, waiting stretcher teams, and sealed orders missing only the signal time. These details show what depends on the sappers without functioning as a concealed failure clock.

Operation Map

A standard operation map is:

- **36 squares wide**
- **84 to 144 squares long**
- Anchored by the Allied trench along one short edge
- Oriented toward the objective and enemy line near the opposite edge

The precise physical distance represented by a square matters less than consistency. Combat uses the range and movement rules in [Combat and Movement](#).

Longer maps are not automatically harder. A 144-square map should contain more useful routes, shelter, and discoveries rather than merely requiring more movement rolls.

Do not count every square during ordinary exploration. Advance the unit between meaningful locations and decisions. Use exact movement only during combat, pursuit, timed hazards, or dangerous crossings where position and exposure matter. Once the unit proves a route safe, let later runs cross it quickly until the battlefield changes.

Preparing the Ground

For a fast physical setup, use a roll of butcher paper, kraft paper, the blank back of wrapping paper, or taped one-inch grid sheets. Give yourself ten minutes to establish the trenches, major landmarks, broken routes, and broad danger areas. When the timer ends, stop making the map neat. Add hidden obstacles and enemy positions in rough notation, then let smaller findings enter the map as the unit explores. The battlefield should look used, corrected, and argued over rather than professionally drafted.

A full 36-by-84 or 36-by-144 field is intentionally long and works best on a paper roll laid across or beside the table. If space is limited, divide the same map into connected sections such as **Approach**, **Killing Ground**, and **Enemy Works**. Keep coordinates or matching edge marks so routes continue cleanly between sheets. This changes only how the map is handled, not its total length.

Before play, draw or place the features that will remain stable throughout the operation:

- Ridges, depressions, mud, flooded ground, and shell craters
- Burnt-out tanks and other artillery shelter
- Ruined homes, bunkers, chapels, factories, and farm structures
- Barbed wire, tank traps, barricades, and fortified walls
- Known and hidden tunnel entrances
- Minefields and other buried hazards
- Enemy trench lines and permanent fortifications

- Several possible approaches to the objective

For an operation set in a ruined settlement, include at least one hollow route through connected cellars, drains, buried alleys, or gaps beneath burnt foundations. Put its confirmed entrances on the referee's map and decide what surface obstacle it bypasses, what signs reveal it, what danger occupies or destabilizes it, and how another exit might be uncovered. Use [Changing Ground](#) for travel and revelation guidance, and [The Hollows Beneath the Ruins](#) for the setting detail.

Build pillboxes, projectors, and other fixed weapons using [Stationary Defenses](#). Their coverage and triggers belong on the referee's map. Give every emplacement visible evidence, blind ground, and several ways to create an opening rather than treating it as an enemy with a larger Defense.

Then prepare mobile or reactive elements:

- Patrol routes and patrol composition
- Sentries and firing positions
- Artillery and mortar targets
- Corpse recovery routes
- Enemy reserves
- Traps or ambushes the enemy may deploy after learning the sappers' habits

The referee's map contains all prepared information. The players begin with a clean copy showing the Allied trench, broad landmarks known to command, and the approximate objective when its location is known.

Recommended Supplies and Battlefield Salvage

Before the first briefing, prepare a short **recommended supplies** list based on what command believes about the operation. Give it to the players before outfitting. It should suggest useful categories without revealing the correct route or every hidden threat.

A useful list contains five to eight entries drawn from:

- A weapon suited to the expected engagement range
- A tool for the most obvious barrier or terrain
- A way to locate a hidden threat
- Explosives suited to the known objective
- Smoke, camouflage, or another way to break sight
- Field dressings or revival equipment
- One item command recommends for the wrong reason
- One scarce item the unit is told may be recoverable in the field

The list is advice, not extra equipment. Sappers still obey their slots, rank access, and assigned-bearer rules.

Seed two to four salvage opportunities on the map: an abandoned Allied cache, a dead earlier unit, a wrecked supply carrier, enemy equipment, or a tool trapped behind the obstacle it could solve. At least one find should answer a danger on the recommended list, and at least one should offer an unexpected alternative. Mark recovered equipment on the shared map. Unless an operation explicitly says an item can be claimed immediately, it must reach the Allied trench and be formally issued during outfitting before it grants its mechanical benefit.

Salvage should reward exploration without becoming a general inventory hunt. Finding the right tool can reduce an operation-level Resistance, open a route, restore a scarce supply, or change what the unit carries on the next run.

Layers of No-Man's-Land

A useful map has three loose layers. These are design guidelines rather than visible boundaries.

The Approach

The ground nearest the Allied trench teaches the operation's basic dangers. It should contain several routes, early shelter, and clues pointing toward deeper threats. Repeatedly crossing it becomes faster once the sappers mark safe ground.

The Killing Ground

The center of the map contains overlapping hazards, patrols, exposed lanes, ruins, and competing routes. Discoveries here should create meaningful choices: speed against safety, shelter against enemy occupation, or a direct route against a hidden one.

The Enemy Works

The far end contains the strongest defenses and the mission objective. It should reward information or sabotage gathered during earlier runs. A frontal attack may be possible, but the map should hold at least two ways to weaken, bypass, isolate, or surprise the final position.

What Remains Between Runs

The operation map is persistent. Unless a specific event changes them, the following remain where the players marked them:

- Terrain and substantial shelter
- Cleared or confirmed minefields
- Destroyed wire and barriers
- Collapsed or opened tunnels
- Destroyed machines and fortifications
- Placed traps and abandoned equipment
- Discovered routes and landmarks

The following may change between runs:

- Bodies may be recovered, consumed, rebuilt, or moved
- Patrol personnel may be replaced
- Patrol timing may change while the route remains recognizable
- Enemy sappers may shift firing positions
- Reserves may reinforce a damaged area
- New mines or traps may appear where the unit has become predictable

Do not erase useful information arbitrarily. Changes should follow from enemy knowledge, visible battlefield events, or the operation's established threats. When a known feature changes, let the players cross out, revise, or annotate their own map. Its accumulated corrections are part of play.

Use [Changing Ground](#) when bombardment, weather, excavation, or an advance reveals buried streets and burnt structures. A major change should remove or complicate one known feature while exposing another route, shelter, resource, danger, or piece of history. Show the cause and help the players revise the map before the new ground demands a decision.

Enemy Reinforcement

Killing a patrol matters during the current run, but enemy manpower is vast. Unless the unit cuts off reserves, replacements may occupy the same route before the next run.

Reinforcement should preserve learned patterns without making every run identical. A marked patrol route remains valuable for timing an ambush or placing a trap, even if the replacement patrol is larger, earlier, or accompanied by a corpse hound.

Permanent victories require action against the system supporting the enemy. Destroying a barracks, collapsing an access trench, poisoning a corpse depot, or severing communications may remove or reduce reinforcements for the rest of the operation.

The Objective

The players usually know the objective's approximate location from their briefing. Command may identify an enemy trench sector, a ruined village, a battery somewhere beyond a ridge, or a suspected tunnel complex without possessing an accurate position.

Some missions begin with no reliable location. In those operations, early runs are reconnaissance. Clues, captured documents, patrol movements, sound, and terrain gradually narrow the search.

An objective should require several discoveries or changes to the map before it becomes reasonably achievable. Avoid locking the operation behind one indispensable check. Failed checks bring retaliation, but another route, another run, or a more violent solution should remain possible.

For every dangerous obstacle, prepare at least two truths that failure could expose through [Bought Knowledge](#). These should reveal its operation or another approach without defeating it outright: a firing lane rather than a silenced gun, the edge of a minefield rather than a cleared path, or the sound of a buried chamber rather than an open entrance. This keeps failure productive without making preparation irrelevant.

Treat Resistance 4 or higher as an operation problem rather than a larger single roll. Prepared discoveries and sub-objectives reduce its Resistance or remove prerequisites. A bunker might begin at Resistance 4 and be impossible to breach directly; cutting its reinforcement tunnel reduces it to 3, and detonating its ammunition cache reduces it to 2.

Reactive Enemy Doctrine

After each run, consider what the enemy learned:

1. Where were the sappers seen?
2. Which route did they use?
3. What did they destroy, steal, or leave behind?
4. Which enemy positions survived to report?
5. Did the enemy recover an Allied body or piece of equipment?

Choose one or two logical responses. Move a firing position, reinforce a patrol, mine a discovered route, use a corpse as bait, or pull forces away from another part of the map. Responses should create new decisions rather than simply make the best-known route unusable.

If no enemy survives or observes the unit's actions, the enemy should not respond with impossible knowledge.

Pacing a Run

A run should take about thirty minutes of real time. Keep attention on immediate choices:

- Which route does the unit take?
- What does it stop to investigate or mark?
- Who risks a check?
- Does the unit press forward, revive the dead, or retreat?

Use Resistance 1 or higher only when failure can provoke meaningful retaliation. Offer Resistance 0 when a sapper safely studies visible ground, searches a secured position, or analyzes known evidence and the roll determines how many additional options or resources they uncover. Once the players understand a safe route, let them cross familiar ground quickly until something has changed.

If discussion stalls, signal an approaching patrol, descending shell, engine noise, or other immediate danger. Ask for a decision. If the unit still hesitates, retaliate as described in [Combat and Movement](#).

Mission Frameworks

Each framework supplies an operation's final objective and the kinds of discoveries that make it possible. Any framework can be reskinned for a different stretch of the front.

1. Raise the Red Flag

Objective: Capture an enemy trench section and raise the Allied signal flag so reinforcements can advance.

The unit must find a viable crossing, breach the outer defenses, silence the trench's weapons, and hold the position long enough to raise the flag. The approximate location is known from the beginning.

Useful discoveries include a buried approach, an observation blind spot, a weak section of wire, a reserve route, or the position of the trench's signal bunker.

The enemy reacts by strengthening whichever approach the sappers reveal. Permanent progress comes from destroying defensive structures and cutting reinforcement trenches.

2. Silence the Battery

Objective: Locate and destroy an artillery battery shelling the Allied line.

Command knows the direction of fire but not the battery's exact location. The unit must follow sound, shell trajectories, ammunition carriers, or communication wire to find it.

The guns may occupy armored pits, travel on rails, or be integrated into a living fortification. Destroying ammunition, severing observation lines, and trapping resupply routes can weaken the final assault.

The enemy may move individual guns or establish false firing positions after each attack.

3. Cut the Buried Nerve

Objective: Enter an underground communication complex and sever the enemy's control of the sector.

The surface map conceals a second network of tunnels. The unit must locate entrances, determine which passages connect, and identify the command or signal organ at the center.

Collapsing the wrong passage may close a route while opening another. Enemy sappers can emerge behind the unit through unmarked shafts. Once the buried nerve is cut, patrol reinforcement and coordinated artillery cease for the remainder of the operation.

4. Recover the Black Case

Objective: Find and return an intelligence case, prototype, officer, or preserved body lost in no-man's-land.

Command knows the missing unit's planned route but not where it fell. The players reconstruct its final movements from bodies, spent equipment, map scraps, and enemy recovery activity.

The target must be carried back to the Allied trench, turning the return journey into part of the mission. The enemy may move it between runs or use it as bait once it recognizes the search.

5. Burn the Battleborn

Objective: Permanently destroy an enemy Battleborn that repeatedly returns to command local patrols.

Killing the target is insufficient. The unit must learn its routes, locate the remains it uses for repair, defeat it, and incinerate or otherwise annihilate the body.

Each failed attempt teaches the creature about the sappers. It may adopt their tactics, use parts recovered from their bodies, and remember individual characters across revivals.

The mission should offer several means of permanent destruction, including carried incendiaries and dangerous environmental opportunities.

6. Collapse the Iron Saint

Objective: Destroy a mobile fortress, siege engine, or enormous reconstructed war organism before it reaches the Allied trench.

Its expected path crosses the long map, providing an approximate location that changes as the operation continues. A direct attack is nearly impossible. The unit must discover weak points and prepare the ground.

Possible solutions include mining a bridge, opening flooded ground, sabotaging its fuel or circulation, killing its guidance crew, or luring it over buried charges. The target advances or changes position between runs, making time visible on the shared map.

Completing the Operation

Mission success should be unmistakable. The flag rises, the guns stop, the buried signals go silent, the case reaches Allied hands, the Battleborn burns, or the Iron Saint collapses.

Once the objective is complete, the operation ends even if the war does not improve. Command records the surviving sappers, gathers whatever equipment remains, and prepares the next unit for another part of the front.

Continue: [Raise the Red Flag](#) is a prepared first operation. Use [Referee Lore Guide](#) when you want to seed deeper discoveries.

Referee Lore Guide

The setting should feel larger than the operation without requiring the referee to explain thirty-seven years of alternate history. Lore appears as pressure, objects, habits, and contradictions. Use the dossiers on [The Long War](#), [The Allied Trench](#), the [187th Sappers Regiment](#), [The First Sappers](#), [Project Eisensee](#), [The Butchers](#), [Corpse Hounds and Handlers](#), [Faith of the Final Trench](#), [No-Man's-Land](#), [The Shifting Front](#), and [The Enemy](#) as reservoirs of details rather than required exposition.

Five Firm Truths

1. The war has reorganized every institution around continuing itself.
2. Revival works, but nobody can prove what returns.
3. The enemy is horribly similar to the Allies.
4. No-man's-land remembers bodies, violence, and routes.
5. Becoming more useful means becoming less able to leave the war.

Everything else may be propaganda, doctrine, incomplete science, or a local truth.

A Three-Step Reveal

For each operation, choose one lore thread and reveal it three times.

1. **Sign:** An unsettling detail with no explanation.
2. **Pattern:** A second detail showing the first was not accidental.
3. **Cost:** The truth changes a choice, body, route, or relationship.

Example: the unit finds an enemy hand wearing an Allied wedding ring; later an enemy prisoner recognizes the ring; finally a sapper's replacement hand remembers the prisoner's child.

Horror Rhythm

Do not make every description wet flesh and screaming. Use contrast:

- Procedure followed by violation
- Familiarity followed by incorrect recognition
- Military efficiency applied to an impossible body
- Domestic comfort beside industrial death
- A useful new skill accompanied by a private loss
- Silence after prolonged noise

One precise image is stronger than a paragraph of gore.

Recurring Motifs

Choose two or three for an operation:

- Names crossed out or belonging to several bodies
- Hands performing work their owners never learned
- Telephone voices from disconnected lines
- Gold vestments stained progressively darker
- Red thread marking recoverable remains
- Teeth appearing in manufactured objects
- Maps that anticipate changes
- Animals remembering dead handlers

- Fire as both mercy and execution
- The smell of a home nobody present has visited

Repeat a motif with a changed meaning. A telephone voice may first warn the unit, later imitate them, and finally answer from inside a revived sapper.

Questions to Ask Players

Use one after a revival or quiet discovery:

- Which familiar sensation now feels borrowed?
- What does the new part do while you sleep?
- Whose name almost comes when someone calls yours?
- What feature does your section use to recognize you now?
- What did you see on the other side that you refuse to describe?
- Which enemy position feels like somewhere you once lived?
- What ordinary object frightens the donor part?
- What promise are you no longer sure you made?

Accept short answers and reuse them later.

Rumor Procedure

When the unit hears a rumor, decide secretly whether it is **true**, **partly true**, or **useful propaganda**. Do not announce the category. A false rumor should still reveal what the speaker fears or wants.

Rumors:

1. Colonel Vale has never died because there is no body inside the uniform.
2. Corpse hounds can smell the original soul beneath donor meat.
3. The enemy trench has been trying to surrender for eleven years.
4. The First Sappers returned with one more shadow than bodies.
5. Black Matter is leaking upward from the Final Trench.
6. Butchers keep the memories they remove and trade them as favors.
7. Every red flag raised on the front is the same flag.
8. Battleborn do not lose their humanity; they remember everyone else's.
9. A quiet sector exists where the dead refuse revival.
10. The war ended years ago, but neither front received the order.

What Not to Explain

Never conclusively answer all of the following:

- Whether revival restores, copies, or replaces a person
- Whether the other side is an afterlife or a physical place
- What Black Matter ultimately is
- Which coalition began reconstruction
- Whether peace outside the military system is still possible

The players should understand procedures and consequences. They do not need a reliable cosmology.

Connecting Lore to the Map

Every important piece of lore should eventually become spatial. Put its evidence somewhere the sappers can mark:

- A First Sapper recovery site

- A Black Matter seam
- A buried civilian home
- A town or burnt building newly exposed by the shifting Front
- An enemy memorial
- A silent Project Eisensee chamber
- A corpse route used by both sides

Lore becomes part of play when it changes where the unit goes, what it recovers, or what it chooses to destroy.

Continue: The Long War begins the setting dossiers; take only the details your operation needs.

Changing Ground

Use this referee procedure when the Front opens a route, exposes a structure, or changes terrain the unit already knows. [The Shifting Front](#) holds the setting and sensory context; this page keeps the map and movement rules together.

Traveling by Hollow

Telegraph underground dangers as honestly as surface fire. The horror should come from choosing whether the protected route is worth what the signs imply, not from an unseen collapse imposed without warning.

A known hollow lets the unit bypass surface sight, wire, and ordinary firing lanes while it remains intact and unoccupied. Mark every confirmed entrance, branch, obstruction, and exit on the shared map. Draw the hollow as a dotted route or as a small inset beneath the surface map so players can see which landmarks it connects without needing a complete floor plan.

Moving through a mapped, stable hollow requires no check. Use Resistance 0 to study an entrance safely, sound the nearby ground, compare buried walls with the surface, or determine what additional route might connect to it. Each success can reveal an exit direction, load-bearing wall, dry chamber, airflow, recent passage, salvage, or the location of danger without requiring the sapper to enter it.

Entry becomes Resistance 1 or higher when the route is unstable, flooded, occupied, watched, chemically fouled, or being crossed under time pressure. Do not make every few feet another roll. Establish one danger for a section of hollow, resolve the unit's approach to it, and allow safe movement through the section once that danger has been understood or removed.

Hollows provide strong advantages but impose physical limits:

- Far attacks and surface observation cannot pass through solid earth.
- Movement may be reduced to crawling where the gap narrows.
- Long weapons, rigid equipment, and bodies may not fit through every passage.
- Explosions and heavy movement above can change or collapse the route.
- Smoke, gas, fire, and floodwater follow airflow and slope rather than the surface map.
- A single blocked exit can turn shelter into a sealed grave.

When the Hollow Changes

A hollow is persistent terrain, but never guaranteed terrain. Mark changes rather than erasing the route:

- A collapse seals one branch and opens a room beside it.
- Floodwater makes one descent impassable and reveals where another exit rises.
- Enemy braces and footprints show that the far end is now occupied.
- A new crater creates a dangerous entrance in exposed ground.
- A bombardment joins two cellar systems that were previously separate.
- Something below has widened a passage without leaving excavated soil.

When a known hollow changes, preserve what the unit learned about its direction, construction, and connections. Even a sealed route tells the sappers what lies beneath and where another entrance might be found.

Revealing New Ground

When the Front exposes a structure, draw its visible footprint on the shared map immediately. Do not demand a check to notice a house rising from a crater or a street opened by shellfire. Use [Resistance 0](#) when safe study can reveal additional details, and use dangerous checks only when entry, excavation, instability, enemy observation, or something inside can retaliate.

Reveal the place in layers:

1. **Outline:** What has emerged, where it sits, and how it changes movement or sight.
2. **Access:** Doors, windows, shell openings, tunnels, flooded sections, and blocked passages.
3. **Use:** Shelter, observation, salvage, routes, evidence, and positions the enemy may occupy.
4. **History:** Civilian purpose, later military uses, and signs that connect it to the wider war.
5. **Wrongness:** One contradiction, living process, borrowed memory, or impossible preservation when the operation needs horror.

DRAW ONLY WHAT IS KNOWN Help the players annotate each confirmed layer. Use room outlines, arrows, short labels, and question marks rather than drafting a complete architectural plan. If only part of a buried town has emerged, draw only that part. The blank ground around it remains a promise and a threat.

Changing a Persistent Map

A shifting Front should complicate knowledge, not make it worthless. Preserve what the unit earned whenever possible.

- A collapsed safe route may reveal why it collapsed and expose another route.
- A destroyed shelter may become a crater, rubble wall, or entrance to the cellar beneath it.
- A flooded trench may carry bodies, equipment, and evidence to a new marked location.
- An enemy advance may occupy a known landmark without changing its layout.
- New wire may alter an approach while the unit's recorded firing lanes remain useful.
- A bombardment may erase an uncertain mark but should confirm something else through the destruction.

Cross out and revise old annotations instead of erasing them. Date or number major versions when useful. A palimpsest of corrections shows that the sappers have survived long enough to watch geography become unreliable.

Do not shift the map merely because the unit found an effective route. Give every change a cause the players could observe or later discover. Enemy adaptation should answer knowledge the enemy actually obtained. Weather and shelling should change several connected features, not select only the sappers' best advantage.

2d6: What the Front Uncovers

Roll two six-sided dice when bombardment, collapse, or weather opens an older layer. Results near 7 are common remains of civilian life and earlier fortification. Extremes are rare and wrong.

2d6	The ground exposes
2	A complete room untouched by dust, containing warm food and a family who insist the bombardment has not begun
3	A sealed reconstruction ward whose numbered patients share parts with living members of the unit
4	An old command gallery with maps, firing records, and a route omitted from every current chart
5	A row of burnt house fronts backed by connected cellars and one defensible courtyard
6	A workshop or storehouse containing damaged tools, useful materials, and signs of hurried evacuation
7	A civilian cellar, kitchen, shop, chapel, or schoolroom converted by several generations of soldiers
8	A buried street or rail spur that creates a faster route but passes beneath watched ground
9	A collapsed aid station containing bodies, medical supplies, and records from both armies

2d6	The ground exposes
10	An earlier trench line with intact firing steps, blocked dugouts, and obsolete mine warnings
11	A crypt or communal shelter whose dead have been catalogued for future military use
12	The upper floor of a building rising from below, its windows looking down into earth and its occupants still moving behind them

The result is a starting shape, not a complete encounter. Give it one immediate use, one danger, and one question the unit can pursue. If a failed check exposes it, apply [Bought Knowledge](#) through the discovery without cancelling the retaliation.

Referee Details

Use one or two details at a time:

- Wallpaper protected behind the outline of a removed cabinet
- Tram rails rising from mud and ending at a crater wall
- A house number repeated on three military bunkers built from the same street
- Charred floorboards polished smooth by years of boots
- A cellar window opening into the side of a trench
- Roots growing through a dining table without disturbing the place settings
- Enemy sandbags sewn from curtains carrying Allied ration marks
- A street sign used as a surgeon's drainage board
- Children's height marks continued upward in several soldiers' handwriting
- A church bell beneath the ground ringing only when artillery passes overhead
- A bathtub filled with clean water in a district without working pumps
- A front door standing alone, still locked, with fresh mud on the interior handle

Continue: Return to [Mission Construction](#) to place the change in an operation, or read [The Shifting Front](#) for the place it exposes.

Retaliation Tables

These results extend the failure procedure in [Skill Checks and Exploration](#). Preserve lasting discoveries and changes using the map procedure in [Core Game Loop](#).

Outside combat, when a Resistance 1 or higher check fails or the unit hesitates, the battlefield retaliates. Resistance 0 checks automatically succeed and never use these tables. During combat, use these tables only when an action, hazard, or operation explicitly calls for an additional retaliation.

After resolving a failed non-combat check, also apply [Bought Knowledge](#). Reveal one useful truth through the result and mark it on the shared map. The truth may be part of the rolled retaliation or a separate fact it exposes, but it does not cancel the consequence or complete the failed action. Hesitation without a check does not automatically grant Bought Knowledge.

The referee may choose a fitting result or roll **three six-sided dice, add them together, and read the total** on the most relevant table. This produces results from 3 to 18.

The middle of each table is common: exposure, displacement, damaged equipment, approaching enemies, and survivable wounds. Results near 3 and 18 are increasingly rare and strange. A low extreme often reveals something useful through a dangerous accident; a high extreme permanently changes the map, destroys bodies, or brings overwhelming force.

Total	Frequency
3 or 18	0.5% each
4 or 17	1.4% each
5 or 16	2.8% each
6 or 15	4.6% each
7 or 14	6.9% each
8 or 13	9.7% each
9 or 12	11.6% each
10 or 11	12.5% each

Retaliation follows the fiction. Ignore or reinterpret a result that cannot happen in the current position. Shelter may prevent bombardment, an empty minefield cannot produce an enemy mine, and the enemy cannot react with knowledge nobody survived to report.

One result may threaten one sapper or the whole unit as written. If an attack threatens several targets, roll once and compare its successes separately with every target's Defense. Do not add unrelated punishments merely because the result is dramatic.

Artillery and Mortars

3d6	Retaliation
3	A shell opens the battlefield instead of closing it: create a deep crater and reveal a buried entrance, body, cache, or Black Matter seam. Everyone within 2 squares is thrown 3 squares and loses one unsecured item into the new ground.
4	A massive unexploded shell buries itself nearby. Mark it as Resistance 2 to defuse or Resistance 3 to move safely; its casing bears coordinates for an unmarked enemy battery.

3d6	Retaliation
5	A body is thrown from old earthworks and lands 6 squares away carrying a recognizable map fragment or item. The impact reveals the unit's position.
6	Dense smoke and falling earth block sight beyond Close range until the unit or wind moves. Shapes inside the smoke move toward the nearest voices.
7	The blast throws every exposed sapper 2 squares in different directions and breaks the unit's formation.
8	One carried consumable loses a use, or one exposed item is torn loose and lands in an adjacent square.
9	A ranging shell lands beside the acting sapper. Mark the square; the next artillery retaliation centers there unless the unit changes position.
10	Shrapnel makes a 6-dice attack against the most exposed sapper. Its path reveals the direction of the firing battery.
11	Flying metal marks one exposed sapper's Wound box; if none is empty, they become Dying.
12	Walking fire crosses the route. Every exposed sapper must immediately move 2 squares toward shelter or mark a Wound box, becoming Dying if none is empty.
13	A shelter entrance collapses. Anyone inside remains protected but trapped; clearing the entrance is Resistance 2 Strength or Engineering.
14	The closest fallen body is thrown 6 squares and badly pulped. Use that damage when choosing its replacement; it grants the normal revival ranks, not extra ranks for extra damaged parts.
15	A mortar crew brackets the area. Mark its center; until the unit escapes or silences the observers, hesitation produces two linked threats instead of one.
16	A direct hit destroys one marked piece of shelter. Occupants may flee immediately or be killed beneath it. Change the map permanently.
17	A heavy shell attacks every sapper in one chosen square with 10 dice and destroys every loose item and ordinary body there.
18	The bombardment erases a 2-square-radius area. Everyone inside is killed, ordinary bodies and equipment are destroyed, and a crater, fire, flooded pit, or Black Matter wound permanently replaces the terrain.

Mines and Wire

3d6	Retaliation
3	A chain detonation tears a crooked permanent route through the minefield and reveals what was buried beneath it. The acting sapper is thrown to the far end of the new lane and marks a Wound box, becoming Dying if none is empty.

3d6	Retaliation
4	The apparent mine is built around a speaking corpse. It wakes, grabs the nearest sapper, and repeats directions toward a route omitted from the Allied map.
5	The wire contains an old identification line. Its tags name a missing Allied unit and point toward a concealed recovery cache, but touching it raises a flare.
6	A marking flag, map coordinate, or known safe square disappears into shifting mud. One section of the route becomes uncertain until checked again.
7	Wire catches one carried item and tears it loose into an adjacent square. Recover it now or leave its position marked.
8	The acting sapper becomes pinned and cannot move until they spend an action and pass Resistance 1 Strength or Engineering.
9	A gas charge bursts. Every nearby sapper without a working respirator marks a Wound box; protected sappers must move or test Mobility at Resistance 1.
10	A shallow mine marks the acting sapper's Wound box; if none is empty, they become Dying.
11	The device is attached to signal wire. An enemy position learns the unit's location and begins moving toward the marked route.
12	The blast scatters live mines into two adjacent unmarked squares. Mark the original lane as changed.
13	A hidden marksman uses the detonation as a signal and makes a 6-dice Far attack against the sapper carrying the most visible tool.
14	A bounding mine makes one 5-dice attack against every sapper within Close range, using the same roll against each Defense.
15	The mine kills the acting sapper and throws the body 3 squares deeper into the field, beyond the nearest cover.
16	Connected charges raise impassable wire between the front and rear of the unit. The section is split until it finds a route or creates an opening.
17	The explosion awakens a Skinless Burrower beneath the marked safe lane. It knows the vibration of everyone who crossed it.
18	The field chain-detonates. Kill one exposed sapper, mark a Wound box on every other sapper in the field, and permanently replace the minefield with burning craters and one narrow passable route.

Patrols and Enemy Fire

3d6	Retaliation
3	An enemy patrol withdraws through a route not shown on either map. It signals reserves, but the unit may mark the newly revealed access trench before pursuit begins.
4	A sentry glimpses movement and changes the patrol's timing. The

3d6	Retaliation
	unit learns the new interval if it remains hidden long enough to watch.
5	Enemy voices force an immediate choice between hiding, retreating, or following them toward an unknown position.
6	A flare removes concealment until the end of the next enemy turn and exposes the outlines of one previously hidden position.
7	A Line Soldier makes a 4-dice attack at Far range, then moves toward the nearest prepared position.
8	Two Line Soldiers enter along a known patrol route and begin searching the last place the unit was heard.
9	A recovery patrol advances toward the nearest fallen body. It will move the body on its next turn unless stopped.
10	A patrol changes course and occupies the unit's most direct retreat route. Mark the new timing if observed.
11	The enemy tries to capture a wounded or isolated sapper with 25 Humanity or less, extensive visible reconstruction, or level 3 equipment. Otherwise it attempts to strip or destroy one carried item.
12	A marksman makes a 6-dice Far attack against the sapper carrying the most valuable visible equipment.
13	The enemy calls mortar fire on the unit's position. Roll or choose on the Artillery and Mortars table.
14	Three Line Soldiers enter from prepared cover on the unit's flank. They form one formation if they remain together.
15	An Assault Corporal and one Line Soldier advance from Close range while another enemy holds the retreat route.
16	Incendiary fire targets the nearest fallen sapper. Recover or move the remains before the next enemy turn or they are completely incinerated.
17	A concealed machine-gun emplacement attacks every exposed sapper in its lane with 7 dice. Mark its coverage and use Stationary Defenses if the unit survives.
18	A coordinated assault begins from two directions: one suitable enemy per living sapper enters, supported by a stationary defense or artillery observer already watching the field.

Ruins and Wrecks

3d6	Retaliation
3	The floor collapses into a sealed room containing a useful cache and evidence of why nobody retrieved it. The acting sapper falls inside, marks a Wound box, and is separated from the unit.
4	A wall opens around an intact civilian room untouched by time. One object answers a sapper's borrowed memory while something

3d6	Retaliation
	behind the room begins moving.
5	A dead engine turns once and moves the entire wreck 2 squares, revealing an entrance or crushed body beneath it.
6	Rotten flooring drops the acting sapper into a lower room outside the unit's sight.
7	Falling masonry blocks the route behind the unit and creates hard shelter on the opposite side.
8	Broken glass, metal, or bone tears one carried item loose or destroys one consumable use.
9	A wall shifts and exposes the unit to a known firing lane or observation point.
10	Jagged debris marks the acting sapper's Wound box; if none is empty, they become Dying.
11	The structure catches fire and will become unusable after the next sapper turn. Everyone inside must choose what to recover before leaving.
12	A concealed Line Soldier makes a 5-dice Close attack, then retreats toward a hidden exit if able.
13	Stagnant gas fills the lowest room. Every sapper inside must leave or pass a Resistance 1 Mobility check using a respirator; failure marks a Wound box.
14	A cellar door seals behind the unit. Reopening it is Resistance 2 Strength or Engineering while sound approaches from the other side.
15	The ruin collapses, marking one Wound box for everyone inside and permanently changing its passages and shelter.
16	A direct shell enters through the roof, killing the most exposed sapper and opening the structure to the sky.
17	A Patchwork Heap rises from the bodies beneath the floor and immediately incorporates the nearest unattended remains.
18	Black Matter floods the foundation. It pulls every loose body and item 3 squares toward its center, wakes one unfinished horror, and permanently makes the ruin living terrain.

Tunnels and Buried Works

3d6	Retaliation
3	A collapse opens an older tunnel running in an impossible direction. It offers a new route, but the acting sapper falls inside and hears the unit continuing along a different version of the passage.
4	Telephone wire begins whispering current enemy orders in a dead sapper's voice. Following it reveals a signal route while alerting whatever is speaking.

3d6	Retaliation
5	A wrong turn returns the unit to a known junction with one new door, body, or set of footprints that was not there before.
6	The unit's light fails. Repair or replacement requires an action; movement beyond Melee range is unseen until light returns.
7	Water rises and reduces movement by 2 squares until the unit reaches higher ground or opens a drain.
8	A narrow section forces one bulky item to be left at the entrance or carried only by spending the bearer's full action to move.
9	The ceiling groans. Moving slowly avoids collapse but allows an approaching threat to advance one step.
10	A cave-in separates the first or last sapper from the rest of the unit.
11	Stagnant gas marks one sapper's Wound box, leaving them Dying if none is empty, and extinguishes open flame.
12	An enemy listening post learns the unit's location and begins sealing or occupying the nearest exit.
13	A trap seals both ends of the passage and begins filling it with smoke or water. One exit is Resistance 2 to reopen.
14	An Enemy Sapper attacks from a concealed side shaft, then attempts to close it behind them.
15	The passage collapses behind the unit and permanently removes the known retreat route while revealing a smaller forward breach.
16	A gas main ruptures. Everyone must reach a marked exit before the end of the next sapper turn or be killed.
17	Enemy charges detonate, killing the sapper nearest the prepared wall and opening a breach into occupied enemy works.
18	The buried structure shifts between two known entrances. Separate the unit at the nearest junction, revise the map, and place an unfinished reconstruction chamber between the new paths.

Flesh Wastes and Unnatural Ground

3d6	Retaliation
3	The battlefield briefly aligns with the other side. Reveal a route, structure, or objective that exists in both places; every sapper who looks at it loses 1 Humanity.
4	The mud identifies a buried Allied body by using the voice of someone still alive. Digging toward it also wakes what is wrapped around the remains.
5	One replacement part pulls toward a useful cache, body, or Black Matter seam while trying to tear itself free of its owner. Mark a Wound box or let it guide the unit.
6	The mud repeats the acting sapper's last words in the voice of their donor. Nearby creatures hear the reply.

3d6	Retaliation
7	Hair, teeth, or fingernails grow across one square and make it dangerous ground.
8	A corpse beneath the unit repeats a sapper's familiar memory aloud, revealing the unit's position. The player may describe a donor memory in response, without any required reaction or memory cost.
9	Black rain marks every exposed sapper with a scent that grants nearby monsters 2 additional Awareness dice.
10	The ground drinks spilled blood and moves the nearest body 2 squares beneath the surface. Its location remains visible as breathing mud.
11	A replacement part rejects its owner. Mark a Wound box; if none is empty, the sapper becomes Dying.
12	Feral Corpse Hounds arrive from two directions, following the most recently revived sapper.
13	A Choir in the Mud begins calling the unit by name. If not silenced before the next enemy turn, it calls artillery.
14	The nearest unattended body is incorporated into a forming Patchwork Heap. Recover it before the next enemy turn or fight the completed Heap.
15	A Trench Mare charges through the unit with a 9-dice Melee attack against everyone in its line, then continues toward the Allied trench.
16	A Black Matter Bloom opens beneath a marked body or cache and pulls it below the surface.
17	Random remains knit into a new horror with Defense 3, Speed 6, and a 7-dice Melee attack. It possesses one voice and skill taken from the unit.
18	Something beneath the entire area wakes. Move every body, monster, and sapper 3 squares toward the center, permanently reshape the ground, and place the mouth, hand, or eye of an operation-level horror at its heart.

Scaling Retaliation

The dice already make ordinary battlefield pressure more common than extreme destruction. Do not add numerical modifiers to the 3d6 roll merely because the operation has progressed; doing so erases the usefulness of the curve and makes one extreme more common than the other.

Instead, scale through interpretation:

- Early in an operation, let common results reveal positions, alter movement, threaten equipment, and introduce enemies.
- As the unit learns the map, let the same results target established routes, scarce supplies, bodies, and recovery plans.
- Near the objective, let prepared enemy reactions overlap with whatever the roll creates.

Choose instead of rolling when only one consequence honestly follows from the fiction. Never protect a sapper merely because they have not died recently. Never kill them arbitrarily when a more specific consequence would make the map or next decision more interesting.

Brutality works best when players understand what killed them and carry that knowledge into the next run.

OPERATIONS

Introductory Operation: Raise the Red Flag

Run this operation with [Quick Reference](#), [Retaliation Tables](#), [Enemies and Monsters](#), and [Stationary Defenses](#) available. Use the ready-made unit in [Example Sappers](#) when the group wants to begin immediately.

This operation teaches the complete cycle of **Entrenched**: cross known ground, discover a route, mark the map, die, return altered, and use what the unit learned to push farther.

It is written for **three to six sappers** and should last two to four sessions.

Briefing

Enemy troops hold **Trench 19**, a forward position overlooking the Allied line. A larger assault is assembled behind the Allied parapet. It will advance only when the sappers raise a red signal flag over the trench.

The unit must cross no-man's-land, breach Trench 19, silence its defenders, and keep the flag standing through one complete enemy turn. Command knows the trench's approximate location and provides a flag, a rough map, and no promise of support.

The operation succeeds when the red flag remains raised at the end of an enemy turn. There is no fixed deadline. It fails permanently when every remaining sapper is permanently destroyed.

READINESS, NOT A COUNTDOWN After every cycle, show the assault waiting: more troops in the communications trenches, loaded guns trained on Trench 19, officers asking whether the next run will raise the flag, and casualty stations preparing empty beds. These signs do not secretly end the operation or punish careful reconnaissance. They show the human weight gathering behind the sappers' unfinished work.

What Command Knows

Mark the following on the players' map before the first run:

- The Allied trench along the southern edge
- The approximate position of Trench 19 near the northern edge
- One ruined road or drainage line pointing toward the enemy
- A broad area believed to contain mines
- A visible landmark such as a shattered chapel, dead tree, or burnt tank

Command does not know the safe routes, patrol schedule, usable shelter, precise wire layout, or the location of the trench's machine gun.

Recommended Supplies

Command recommends the following before the first outfitting:

- Wire cutters or a Bangalore section for the outer belts
- A mine probe, marking flags, or another way to identify a safe lane
- Field glasses for locating the trench's firing positions
- Smoke grenades or camouflage for crossing exposed ground
- Satchel charges for the wire, machine-gun position, or weak revetment
- A Far-range weapon for sentries and trench defenders
- Field dressings or a Butcher's field roll for recovery near the objective

This list is incomplete intelligence, not a required loadout. Place at least two useful pieces of salvage beyond the Allied line: one among an earlier unit's remains near the Approach and another in a dangerous cache or wreck within the Killing Ground. Anything brought back may be formally issued on a later run. The players should have to choose between carrying the ideal tool now and learning where another can be recovered later.

Drawing the Map

Use a roll of butcher paper, kraft paper, the blank back of wrapping paper, or paper with a **one-inch square grid**, plus a dark marker and a **ten-minute time limit**. The map should feel like an officer's hurried battlefield sketch, not a finished tactical diagram.

Draw a field **36 squares wide** and **84 squares long** for the introductory operation. A long roll can sit across or beside the table. If the available paper or table is smaller, tape sheets together or divide the field into connected Approach, Killing Ground, and Enemy Works sections while keeping one continuous coordinate system.

During the ten minutes:

1. Draw the Allied trench across the southern edge.
2. Draw Trench 19 across part of the northern edge.
3. Add three large landmarks visible from a distance.
4. Draw two broken routes from south to north: a road, drainage ditch, communications trench, ridge, or crater chain.
5. Add six to ten areas of difficult or exposed ground.
6. Add three to five pieces of artillery shelter, such as burnt tanks or deep ruins.
7. Leave open space. Unmarked ground gives the operation room to grow.

Do not try to detail every square. After the timer ends, secretly add the prepared obstacles, routes, and enemy positions below. Add further findings during play whenever exploration, retaliation, or player curiosity makes them relevant.

Prepared Features

Place these features secretly before play:

- **The wire:** Two belts guard Trench 19. One is obvious; the other is partly buried by mud.
- **The minefield:** It blocks the most direct route but contains one narrow, discoverable passage.
- **The machine gun:** It covers the obvious breach and one exposed approach.
- **The patrol:** It follows a repeatable route through the middle third of the map.
- **The shelter:** A burnt tank or deep cellar protects against artillery but contains evidence of an earlier unit.
- **The hidden approach:** A drainage cut, crater chain, or collapsed tunnel reaches the enemy wire with less exposure.
- **The reinforcement route:** A communications trench allows new defenders to reach Trench 19 between runs.
- **The signal position:** A visible point where the red flag can be raised.

The unit should be able to discover at least two viable approaches. No single failed check should make the objective impossible.

Discoveries

Reveal or invent discoveries as the sappers explore. Useful findings include:

- A marked gap in the minefield
- The patrol's route and timing
- A crater deep enough for field revival
- A corpse carrying cutters, explosives, or part of an old map
- A blind angle beneath the machine gun's traverse
- A culvert that passes under one wire belt
- A listening post connected to the enemy trench

- A weak revetment that can be collapsed
- A field telephone wire leading toward the reinforcement trench
- An abandoned ammunition cache that can be detonated

Every run should reveal something worth adding to the players' map, even when the unit gains little ground.

When the unit studies visible ground from safety, use Resistance 0. The basic result identifies the obvious feature; each success adds a useful detail such as a firing angle, recent track, sheltered approach, recoverable supply, or clue connecting two discoveries. Searching exposed ground, probing a suspected mine, or watching while a patrol can detect the unit remains Resistance 1 or higher and may retaliate on failure.

Enemy Forces

Use ordinary enemy soldiers from [Enemies and Monsters](#). Begin with enough defenders to make a frontal attack suicidal rather than impossible:

- One patrol of two soldiers, plus one additional soldier for a unit of five or six sappers
- Two sentries near the outer wire
- One machine-gun team in Trench 19
- Two trench defenders, plus one additional defender for every sapper beyond three

These numbers describe positions, not a balanced encounter. The unit should weaken, bypass, isolate, or surprise them across repeated runs.

Roll every enemy attack openly.

Enemy Reactions

After each run, choose one response the enemy could justify:

- Replace a destroyed patrol on the same route with altered timing
- Add a sentry to a route where sappers were seen
- Place bodies or abandoned equipment as bait
- Repair part of the wire while leaving visible evidence
- Aim the machine gun toward a revealed approach
- Mine a route the unit used repeatedly
- Move defenders from Trench 19 to protect the reinforcement trench

Permanent damage remains permanent. A destroyed machine gun, collapsed tunnel, cut reinforcement trench, or detonated ammunition cache is not restored unless the fiction gives the enemy time and means to restore it.

Taking Trench 19

Reaching the trench is not enough. The unit must create a breach, overcome or bypass the defenders, and spend an action raising the red flag at the signal position.

The flag must remain standing through the next enemy turn. The enemy may attack its bearer, cut it down, or attempt to reclaim the position. If the flag survives until the following sapper turn, Allied whistles answer from the southern trench and the operation succeeds.

Trench Interludes

Use brief scenes to show the operation changing the Allied trench:

- After the first run, a map clerk carefully copies the unit's marks while stretchers arrive behind them.
- After the first Battleborn transformation, nearby soldiers stop using the sapper's name.
- When the unit finds the hidden approach, an officer promises that thousands of lives now depend upon it.
- Before the final run, the Butchers have already laid out replacement parts beside empty tables.

- As cycles accumulate, fresh infantry fill the trench until the sappers must turn sideways to pass them.
- Gun crews sleep beside loaded pieces, waiting for coordinates and the red signal.
- A clerk repeatedly leaves the assault time blank while completing every other line of the order.

Further Complications

If the unit is progressing too easily, add one complication that follows from play:

- Artillery begins targeting the most-used route.
- A corpse hound starts following the unit's scent.
- Rain floods the hidden approach but exposes another entrance.
- An enemy sapper rebuilt from a player's former limb recognizes them.
- Trench 19 begins recovering and reviving its dead.

Do not add complications simply to erase success. Each should create another choice or reveal another route.

Debrief

Once the flag has remained standing through the enemy turn, Allied troops advance past whatever remains of the unit. Ask each surviving player:

- What part of the map will future soldiers know by their sapper's name?
- Which borrowed memory do they now mistake for their own?
- Do they still recognize the red flag as a sign of victory?

The war continues. This operation does not.

Next at the table: [Run Cycle Checklist](#) tracks the return and next run. For setting clues, read [Referee Lore Guide](#).

THE FRONT

The Long War

The Great War began in 1914. In every official calendar it is now 1951. Nobody at the front believes either number matters.

The opening years resemble the history old civilians still remember: mobilization, bright uniforms, cavalry dying beneath machine guns, and armies digging temporary trenches that became permanent borders. The promised breakthroughs never arrived. Governments fell without ending the war. New governments inherited the same trenches, renamed the same enemies, and conscripted another generation.

By 1951, western Europe is no longer a collection of recognizable nations. It is a belt of fortified states, military protectorates, ration territories, church administrations, and corpse-processing districts. Maps still carry old borders because printing new ones would imply that something had changed.

Thirty-Seven Years Without Peace

The Long War did not remain technologically frozen. Everything useful to civilian life became scarce while anything that could move soldiers, preserve bodies, or break fortifications advanced rapidly.

- Railways feed ammunition, animals, recruits, and donor meat directly to the front.
- Cities manufacture standardized weapons but cannot keep their streetlights burning.
- Chemical plants produce gas, embalming agents, stimulants, and reconstruction fluids instead of fertilizer.
- Telephones connect officers across hundreds of miles but ordinary families wait years for censored letters.
- Medicine can return the dead to service but cannot promise a painless birth or cure common disease.

The war did not consume society. Society was rebuilt to feed the war.

The Calcified Front

The Western Front has shifted only miles in decades. Some trenches have foundations, addresses, shrines, markets, schools, and cemeteries beneath their firing steps. Several have changed hands so often that their buried lower levels contain signs, bodies, and wiring from both sides.

Every captured trench is renamed. The old name survives in maintenance records, borrowed memories, and the mouths of enemy prisoners. A sapper may die defending a position their donor hand remembers constructing for the enemy.

Command measures success in yards, recovered equipment, and bodies denied to the opposing reconstruction workshops. Entire operations are fought to move an observation post far enough to see the next observation post.

The Home Front

Few sappers have seen a true civilian district recently. Behind the lines, rationing begins at birth. Children learn gas alarms before arithmetic. Recruitment sermons play over factory horns. Families receive notification not only of death but of reuse: a stamped form may state that a loved one's remains were retained for continued national service.

The state promises that sacrifice preserves everyone behind the trench. It rarely explains how little remains behind it.

Letters from home are valuable because they prove a home existed. They are also dangerous. Many contain phrases copied by censors, news about people the recipient no longer remembers, or handwriting recognized as a replacement hand rather than its owner.

What the Sappers Are Told

Every recruit is taught these facts:

1. The Allied line is the final barrier protecting human civilization.
2. The enemy began unlawful reconstruction and forced the Allies to answer in kind.
3. Revival returns the loyal dead to complete their duty.
4. The trenches of the hereafter await those permanently destroyed in service.
5. Victory remains possible if every soldier holds one day longer.

The first four claims contain useful pieces of truth. No living officer can prove the fifth.

Referee Truths

- Both sides describe themselves as the Allies and the opposing force as the enemy.
- Both sides claim the other discovered reconstruction first.
- Civilian authority survives mostly as a vocabulary used by military administrations.
- Nobody commanding the present war remembers a world before it.
- The front persists partly because reconstruction makes casualties sustainable and partly because institutions built for war cannot imagine surviving peace.

REVEAL, DO NOT LECTURE Reveal these truths through an enemy identification disc stamped **ALLIED**, a captured prayer identical to one spoken in the players' trench, or a map on which the unit's homeland is labeled occupied territory. [!NOTE] Related Records [The Allied Trench](#) · [No-Man's-Land](#) · [The Shifting Front](#) · [The Enemy](#)

Next setting record: [The Allied Trench](#).

The Allied Trench

The Allied trench is shelter, barracks, hospital, factory, church, prison, and slaughterhouse. It is the closest thing the sappers have to home, but that does not make it safe.

Physical Layers

An established trench has grown downward over decades.

Firing Level

The surface contains firing steps, observation slits, machine-gun nests, duckboards, ammunition lockers, and shallow shelters. Everything is wet, exposed, and repaired with whatever was available. Sandbags may contain earth, ash, hair, or rendered remains.



Sappers are seen planning an attack on an enemy bunker in the distance

Living Level

Below the firing line are bunks, kitchens, chapels, stores, signal offices, and command rooms. Privacy is created with blankets and rank. Lamps burn animal fat mixed with industrial oil. The trench smells of wet wool, disinfectant, cooked grain, cordite, and a sweeter odor coming from below.

Recovery Level

Corpse hounds enter through gated ramps. Bodies are tagged, stripped, washed, and sorted. Equipment goes one direction. Recoverable human material goes another. The dead wait on hooks or shelves until the [The Butchers](#) have space.

Deep Works

The oldest levels contain sealed galleries, abandoned chapels, failed workshops, cisterns, and tunnels that no current plan admits exist. Telephone crews sometimes hear conversations on disconnected wire. Butchers send assistants below for materials and refuse to say where the assistants found them.

A Day Without Days

The trench has no natural morning. Shifts change according to whistles, bells, and bombardment schedules.

- Reveille counts who can stand, not who is alive.
- Inspection checks weapons, respirators, identifying tags, and signs that borrowed parts have begun acting independently.
- Meals are served when supply arrives. Meat is uncommon and never identified.
- Services are held before major assaults and after incinerations.
- The names of the dead are read only after command confirms they cannot return.

Soldiers sleep through artillery but wake when it stops. Silence usually means an assault, gas, or that the listener has gone deaf.

People in the Trench

Use recurring figures sparingly. Familiar faces make later alteration matter.

- **The Map Clerk:** Copies player markings onto command maps and quietly preserves annotations that officers order erased.
- **The Quartermaster:** Knows which equipment returned without its bearer and which living weapons dislike particular sappers.
- **The Corpse-Hound Keeper:** Recognizes people by regimental scent after their faces cease to match. See [Corpse Hounds and Handlers](#).
- **The Chaplain:** Records original names in gold ink and battlefield names in black.
- **The Butcher's Assistant:** Is young enough to have been born after revival became ordinary.
- **The Replacement Officer:** Arrives with the same orders and voice as the previous officer but different hands.
- **The Trench Cook:** Remembers everyone's preferred meal even after they forget it themselves.

Give one of these figures a repeated habit. Later, transfer that habit to another body without explanation.

Discipline

The Allied trench is an authoritarian military settlement. Orders are law because hesitation can expose thousands of people to artillery. That justification is real, and it is used to excuse everything.

Deserters are executed, reconstructed, and sent out again when recoverable. Repeated refusal may result in removal of useful parts before execution. Officers call this reassignment of material.

Punishment should remain background unless the players force it forward. The objective is to make deployment feel coerced without turning every trench scene into an argument with command.

Short Trench Details

Choose one between runs:

1. A soldier practices a signature because their new hand writes another name.

2. A corpse hound scratches at a living sapper's bunk.
3. The soup contains a tooth bearing an gold filling.
4. Fresh uniforms are issued with old blood still inside the seams.
5. A child-sized respirator hangs above the chaplain's altar.
6. Two soldiers argue over which one owns the memory of the same wedding.
7. An officer's portrait has been altered to match their latest face.
8. A sealed recovery door knocks in the rhythm of the morning whistle.
9. The trench newspaper announces the capture of ground visible beyond the parapet in enemy hands.
10. A Butcher asks a sapper whether they still need a particular finger.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [187th Sappers Regiment](#) · [The Butchers](#) · [Faith of the Final Trench](#)

Next setting record: [187th Sappers Regiment](#).

187th Sapper Regiment

The **187th Allied Sapper Regiment** is formally titled the *Royal 187th Regiment for Penetration, Recovery, and Fortification*. Nobody uses the full title. Its soldiers call it the **One-Eighty-Seventh**, the **Buried Regiment**, or simply **the Returned**.

The regiment specializes in operations too unstable for ordinary infantry: crossing no-man's-land, clearing mines, destroying underground works, recovering bodies and intelligence, and occupying enemy trenches long enough for line units to advance.



***The 187th Allied Sapper Regiment** after capturing the ruins of [REDACTED]*

Regimental Reputation

Other soldiers respect the 187th because its sappers walk knowingly into places everyone else is ordered to avoid. They also distrust it. The regiment returns from total losses. Its veterans carry enemy reflexes, animal features, and knowledge they could not have learned while alive.

Line soldiers say a sapper is not truly part of the 187th until the corpse hounds have brought them home.

The Red Flag

The regiment's signal flag is a plain red field, chosen because it remains recognizable beneath mud, smoke, and blood. Raising it means a route has been opened and supporting troops may advance.

The red flag is not a national banner. It bears no crest because the regiment has served governments that no longer exist. Sappers sometimes write the names of permanently dead unit members along its hem. Officers forbid this, but rarely cut the names away.

Organization

The regiment is divided into sections of three to six sappers. A section is assembled around specialties rather than friendship or shared origin. In practice, repeated revival creates bonds command did not intend.

- **Privates** are new enough to receive recognizable equipment.
- **Corporals** have lost enough Humanity to operate advanced machinery and are expected to lead recoveries.
- **Sergeants** are issued living weapons and assigned objectives with low survival estimates.
- **Battleborn** remain on the rolls under battlefield names until permanent incineration.

Promotion follows degradation openly. Ceremonies are brief. The officer reads the new rank, the quartermaster unlocks another cage, and a clerk crosses out the old equipment allowance.

Regimental Customs

- **The First Mark:** After a sapper's first revival, the rest of the section marks the place of death on the shared map, even if it has no tactical value.



A recruit of the 187th after his first revival, note the slightly longer left arm

- **Counting Back:** Before deployment, each sapper says the last thing they remember before their previous death. Anyone who cannot answer is watched closely.
- **The Empty Bunk:** A permanently dead sapper's bunk remains unused until the operation ends.
- **Borrowed Salute:** A sapper whose right arm has been replaced may salute with the left so nobody mistakes the gesture for a donor reflex.
- **Red Thread:** Before a Burn-Listed sapper deploys, the unit ties red thread around every reconstructed limb. Corpse hounds are trained to follow it through ash and phosphorus residue.

Command

The current regimental commander is identified in orders only as **Colonel Vale**. Soldiers disagree about Vale's sex, age, voice, and whether the Colonel has ever appeared above the Deep Works. Every witness remembers a gold mask with sharp bone teeth.

Section officers are replaceable. Orders are not. If an officer dies, a successor reads the same briefing from the same folder, sometimes before the body is cold.

Referee Use

PRESENTING THE 187TH The regiment should feel like both a family and an institution consuming that family. Let trench personnel remember the sappers' habits, mourn their disappearing identities, and still hand them the next set of orders. When the players need motivation, connect the objective to recognizable people in the trench. When they need horror, show that command values the route, equipment, and accumulated skill more than the people who carry them. [! NOTE] Related Records [The Allied Trench](#) · [The First Sappers](#) · [Field Doctrines](#)

Next setting record: [No-Man's-Land](#).

No-Man's-Land

No-man's-land is not empty ground between two armies. It is thirty-seven years of war compacted into mud.

Villages, forests, farms, roads, cemeteries, and earlier trenches lie beneath its surface. Shelling repeatedly buries and exposes them. A crater may cut through a kitchen, a medieval grave, three uniforms from different decades, and a living cable grown around all of them.

The battlefield's larger movements and the places it excavates are detailed in [The Shifting Front](#).

The Ground

The upper soil is ash, powdered masonry, rust, bone, chemical residue, and human fat. Rain turns it adhesive. Heat seals it into black plates. In cold weather, fingers and faces emerge from frozen walls as though the earth is trying to remember its contents.

NOTHING IS MERELY SCENERY Nothing remains dead reliably. This does not mean every corpse rises. It means the referee should never treat a pile of remains as inert scenery.

Regions

Worked Ground

The approach nearest a trench is watched, shelled, wired, and repeatedly crossed. It contains marked routes, false markers, listening posts, corpse-hound tracks, and the remains of soldiers who almost returned.

Deep Mud

Drainage has failed. Bodies descend slowly and return in pieces after rain. Movement leaves obvious tracks. Black Matter often collects beneath the water's surface in shapes resembling open eyes.

Ruin Fields

Buildings survive as cellars, walls, pipes, and domestic objects stripped of context. A teacup or child's shoe can make the battlefield more horrifying than another mound of bodies because it proves ordinary life occupied the same ground.



Unrecognizable ruins beyond trench 19

Burnt foundations also leave hollows beneath the soil: connected cellars, drains, sewers, and gaps between collapsed floors. These routes can carry a unit beneath wire and observed ground, but also collect gas, floodwater, buried mines, unremoved bodies, and things that learned to live beyond the reach of shellfire.

Flesh Wastes

Repeated reconstruction, mass death, and Black Matter have made the earth assemble whatever it contains. Hair grows across puddles. Teeth form in wooden beams. Telephone wire develops a pulse. Monsters arise here as battlefield processes rather than species.



Black Matter being harvested from a hastily erected shelter in No-Man's-Land

Quiet Ground

Some areas receive no artillery and contain no patrols. Animals avoid them. Compasses turn toward their centers. The silence is more dangerous than shelling because both armies have independently decided tread lightly.

Weather

Weather should change what the map means.

- **Rain** fills craters, exposes Black Matter, and moves bodies downhill.
- **Fog** prevents distant attacks and allows voices to approach unseen.
- **Heat** swells corpses and wakes living equipment.
- **Cold** preserves routes and bodies but makes donor parts stiff or wakeful.
- **Black snow** is ash from mass incineration. Some flakes contain legible fragments of identification documents and photos of unknown people.

Sensory Language

Use two or three senses, then stop.

- The click of cooling wire after a shell burst
- Mud pulling at boots with the rhythm of breathing
- Sweet disinfectant drifting from an unseen workshop
- Warm rain collecting inside a helmet

- A telephone ringing beneath several feet of earth
- The taste of metal before artillery lands
- Horsehair growing from the cut surface of a sandbag
- A familiar hand visible where no body should be

Avoid constant escalation. Alternate explicit bodily horror with absences, domestic remnants, and patterns that imply intention.

Things Found in the Mud

1. An Allied corpse with tomorrow's date on its tag
2. A dry letter addressed to one of the sappers under a false name
3. A mine marked safe in the player's own handwriting
4. A living enemy hand still gripping a field telephone
5. A child's wooden horse repaired with human teeth
6. A corpse whose every replacement came from the same unknown donor
7. A field kitchen serving nobody, its stove still warm
8. A buried observation slit looking upward from beneath the unit
9. Red thread tied around bones too old to belong to the 187th
10. A route marker that turns to face the unit after they pass

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [The Shifting Front](#) · [Retaliation Tables](#) · [Enemies and Monsters](#) · [Stationary Defenses](#)

Next setting record: [The Shifting Front](#).

The Shifting Front

The Front is called fixed because communiqués measure it from far away. At ground level it never holds still.

Trenches advance, collapse, and are dug again. Artillery moves ridgelines one crater at a time. Rain carries whole revetments downhill. A position may remain under the same designation for twenty years while every wall, approach, body, and firing step around it is replaced.

The Front also moves vertically. Thirty-seven years of shelling have buried villages beneath spoil, driven roads under mud, and stacked new defenses over old ones. Another bombardment cuts down through those layers. A cellar sealed in 1916 opens beneath a crater in 1951. A trench wall sloughs away and exposes the upper windows of a house everyone believed flattened. The battlefield does not discover new ground. It remembers what was put underneath.

How the Ground Moves

Changes should have visible causes. The Front shifts through:

- **Bombardment:** Shells destroy cover, open craters, expose buried structures, and collapse tunnels into one another.
- **Sapper work:** Both armies excavate galleries, drainage channels, mines, countermines, and reinforcement trenches throughout the night.
- **Weather:** Rain floods low ground, carries bodies and equipment, strips soil from masonry, and fills yesterday's routes with mud.
- **Occupation:** An advance turns old enemy works into Allied positions. A retreat abandons kitchens, hospitals, depots, prisoners, and unfinished repairs.
- **Reconstruction:** Corpse routes, donor pits, Black Matter seams, and living fortifications alter soil that has absorbed too many rebuilt bodies.
- **Weight:** Tanks, guns, marching formations, and repeated detonations break roofs and streets that still exist beneath the surface.

A shift may happen during a run, between runs, or between operations. During a run, show the immediate cause and let the sappers react. Between runs, mark the change before deployment through artillery reports, aerial photographs, survivor testimony, or what can be seen from the Allied parapet.

Buried Towns

Most towns on military maps no longer resemble settlements. Their names identify sectors, artillery coordinates, and burial grounds. The buildings survive below the violence in disconnected pieces:

- Cellars joined by shell holes and later military tunnels
- Ground floors buried until their windows become doors
- Churches reduced to towers, crypts, bells, and lines of foundation stone
- Factories whose boilers, belts, and rail spurs remain under collapsed roofs
- Schools used successively as hospitals, barracks, butcheries, and ammunition stores
- Sewers and wells that connect positions belonging to both armies
- Rows of houses preserved as scorched partitions with no exterior walls
- Civic shelters still bearing names that do not appear in military records

When one of these places emerges, retain its domestic purpose. A kitchen is more than cover. It has hooks, plates, a stove, a family tally cut into a doorframe, and thirty years of soldiers using it for something else. The horror comes from recognizing what the fortification used to be.

The people who lived there may be dead, displaced, incorporated into military institutions, or still below. Do not make every buried room contain a monster. Empty beds, carefully stored shoes, dry account books, and a hand-painted shop sign can carry the weight of the missing population without explanation.

Burnt-Out Husks

Fire rarely removes a building cleanly. It leaves iron frames, brick shells, fused glass, carbonized beams, and rooms opened like diagrams. Later armies reinforce those remains because anything still standing has already survived something.

A burnt husk can provide:

- Artillery shelter behind thick machinery or cellar walls
- A high observation point that silhouettes anyone using it
- A route through adjoining basements or broken service tunnels
- Materials for braces, traps, fires, repairs, and field revival
- Evidence of an older occupation or atrocity
- A landmark visible from several parts of the map
- A defensible position already registered by enemy guns
- A structure whose heat, ash, or dead occupants never behaved correctly afterward

Make its value double-edged. The factory boiler stops fragments but carries voices through its pipes. The church tower gives a clear view and can be seen by every observer in the sector. The cellar offers a hidden route but contains the bodies of everyone who once trusted it.

The Hollows Beneath the Ruins

Burnt buildings often leave more below the soil than above it. Fire consumes floors, joists, doors, and furniture while foundations, cellar arches, drains, retaining walls, and street-level masonry remain. Later shelling throws earth and rubble across the surviving structure without filling every room. The result is a chain of compressed voids beneath no-man's-land: gaps between collapsed floors, half-filled cellars, buried alleys, sewers, culverts, coal chutes, and rooms connected by holes blasted through adjoining walls.

Sappers call these routes **hollows**. A hollow may run beneath wire, pass under a registered firing lane, or connect two buildings whose visible ruins appear isolated. Some are only wide enough for a crawling body. Others contain whole streets beneath roofs made from compacted soil, wreckage, and the weight of later fortifications.



A captured enemy hollow, a fallen sapper awaits revival at the entrance

Signs of a hollow include:

- Mud sinking in a straight line where a cellar row continues below
- Warm, chemical, or sweet air breathing through cracked masonry
- Rainwater vanishing beneath rubble without forming a pool
- Boots, tracks, blood, or telephone wire disappearing into an apparent dead end
- A hollow sound beneath a rifle butt, probe, or careful footstep
- Brick dust in a fresh crater where no building remains on current maps
- Smoke or voices emerging from a drain far from their source
- A wall, stair rail, chimney, or length of pipe descending into solid earth

AT THE TABLE Use [Changing Ground](#) for hollow travel, map changes, and the table of newly exposed locations. This dossier describes what the sappers see and what those places have become.

What Waits Below

The earth beneath the Front has been protected from daylight, not from war.

- **Bad air:** Gas, smoke, rot, and oxygenless pockets settle in low chambers. Dead candles, tarnished metal, insects, and animal bodies should warn the unit before breathing becomes a check.
- **Water:** Flooded rooms conceal shafts, wire, bodies, and currents leading toward deeper breaks. A route may remain passable only while pumps elsewhere continue working.
- **Unstable weight:** Soil, tanks, guns, and newer trenches rest on damaged arches. Cracks, falling grit, bowed brick, and sounds from above announce a collapse before it kills.

- **Old works:** Mines, countermines, demolition charges, and listening galleries from forgotten offensives remain connected to civilian foundations. Their markings may belong to either army or neither current language.
- **Occupants:** Enemy sappers, deserters, corpse-recovery teams, and things avoiding both armies use the same protected routes. Signs of habitation should appear before contact.
- **The unremoved dead:** Cellars served as shelters, hospitals, execution rooms, and donor stores. Bodies may block a passage, reinforce a wall, or remember enough movement to follow the living.
- **Black Matter:** Seams collect below groundwater and around mass reconstruction sites. Roots, wire, teeth, and borrowed nerves grow more freely where shellfire does not burn them away.
- **Lost direction:** Sound travels through pipes and joined masonry. Compasses turn toward Black Matter. A sapper may hear the unit ahead, behind, and inside the wall at once.

The sappers may prefer the dark below because shellfire cannot reach it. The signs of what waits there should make that choice costly, never blind.

What the Shift Means

The moving Front prevents either army from owning the ground completely. A trench can be captured, renamed, reinforced, and lost while the town beneath it continues to surface room by room. Soldiers defend ruins belonging to people their governments no longer acknowledge. Sappers navigate yesterday's enemy works using memories from bodies recovered there decades earlier.

Command treats every emergence as terrain, salvage, or intelligence. The sappers are close enough to see that it was once a place where people expected tomorrow to resemble today.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [No-Man's-Land](#) · [The Long War](#) · [Mission Construction](#) · [Referee Lore Guide](#)

Next setting record: [The First Sappers](#).

The First Sappers

Official history says twelve Allied engineers crossed the wire in October 1916, captured an enemy reconstruction laboratory, and returned with the documents that became [Project Eisensee](#). Their sacrifice ended the enemy's monopoly on resurrection and saved the Allied cause.

The official history is printed on recruitment posters. The surviving records are less clean.

The Resonance Raid

For several weeks in 1916, Allied observation posts reported the same enemy assault troops dying in daylight and returning before dawn. Artillery photographs showed bodies moving toward the enemy trench after bombardments. Telephone operators heard dead Allied soldiers speaking on enemy lines.

A sapper section was ordered to enter a buried structure beneath a ruined village and capture proof. Their names were later removed from the record and replaced by numbers One through Twelve.

The raid lasted eight days. Supply records show no food or ammunition delivered after the first night. Recovery logs claim seventeen Allied bodies returned.

What They Brought Back

The First Sappers returned with:

- Surgical diagrams written in several languages and one unknown notation
- Glass ampoules containing Black Matter
- A captured technician who died repeatedly during interrogation
- A field telephone that rang when placed beside a corpse
- Seventeen sealed lead cases, although the departure inventory lists twelve
- Enough procedural knowledge to perform the first Allied revival

They did not return with an explanation.

The First Allied Revival

The first official subject was Sapper Number Four, killed during the return crossing. The procedure restored breathing, movement, speech, and detailed military memory. Number Four correctly identified every member of the section.

Number Four also greeted three corpses by name. Those names appear nowhere in the departure record.

Within months, small reconstruction workshops operated along the front. Within a year, recovery doctrine treated bodies as strategic material. The surviving First Sappers became instructors, research subjects, saints, or sealed records depending on which archive is consulted.



Sapper number Four, as seen moving out into No-Man's-Land shortly after returning

Contradictory Fates

Choose one account as true for an operation or let several remain possible:

1. All twelve eventually became the first Allied Battleborn and are entombed beneath the 187th's trench.
2. Only one person returned; the other bodies were copies carrying divided pieces of the same mind.
3. The captured enemy technician joined the section and invented the numbered identities to conceal it.
4. Colonel Vale is Number Four after hundreds of reconstructions.
5. The First Sappers never captured Project Eisenseele. Something below the village taught them how to make more bodies for it.
6. Every modern revival briefly passes through the memory of one First Sapper who never returned at all.

Relics

First Sapper relics make useful operation hooks:

- A numbered identification disc that becomes warm near Black Matter
- An original map with trenches that do not exist yet
- A field notebook in the handwriting of a current sapper
- A preserved hand that points toward unrecovered bodies
- A sealed order naming the 187th decades before its formation
- A red flag made from an unknown uniform

Never settle every contradiction. The horror lies in the fact that revival works reliably while its origin remains fundamentally untrustworthy.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [Project Eisensee](#) · [187th Sappers Regiment](#) · [The Butchers](#)

Next setting record: [Project Eisensee](#).

Project Eisensee

Eisensee is usually translated as **Iron Soul**. The name refers at once to the captured enemy research, the Allied reconstruction program built from it, and the material process that allows dead tissue to return.

No single living person understands the entire project. Surgeons know procedures. Engineers know apparatus. Chaplains know rites. Handlers know how to calm living equipment. Each group believes the others have mistaken superstition for science.

What Is Known

Reconstruction requires four things:

1. **Recoverable structure:** Enough body remains to establish a pattern, although the required amount decreases with experience and Black Matter exposure.
2. **Donor material:** Human, animal, cultivated, or recovered tissue replaces what was destroyed.
3. **Resonance:** The dead body must be exposed to a patterned combination of current, pressure, sound, and memory.
4. **Black Matter:** Even when none is visibly implanted, trace amounts appear in every successful reconstruction.

The result returns with the subject's military skills, much of their memory, and an increasing collection of donor impulses. Repeated revival improves useful performance while degrading personal identity.

Black Matter

Black Matter resembles wet soot suspended in clear oil. It gathers into branching veins when near dead tissue and becomes still around open flame. Under magnification it forms shapes resembling trenches viewed from above.

It cannot be reliably manufactured. It is harvested from old reconstruction sites, deep corpse pits, failed living weapons, and seams beneath no-man's-land. The more it is used in one location, the more frequently that location produces spontaneous movement in dead material.



Black Matter being harvested from [[No-Man's-Land]]

The Other Side

Revived sappers report an interval between death and return. Most remember only darkness, pressure, and distant artillery. Repeatedly revived sappers describe an endless trench network beneath a lightless sky.

Common details include:

- the dead are present, but not aware.
- Shells rise from the ground into the sky.
- Voices travel through walls and telephone wire.
- Something stalks the dead, one trench beyond sight.
- A light appears only when a living person begins revival.
- Some dead resist that light because returning means forgetting more.

Chaplains call this place the Final Trench. Engineers call it residual cognition. Butchers rarely name it.

Three Explanations

KEEP THE ANSWER UNSTABLE The referee may favor one explanation without confirming it. Evidence should support several readings even when one is privately treated as true.

Resonance Theory

Identity is a physical pattern retained by nervous tissue and surrounding matter. Reconstruction catches enough of that pattern to restart the person. Borrowed memories are contamination.

Final-Trench Doctrine

The dead continue beneath the world. Revival opens a path and calls one of them back, but the wrong soul may follow parts of the body through.

Cultivation Theory

Black Matter does not return anyone. It grows a useful continuation from remains and memories, improving the imitation each time while consuming the original.

All three predict the observed results. None can prove the person who wakes is the person who died.

Project Sites

Eisenseele facilities may appear as:

- Tiled surgical works connected to corpse railways
- Resonance chambers lined with telephone receivers
- Black Matter wells beneath ruined churches
- Equipment nurseries where weapons grow around donor skeletons
- Archives of removed memories stored on wax cylinders
- Incineration halls built beside revival rooms

The project is not a secret. Its details are compartmentalized because no institution wants its soldiers asking questions.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [The First Sappers](#) · [The Butchers](#) · [Faith of the Final Trench](#)

Next setting record: [The Butchers](#).

The Butchers

Butchers are the reconstruction surgeons of the Allied forces. Their title began as trench slang and became an official rank after no cleaner word remained credible.

Their workshops resemble abattoirs built inside chapels. Bodies hang from numbered hooks. Donor limbs rest in brine or twitch beneath damp cloth. Tiled channels carry blood and Black Matter toward separate drains, although both pipes disappear into the same lower wall.

Appearance

Butchers wear waxed aprons over surgical gowns that were once white. Senior Butchers adopt the gold vestments of the Faith of the Final Trench, marking their claimed authority over the border between life and death. Their tools are kept immaculate even when everything around them is black with old blood.

Many replace their own fingers with narrow jointed instruments. This is presented as professional devotion. Assistants whisper that natural hands eventually begin remembering too many patients.

The Workshop

A typical workshop contains:

- Intake hooks labeled with unit, rank, and estimated Humanity
- A donor wall divided into human, animal, enemy, and uncertain material
- Resonance coils connected to field telephones
- Bone saws, pressure pumps, stitching frames, and memory cylinders
- A black-glass cistern that is never shown empty
- Incineration doors for contaminated tissue and permanently dead Battleborn
- A curtained gallery from which chaplains and officers observe

The workshop never becomes quiet. Pumps breathe. Teeth chatter in trays. Telephones ring without being answered. Something heavy moves in the donor wall when artillery lands.



A Butcher seen in the shrouded trenches behind friendly lines

The Butcher's Work

Butchers do not restore a body to its original state. They make it capable of returning to duty. Their priorities are:

1. Recover military memory and useful reflexes.
2. Build enough structure to survive deployment.
3. Integrate available donor material.
4. Preserve personal identity when it does not interfere with the first three priorities.

A Butcher may be compassionate and still follow this order.

During reconstruction, the dead are not always unconscious. Muscle can react before identity returns. Donor parts may recognize a voice, resist a cut, or attempt a gesture from their previous life. Butchers restrain these movements without comment.

The Price of Expertise

Every Butcher has witnessed thousands of people return incorrectly. They develop habits to remain functional:

- Referring to bodies by hook number until the patient speaks
- Never asking donor material where it came from
- Covering mirrors before facial reconstruction
- Humming over the sound of the other side
- Keeping one glove on even while sleeping

- Recording impossible memories as equipment faults

Some Butchers believe they are saving lives. Some believe they are maintaining weapons. The most frightening can no longer distinguish the two.

Butchers and Sappers

A sapper depends on their Butcher and has every reason to fear them. The Butcher remembers bodies better than their owners do. They can identify an old rib beneath new skin, recognize which enemy supplied a hand, or casually mention that a heart has served in three different regiments.

Use a recurring Butcher to make revival personal. Give them one boundary they will not cross, then place the operation in a situation that pressures it.

Possible boundaries:

- Will not mix enemy brain tissue with an Allied face
- Will not revive anyone who asked for permanent death
- Will not open the sealed donor chamber below the workshop
- Will not perform a fourth reconstruction on the same skull
- Will not answer a field telephone during surgery

Workshop Details

1. A tray of eyes turns toward the sapper whose body enters.
2. The Butcher recognizes a donor limb as their own former arm.
3. An assistant asks the dead sapper to confirm their name before the mouth is attached.
4. A gold-robed chaplain apologizes to the donor rather than the patient.
5. The saw stops when a disconnected telephone rings.
6. A corpse on the next table wakes with the sapper's childhood memory.
7. The Butcher removes an object from the chest that does not appear on any anatomical chart.
8. A labeled jar contains the identifying mark the player just obscured.
9. The replacement part grips the table hard enough to crack it.
10. The Butcher says, "This has rejected you before," though the sapper has never seen it.

The mechanical procedure for reconstruction is in [Death and Revival](#).

■ RELATED RECORDS [Death and Revival](#) · [Replacements and Memories](#) · [Borrowed Memories](#) · [Project Eisensee](#)

Next setting record: [Corpse Hounds and Handlers](#).

Corpse Hounds and Their Handlers

The Allied trench does not leave recovery entirely to soldiers. When a unit fails to return, the gates beneath the rear line open and the **corpse hounds** are led into no-man's-land.

They are not dogs, though most began with dogs somewhere in their ancestry. A corpse hound is a low, broad recovery animal rebuilt to cross wire, flooded shell holes, collapsed trenches, and ground still moving under bombardment. Its ribs are reinforced into a carrying frame. Its jaw can close around cloth, webbing, bone, or a recovery tag without crushing what it holds. Beneath layers of scar and oilcloth, its nose has been divided into wet chambers that sort blood, Black Matter, regimental chemicals, and the fading trace the Butchers call **continuity**.

Handlers use a simpler word.

Self.



Recovery stock awaiting deployment

What the Hounds Find

Every recruit is scented before receiving a rifle. A clerk takes blood, hair, breath condensed against cold glass, and a thumbprint pressed into rendered fat. The samples are sealed in a regimental scent ledger. Before a recovery, the handler lets the hound smell the appropriate page.

A corpse hound can follow more than blood. It can distinguish one sapper's remains from the bodies packed around them, recognize a repeatedly rebuilt sapper beneath donor flesh, and track pieces separated by shellfire. The oldest hounds sometimes identify a sapper whose scent page has been destroyed.

Nobody agrees on how.

The handlers insist the animals remember the regiment. The Butchers claim continuity leaves a measurable residue in living tissue. Chaplains say the hounds smell the portion of the soul that has not yet understood it is dead.

All three explanations have led hounds to the same body.

Recovery Harness

A working hound wears a leather-and-canvas harness fitted with:

- **Retrieval hooks** for webbing, coats, and bodies too damaged to grip safely.
- **Scent tins** containing the unit's regimental samples and articles taken from individual bunks.
- **Red thread reels** used to mark a route back through disturbed ground.
- **Brass tally tags** for each body named in the recovery order.
- **A hood and bite bar** for restraining the hound when donor memories overwhelm its training.
- **One sealed phosphorus charge** for remains that cannot be permitted to return.

The last item is carried under the handler's seal. Its presence is never discussed during the briefing.

Corpse hounds do not drag bodies like dead weight when there is time. They pull a torso onto the reinforced back, gather loose pieces into the rib harness, and carry the remains with a care that appears almost tender. When hurried, they take whatever purchase they can and run.

The Handler

A **handler** is part tracker, part kennel keeper, part mortuary clerk. Most are former stretcher-bearers, failed Butcher apprentices, or sappers no longer able to cross the open ground at unit pace. They learn scent preparation, battlefield navigation, restraint procedures, and enough anatomy to decide which pieces must come home.

Handlers carry no rank that line infantry recognizes. In the recovery yard, however, their orders override officers. A colonel may demand that a body be brought back. Only the handler decides whether the thing at the end of the lead is still that body.

Good handlers speak to their hounds constantly. They name landmarks, read the recovery roll aloud, and describe the person being sought:

Private Vale. Left-handed. Coal smoke in the lungs. Afraid of horses. Returned twice.

This is partly training. It is also a precaution. Hounds exposed to too many dead memories begin answering to names that were never theirs.

Handlers are taught five standing rules:

1. **Trust the nose before the face.** Reconstruction makes appearance unreliable.
2. **Count the tags before returning.** A hound may bring back more than it was sent to find.
3. **Never follow a silent hound underground.** Make it bark first. Listen for an answer.
4. **Do not let two hounds divide the same body.** They may disagree about which pieces contain the sapper.
5. **If the hound recognizes you as dead, report to the Butchers before sleeping.**

The Bond

A handler and hound are paired until one of them can no longer work. The hound learns the handler's gait, pulse, fear, and buried memories. The handler learns which whine means artillery, which means Black Matter, and which means the trail continues beneath the soil.

The relationship is affectionate, but never safe. A hound may protect its handler from shellfire and later attempt to open the handler's chest because it smells a familiar donor organ inside. Handlers sleep beyond the kennel bars. They place a worn glove beneath the hound's muzzle so it remembers whom not to retrieve.

When a handler dies, the hound is sent to find the body. If it returns with the correct remains, the handler may be revived and the pairing continues. If it refuses the scent, kennel doctrine records the handler as **disputed**. Disputed bodies go to a separate table in the Deep Works.

When a hound dies, its usable parts enter the same repair stores as everything else. Handlers are not permitted to request them. They frequently recognize them later.

A Recovery in No-Man's-Land

Recovery teams usually move after bombardment, when smoke hides them and fresh craters have broken the established paths. A team consists of one handler, one or two hounds, and sometimes a sapper escort. The handler does not search the whole battlefield. They follow a sequence:

1. Give the hound the sapper's scent and show it the last confirmed position on the unit map.
2. Follow until the hound indicates **blood**, **continuity**, or **wrongness**. Each signal uses a different posture and lead tension.
3. Mark hazards and recoverable routes as the hound exposes them.
4. Confirm the remains with tags, equipment, anatomy, remembered wounds, and the hound's response.
5. Gather enough of the sapper for the Butchers to establish identity.
6. Follow the red thread home before artillery or scavengers close the route.

The hound may find the body quickly. Getting it back is the operation.

When Recovery Goes Wrong

Corpse hounds fail in ways instruments do not:

- The hound finds several bodies carrying pieces of the same sapper.
- A buried structure contains the scent, but something inside has learned to imitate the hound's recall whistle.
- The hound refuses a recognizable corpse and leads the handler toward a living soldier.
- Enemy handlers have crossed the trail with captured Allied blood.
- The remains stand, crawl, or call the hound by its kennel name.
- The hound returns alone with every tally tag removed and one unfamiliar tag tied beneath its tongue.
- A recovered sapper wakes in the harness before reaching the trench and begs not to be taken to the Butchers.

Do not use every failed recovery to deny revival. Most hounds perform their work. Their horror comes from how routinely the trench depends on them and from the rare moment when an animal trained to recognize a person decides that person is no longer present.

Allied, Enemy, and Feral Hounds

Allied corpse hounds recognize regiment scent and normally ignore living sappers unless commanded, threatened, or confused by donor tissue.

Enemy recovery animals perform the same military function under different handling doctrine. Some retrieve Allied bodies for study. Others have been trained to separate useful anatomy in the field.

Feral corpse hounds are lost, abandoned, or handlerless animals whose recovery commands never ended. They follow the dead, collect bodies, and assemble caches in dugouts or shell holes. A feral hound is not automatically hostile. It may attempt to return a fallen sapper to a trench that no longer exists.

See [Feral Corpse Hound](#) for its battlefield profile.

Referee Use

PRESENTING A RECOVERY Use corpse hounds to make recovery visible, uncertain, and personal. The hound may find the body quickly. Getting it home should create the pressure.

- Before a run, let a handler scent the unit and ask one sapper for an article from their bunk.
- After a failed operation, describe what the hounds had to cross and what they brought back with the body.
- Let tracks, red thread, kennel whistles, and tally tags warn the unit that another recovery team is nearby.
- When a sapper is left behind, keep their location on the map and reveal the hound's approach one finding at a time.
- Let a hound recognize a heavily reconstructed sapper when friends or records do not.
- Reserve hostile hounds for broken doctrine, enemy action, or a recovery instinct turned inside out.

THE HANDLER IS AN ALLY The handler should usually be a cooperative presence. They want the sappers home, know routes command has ignored, and understand that a body may still be a person. Their limits create the horror: they cannot stop the shelling, cannot overrule a Burn order, and cannot promise that everything the hound retrieves should be revived. [!tip] **A Voice for the Handler** Speak plainly and use names. A handler has seen too much anatomy to be impressed by gore. What unsettles them is uncertainty: a scent that divides, a body that remembers the wrong kennel, or a hound wagging its tail for someone officially dead. [!note] **Related Records** [Death and Revival](#) · [The Allied Trench](#) · [The Butchers](#) · [187th Sappers Regiment](#)

Next setting record: [Faith of the Final Trench](#).

Faith of the Final Trench

The churches of the prewar world did not survive unchanged. Their buildings became hospitals, recruitment halls, corpse depots, and artillery landmarks. Their languages and symbols were absorbed into the state doctrine now called the **Faith of the Final Trench**.

The Faith teaches that the world above is only the forward line of a greater war. The worthy dead continue serving in trenches beneath creation until final victory. Revival is therefore not resurrection but temporary reassignment.

Common Teachings

- Pain proves the soul remains in tattered flesh.
- Borrowed parts are reinforcements sent by the honored dead.
- Forgotten memories have been transferred to the Final Trench for safekeeping.
- Battleborn stand with one foot in each battlefield.
- Incineration releases a loyal soul from further earthly duty.

These teachings make reconstruction bearable and military losses sacred. They also make refusal a form of spiritual treason.

Chaplains

Chaplains wear gold because it is the color believed visible from the other side. Their vestments are cut to fit over armor and replacement limbs. They witness Butcher procedures, preserve original names, carve living weapons, and decide whether a speaking reconstruction is actually an ally.

Some chaplains are sincere comforts in an unbearable system. Others are political officers with censers. Most are blood soaked and distant.

Rites

Before a Run

The chaplain touches the red flag to every sapper and says, “Return by the road you make.” The unit answers, “Light it behind us.”

Before Reconstruction

The original name is spoken three times: once to the body, once to the donor material, and once into a field telephone. If the telephone answers, the Butcher tenses.

Permanent Death

The dead sapper's remaining name is written on flash paper and burned. Sometimes the flame burns black, the Chaplains do not mention that name again.

Heresies

- **The Empty Return:** The belief that revival produces a new being and the original remains trapped below.
- **The Merciful Flame:** Secret groups who incinerate recoverable bodies to spare them further service.
- **The One Soul:** The claim that every revived soldier contains fragments of a single vast dead consciousness.
- **The Peace Below:** The forbidden teaching that the Final Trench contained no war until we brought it there.

Any of these beliefs can motivate an NPC without being objectively correct.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [Project Eisensee](#) · [The First Sappers](#) · [The Butchers](#)

Next setting record: The Enemy.

The Enemy

Allied doctrine refers to opposing soldiers only as **the enemy**. National names are absent from briefings. Captured maps are translated before sappers see them. Prisoners are numbered, masked, and removed quickly.

This is presented as operational security.

What Sappers See

Enemy soldiers wear unfamiliar respirators, layered armor, and uniforms faded into the same mud as Allied cloth. Their weapons are different enough to be threatening and similar enough to operate without instruction. Their reconstructed veterans display animal grafts, borrowed Allied parts, and living equipment shaped by another surgical tradition.

They recover their dead. They mark routes. They send sappers through no-man's-land. When a Battleborn becomes Burn-Listed, they send white-coated sections with restraint hooks and phosphorus.

The enemy should be frightening because it is capable and prepared, not because every soldier is a monster.

What Command Says

- The enemy began the Long War.
- The enemy has no civilian population, only breeding districts.
- Enemy revival produces obedient copies without souls.
- Enemy soldiers cannot surrender sincerely.
- Their language contains no word for peace.

Captured evidence contradicts all five claims.

Referee Truth

The enemy is another fortified coalition held together by conscription, state religion, and fear of Allied invasion. Its soldiers receive almost identical instruction about the Allies. They call themselves defenders. Their reconstruction program descends from the same Eisensee procedures.

This does not make them harmless. Enemy officers protect their trench with the same calculated brutality Allied command uses. Human similarity should complicate the horror, not remove danger.

Revealing the Mirror

Use small evidence rather than speeches:

- An enemy family photograph posed before a familiar monument
- A prayer translated word for word into the Allied burial rite
- A ration tin manufactured in a supposedly Allied city
- An enemy sapper carrying a grease-pencil map covered in death marks
- A replacement hand that salutes an enemy officer automatically
- A prisoner terrified that Allied Butchers will steal their memories
- An enemy red signal flag with names written along its hem
- Orders referring to the players as corpse-thieves and soulless copies

Do not require the players to sympathize or negotiate. The discovery should make killing intimate and propaganda unstable.

Enemy Reconstruction

Enemy reconstruction tends to be more visibly integrated with equipment. Respirators may be grafted into lungs, rifles grown along forearms, and signal wire threaded through the spine. Allied observers call this proof of enemy inhumanity. Enemy observers describe Allied patchwork bodies as uncontrolled contamination.

When the enemy recovers an Allied body, choose a purpose:

- Study its memories and learned routes
- Use recognizable parts to bait the unit
- Rebuild it as a prisoner or infiltrator
- Incorporate useful tissue into an enemy veteran
- Burn it to deny Allied recovery
- Return it deliberately with a message stitched inside

Keeping the Enemy Unnamed

Players may learn personal names, unit numbers, and local words. The larger coalition can remain unnamed. No single label can contain thirty-seven years of collapsed nations and merged commands.

If the players demand a proper name, give them several mutually incompatible names from maps, prisoners, sermons, and old documents. Every faction believes its own name means the Allied Defense.

■ **RELATED RECORDS** [The Long War](#) · [Enemies and Monsters](#) · [Stationary Defenses](#) · [Project Eisensee](#)

End of the setting route. [Return to the reading routes](#) or use [Referee Lore Guide](#) to put these revelations into play.

THREATS AND FORTIFICATIONS

Enemy Forces and Battlefield Horrors

Resolve these profiles using [Combat and Movement](#). Use [Stationary Defenses](#) for protected emplacements and fixed living weapons.

No-man's-land contains enemy soldiers, reconstructed veterans, living weapons, and things assembled by accident from everything the war left unburied.

The enemy is mechanically comparable to the sappers. They use the same dice, ranges, actions, Defense, and lethal combat rules. A single enemy soldier can kill a sapper. The war rarely sends only one.

Pillboxes, gun rooms, gas projectors, and living fortifications use the puzzle-like procedures in [Stationary Defenses](#). They retaliate when their triggers are met rather than taking routine enemy turns.

Reading an Enemy Profile

Each profile lists:

- **Defense:** Successes required to kill it.
- **Speed:** Squares it can move with one action.
- **Attack:** Dice rolled and the attack's range.
- **Skills:** Dice used for important non-combat checks.
- **Traits:** Rules unique to the enemy.

Weapon dice are already included in listed attack pools. The referee does not need to build the pool again.

Enemy Soldiers

Enemy soldiers can use more detailed skills and equipment when a mission requires it. The following profiles keep ordinary fights quick.

Line Soldier

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 4 **Attack:** Rifle 4 dice at Far; bayonet 3 dice at Melee **Skills:** Awareness 3, Mobility 3, Strength 2

Line soldiers hold firing positions, patrol known routes, and concentrate fire when directed. They are roughly equal to newly enlisted sappers but usually fight from prepared positions and in greater numbers.

Enemy Sapper

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 4 **Attack:** Trench gun 4 dice at Close; knife 3 dice at Melee **Skills:** Choose two mission-relevant skills at 5 dice and other checks at 2 dice

Enemy sappers lay mines, recover bodies, alter routes, and investigate Allied equipment. Give each patrol a purpose such as mining a breach, retrieving remains, repairing wire, or hunting the unit.

Assault Corporal

Defense: 2 **Speed:** 6 **Attack:** Automatic trench gun 7 dice at Close; pile-driver 6 dice at Melee **Skills:** Awareness 5, Mobility 5, Strength 5

An Assault Corporal directs nearby soldiers to coordinate fire, flank, and protect recovery efforts. This describes its tactics; enemies still use the normal action and turn-order rules.

Enemy Sergeant

Defense: 3 **Speed:** 8 **Attack:** Choose a level 3 weapon; 10 dice at its listed range **Skills:** Three specialties at 8 dice; other trained actions at 5 dice

Enemy Sergeants are reconstructed veterans carrying rare war technology. They recognize revival kits, target body-recovery efforts, and retreat when preserving their experience will hurt the sappers more than dying.

Enemy Battleborn

Defense: 4 **Speed:** 10 **Attack:** 12 dice at one listed range; 9 dice at another **Skills:** Relevant checks at 10 dice

An enemy Battleborn revives without assistance unless it is completely immobilized or its remains are incinerated. It remembers the unit between runs and may incorporate unrecovered Allied parts into its body.

A Battleborn should be a mission problem rather than an incidental encounter. Trapping, immobilizing, and burning it is more reliable than repeatedly winning direct combat.

Anti-Battleborn Section

Defense: 1 per hunter **Speed:** 4 **Attack:** Restraint gun 5 dice at Close; phosphorus projector 6 dice at Close **Skills:** Awareness 5, Engineering 4, Mobility 3

These specialists deploy only against a Burn-Listed body, a captured Battleborn, or a target command has positively identified as capable of unaided revival. A section contains three to six hunters carrying hooked restraint lines, corpse-recognition reagents, fuel, and enough phosphorus to deny the Butchers a specimen.

The hunters act as one formation. They advance toward the marked body, then spend one formation action beside it securing the remains and preparing the burn. On their next enemy turn, they may spend the formation's action to completely incinerate it. Preparation and incineration must occur on separate enemy turns; splitting the hunters cannot accelerate this procedure. Restraint lines, suppressing fire, and ordinary soldiers protect that procedure. Killing the crew, moving the body, severing their route, or forcing them away interrupts it.

Their arrival must be telegraphed. Let the unit hear the fuel tins, see white-coated troops enter a communications trench, intercept the cremation order, or watch recognition flares rise over the corpse. They are a closing recovery puzzle, not an invisible punishment.

Enemy Recovery

Enemy recovery details operate between runs. Unless the sappers prevent it, enemy bodies are removed, reconstructed, and returned to service. A marked patrol route may therefore be occupied again even after the unit kills everyone assigned to it.

The sappers can interfere by:

- Burning or destroying bodies
- Trapping bodies and recovery routes
- Dragging enemy remains away
- Collapsing access trenches
- Destroying corpse depots and Butcher workshops
- Using enemy remains for field revival

Enemies can do the same to Allied bodies, but they normally attempt capture for study only when a sapper has 25 Humanity or less, bears extensive visible reconstruction, or carries level 3 equipment. A captured sapper may return with enemy alterations, be used as bait, or be incinerated if already Battleborn. Mark the captive's route and provide a rescue opportunity whenever the fiction permits it.

Monsters of No-Man's-Land

Monsters are not a separate ecosystem. They are consequences: corpses combined by shelling, repair organisms that escaped, bodies that revived without enough memory to remain people, and Black Matter teaching meat how to move.

Feral Corpse Hound

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 8 **Attack:** Bite 5 dice at Melee **Skills:** Awareness 6, Stealth 4

Corpse hounds are bred to find and recover bodies. Allied hounds recognize regiment scents and are normally harmless. Feral or enemy hounds drag fallen sappers toward their own trench. A hound that begins its turn beside a body may drag it its full Speed.

Patchwork Heap

Defense: 2 **Speed:** 2 **Attack:** Grasping limbs 6 dice at Melee **Skills:** Strength 8, Awareness 2

Dozens of partial bodies share one directionless revival. When beside a corpse at the beginning of its turn, the Heap incorporates it, gains 1 Defense for the rest of the run, and removes the body from play until the Heap is killed.

Skinless Burrower

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 10 **Attack:** Eruption 6 dice at Melee **Skills:** Stealth 7 beneath earth, Awareness 5

The Burrower travels through soft ground and corpse-filled mud. Its position cannot be attacked until it erupts or an Awareness check reveals its moving tunnel. Substantial flooring, flooded ground, and old foundations block it.

Wire Saint

Defense: 3 **Speed:** 2 **Attack:** Barbed embrace 7 dice at Close **Skills:** Awareness 5, Strength 8

Bodies have grown through a mass of signal wire and barbed coils. A sapper who becomes Dying or is killed by its attack is pulled adjacent to it. A Dying sapper still receives their Last Action. Once the sapper is dead, the Saint knots the body into itself at the beginning of its next turn if it remains adjacent; recovering that sapper then requires killing the Saint or passing a Resistance 3 Engineering check beside it.

Trench Mare

Defense: 2 **Speed:** 12 **Attack:** Charge 7 dice at Melee **Skills:** Mobility 7, Awareness 5, Strength 7

A long equine reconstruction burdened with human arms and respirators. As one charge action, it may move in a straight line and make one Melee attack. If it moves at least 6 squares before attacking, add 2 dice. After a failed attack,

it continues along that line until blocked or its total movement for the action reaches its Speed. It cannot move farther than its Speed during a charge.

Choir in the Mud

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 0 **Attack:** Remembered scream 6 dice at Close **Skills:** Awareness 8

Only its mouths break the surface. When the Choir detects a sapper, it imitates Allied voices, names, and calls for help. If not silenced before the next enemy turn, its screaming triggers an artillery retaliation centered on its position.

Black Matter Bloom

Defense: 2 **Speed:** 0 **Attack:** Rooted tendrils 7 dice at Close **Skills:** Awareness 7 through connected earth

The Bloom grows where too many revivals have soaked the same ground. A sapper killed beside it is pulled below the surface. If not recovered before the next run, the body returns as an enemy reconstruction with one Black Matter replacement and no memory of its unit.

The Unreturned

Defense: 1 **Speed:** 6 **Attack:** Stolen weapon 5 dice at its proper range **Skills:** Stealth 6, Awareness 4, one remembered specialty at 6

The Unreturned resemble missing sappers until light catches the seams. They remember names, routes, and fragments of unit procedure. They attempt to separate one sapper from the group before attacking and may carry equipment lost during previous runs.

Building New Horrors

Start with a recognizable battlefield function: recovery, concealment, breaching, observation, transport, or denial of ground. Give it a body assembled from the war's remains, then add one rule that changes how the sappers approach it.

Use these profiles as rough benchmarks:

Threat	Defense	Attack Dice	Speed
Lesser horror	1	4–5	4–8
Serious horror	2	6–7	2–10
Major horror	3	8–10	2–12
Operation threat	4+	10+	Any

Numbers alone do not make a memorable monster. Its behavior should threaten bodies, map knowledge, equipment, or the unit's ability to recover its dead.

Fixed Defenses and Killing Works

Stationary defenses are not ordinary enemies waiting to exchange attacks. They are sections of the battlefield built to make a direct approach impossible: pillboxes, buried projectors, sealed gun rooms, observation cupolas, and living fortifications whose operators may never be visible. Use the normal checks, cooperation, attacks, and visibility rules from [Skill Checks and Exploration](#) and [Combat and Movement](#) except where a profile below replaces them. [Field Doctrines](#) can reveal or exploit an opening but never erase a defense's Protection.

Run an emplacement like a **trap with a crew**, not a combatant with another turn. It threatens a known piece of ground, reacts when its trigger is met, and becomes vulnerable only when the sappers learn how it works or force it to look the wrong way.

The unit should solve an emplacement through observation, distraction, concealment, sabotage, terrain, or cooperation. Gunfire may finish the solution, but firing at a sealed wall is not one.

Reading an Emplacement Profile

Each stationary defense lists:

- **Tell:** What careful sappers can notice before entering its killing ground.
- **Coverage:** The squares, route, structure, or area it can threaten.
- **Trigger:** What causes it to retaliate.
- **Retaliation:** What happens when it fires or activates.
- **Protection:** Why it cannot be defeated head-on.
- **Openings:** Conditions that expose its crew, mechanism, ammunition, or blind approach.
- **Defeat:** What permanently disables or destroys it.

Mark confirmed coverage, triggers, blind ground, and successful sabotage on the shared map. What the unit learns survives the sappers who learned it.

The Emplacement Cycle

Most stationary defenses follow three steps.

1. Read the Killing Ground

Describe at least one Tell before the defense activates. From a position outside its trigger and coverage, the players may study visible evidence with a Resistance 0 Awareness, Engineering, or other suitable check: the basic result identifies the obstacle, and each success reveals its probable trigger, the shape of its coverage, or one opening. Investigation performed while exposed to the emplacement is Resistance 1 or higher. Failure then provokes its retaliation when the fiction allows it.

A previously mapped trigger or firing lane remains known on later runs unless the enemy visibly changes it.

When a dangerous investigation fails, the emplacement retaliates and Bought Knowledge reveals one thing its response exposed. Its shot might establish a firing lane, a moving shutter might reveal the reload interval, or responding troops might expose an access trench. Reveal one next step, not every Opening at once.

2. Create an Opening

The unit must make the defense unable to cover everything at once. Common methods include:

- One sapper draws its attention while another moves through a blind area.
- Smoke, darkness, debris, or suppressing fire blocks its sight.
- A false sound, thrown object, animal, or moving corpse triggers it at the wrong time.
- A sapper remains hidden until a firing slit, projector door, vent, or crew member is exposed.
- The unit reaches a tunnel, drainage culvert, roof, rear door, ammunition line, or observation cable.

- Earlier sabotage lowers an operation-level Resistance or removes one of the defense's protections.

A successful distraction holds the emplacement's attention on one declared target or area until the beginning of the distractor's next turn. It cannot retaliate against a different approach during that window unless another profile rule says otherwise. The distractor remains exposed to its retaliation.

3. Exploit the Opening

Once an Opening exists, another sapper may act against the exposed part. The action might be a Ranged attack through a firing slit, a Close Quarters attack on the crew, an Engineering check against a feed mechanism, Demolitions against ammunition or supports, or movement through a concealed route.

During combat, leading and helping with this action consume the participants' actions as normal. The emplacement's listed trigger explicitly allows it to retaliate during combat; it does not also take an enemy turn.

General Rules

No Head-On Attack

An intact emplacement's outer structure cannot be attacked with ordinary weapons. Its crew and working parts cannot be targeted until an Opening exposes them. A weapon or charge specifically capable of destroying the structure treats it as an operation-level obstacle, normally Resistance 4, and still requires preparation that reduces that Resistance.

For example, a reinforced pillbox begins at Resistance 4 and cannot be breached directly. Cutting its reinforcement trench reduces it to 3. Reaching and detonating its buried ammunition supply reduces it to 2.

Triggered Retaliation

An emplacement retaliates when its Trigger occurs, even during combat. It does not act merely because an enemy turn begins. Unless a profile says otherwise, it retaliates no more than once during each sapper turn; several sappers moving together may all be threatened by one explicitly multi-target retaliation.

If one attack threatens several targets, make one roll and compare its successes separately with each target's Defense. Apply one lethal hit to every target whose Defense is met.

Attention and Distraction

A defense capable of aiming has **Attention**. Its Attention rests on the last area where it detected a credible target. A sapper may draw Attention by becoming visible, making a loud attack, deliberately failing concealment, or succeeding on a suitable check. The referee states whether the attempted distraction is credible before dice are rolled.

If the distraction succeeds, another route becomes an Opening. If it fails, the defense retaliates against the distractor and keeps its previous coverage.

Mindless, automated, or living defenses may be distracted by the stimulus described in their profile rather than by ordinary soldiers.

Hidden Sappers and the Perfect Shot

A sapper hidden outside the defense's current Attention may wait without making repeated checks. When an Opening appears, they may use their next action to attack the exposed target. The profile gives that target's Defense. Success disables the listed part or kills the exposed operator; it does not damage the surrounding fortification.

If the shot fails during combat, the emplacement does not gain an extra retaliation unless the shot itself meets its Trigger, such as muzzle flash revealing the sapper inside its coverage.

Bypassing and Returning

Bypassing a defense does not destroy it. Mark the safe route and the still-active coverage separately. The emplacement may threaten retreat, recovery, reinforcements, or later runs until disabled.

A disabled defense remains disabled unless the enemy has a surviving route, crew, and enough time to repair it. Repairs should leave a Tell and should not erase the unit's knowledge of the underlying position.

Conventional Emplacements

Machine-Gun Pillbox

A low concrete bunker covers a road, wire gap, trench approach, or broad firing lane. Its gun fires from a slit too narrow to assault from the front.

- **Tell:** Cut vegetation, rows of old impacts, ammunition links in the mud, a narrow dark slit, or ground conspicuously free of bodies.
- **Coverage:** One marked lane, normally 4–8 squares wide, extending to the limit of the gun's visible coverage.
- **Trigger:** Visible movement, muzzle flash, or a loud impact within the lane.
- **Retaliation:** The gun makes one 7-dice Far attack. If several sappers cross the lane together, the same roll threatens each of them.
- **Protection:** The concrete shell and recessed slit cannot be attacked head-on. The hidden crew has Defense 1 when exposed.
- **Openings:** Attention drawn to one edge of the lane; smoke across the slit; a drainage route beneath its fire; the gun barrel exposed while traversing; a rear entrance, ammunition feed, or observation cable reached from outside its coverage.
- **Defeat:** Kill the exposed gunner, jam or sabotage the feed at Resistance 2 Engineering, place explosives at the slit or rear door at Resistance 2 Demolitions, or collapse its supports after reducing its operation-level Resistance.

The pillbox is the model for a distraction and perfect-shot puzzle. One sapper can draw bursts against hard shelter while a hidden rifleman waits for the gunner to lean into the slit. Another unit might fill the lane with smoke and crawl to the rear door instead.

Armored Observation Cupola

A steel dome watches several approaches and directs artillery it does not fire itself.

- **Tell:** A turning lens, field telephone wire, ranging flags, fresh shell patterns, or a dome on terrain too exposed for an ordinary sentry.
- **Coverage:** Every visible square in its marked coverage, divided by solid barriers and terrain.
- **Trigger:** The cupola observes a sapper remain in one area, use explosives, or cross a previously watched route.
- **Retaliation:** Mark the observed square. At the end of the next sapper turn, a shell attacks everyone still within 2 squares with 8 dice. The mark remains visible before impact.
- **Protection:** The armored dome cannot be harmed by ordinary firearms. Its observer has Defense 1 when a vision shutter opens.
- **Openings:** Feed it movement at a false target; sever or follow its telephone wire; approach through dead ground; reflect light into the lens; wait hidden for the shutter to open while it confirms a target.
- **Defeat:** Kill the observer through the open shutter, cut the communication line at Resistance 1 Engineering, enter through its buried access, or destroy the dome's foundation at Resistance 3 Demolitions after reaching it.

Retractable Trench Cannon

A heavy gun rises from a protected pit, fires once, and sinks below an armored cover to reload.



An enemy trench cannon as seen from the front

- **Tell:** Parallel rails, hydraulic fluid, a semicircle of blast-cleared mud, shell racks, or a crew trench leading to an apparently empty pit.
- **Coverage:** One broad Far firing arc shown on the referee's map.
- **Trigger:** A vehicle, formation, fortification, or several sappers enter the arc together.
- **Retaliation:** The cannon makes one 10-dice attack against one target or one occupied square, then retracts. Everyone in a targeted square is threatened by the same roll.
- **Protection:** It cannot be targeted while retracted. The raised gun has Defense 3; its loading crew has Defense 1.
- **Openings:** Bait the gun into firing at false movement; jam its cover while raised; enter the loading trench during its reload; sabotage the rails or hydraulic line.
- **Defeat:** Jam it at Resistance 2 Engineering during the firing window, kill the exposed crew, detonate its shell rack, or place a charge beneath the retracted platform.

Flame and Gas Emplacements

Flame Casemate

A buried fuel reservoir feeds a projector behind an armored shutter. It denies trenches, tunnels, and narrow approaches rather than sweeping an entire field.

- **Tell:** Oily condensation, dead ground without intact corpses, heat shimmer, fuel pipes, scorched brick, or the click of a shutter cycling.
- **Coverage:** A Close cone or one trench section extending 6 squares from the projector.
- **Trigger:** Warm movement, vibration on a pressure line, or any sapper crossing the marked threshold.

- **Retaliation:** Everyone in the covered area is attacked once with 7 dice. A sapper killed by the flame, including one who dies after a Last Action caused by its hit, cannot be revived unless recoverable material remains. A Battleborn death marks Burn normally; an effect that explicitly completely incinerates the remains causes permanent destruction.
- **Protection:** The projector sits behind a shutter that opens only to fire. The nozzle has Defense 3 while open.
- **Openings:** Trigger it with a thrown object or moving corpse; cool or mask a sapper's heat; cut the pressure line; flood the trench; approach along the fuel pipe; wait hidden for the shutter.
- **Defeat:** Shoot or jam the open nozzle, close the fuel valve at Resistance 2 Engineering, rupture the reservoir from a safe route, or redirect the projector into its own position.

Rupturing fuel without first learning its route may turn the surrounding ground into a larger fire hazard. Telegraph this clearly.

Gas Projector Nest

A sealed bunker pumps gas through buried pipes and low vents. Its true weapon is the ground around it.

- **Tell:** Dead insects, tarnished metal, low vapor, masks nailed near safe passages, buried ceramic pipe, or wind flags watched by a sealed crew.
- **Coverage:** One depression, trench network, tunnel, or connected group of marked squares. Wind or ventilation determines where gas moves.
- **Trigger:** A trip line, opened hatch, detected movement, or a remote observer's signal.
- **Retaliation:** Fill the first covered area with gas and move it 2 squares with the wind at the end of each sapper turn. A sapper entering or beginning a turn in it must pass a Resistance 1 Mobility check using a working respirator or mark a Wound box. This explicitly applies during combat.
- **Protection:** The sealed pumping room cannot be attacked through the cloud. Its external valves and vents can be reached.
- **Openings:** Move upwind; block or reverse a vent; follow a clean-air pipe; create a false trigger while the unit waits outside the spread; enter through a maintenance line; turn the gas toward enemy works.
- **Defeat:** Shut the master valve at Resistance 2 Engineering, destroy the pump after reaching its service room, collapse the feed tunnel, or ignite an identified gas that the referee has clearly established as flammable.

Gas remains on the map until wind, ventilation, or deliberate action clears it. Respirators permit the check; they do not make the area safe.

Reconstructed and Unnatural Emplacements

Corpse-Recognition Gun

A pillbox that has no living gunner. Preserved eyes and noses are wired around its slit, and the gun fires at bodies it does not recognize.

- **Tell:** Jars facing the field, a wet clicking behind the slit, bodies arranged by uniform, or a firing lane interrupted around enemy corpses.
- **Coverage:** One Far lane or approach.
- **Trigger:** The organs see or smell an unrecognized living body within coverage.
- **Retaliation:** A 7-dice Far attack against the detected target. Several sappers deliberately moving together can be threatened by one roll.
- **Protection:** Killing a crew cannot stop it. The sensing cluster has Defense 3 and is visible only when its lids unfold to identify a target.
- **Openings:** Wear enemy material; move behind a recognized corpse; overwhelm one sense with smoke, blood, or decay; let one disguised sapper hold its Attention; approach through a route with no line to the organ cluster.
- **Defeat:** Destroy the exposed cluster, replace its scent reservoir, sever its preserved nerves at Resistance 2 Engineering, or feed it donor material that makes the Allied unit register as recognized.

A failed disguise should reveal which sense rejected it before the gun fires. The death must teach the next run something.

Choir Aperture

Human throats are mortared into a bunker wall. They listen for speech, repeat it in the voices of the dead, and direct a hidden weapon toward anyone who answers.

- **Tell:** Whispered repetitions, names spoken from inside solid masonry, wax-filled enemy ears, or firing lanes aimed at places where echoes carry.
- **Coverage:** A Close network of trenches, rooms, or ruins connected by sound.
- **Trigger:** Speech, shouted orders, gunfire, or a sapper answering an imitated voice.
- **Retaliation:** The Choir fixes the speaker's location. A concealed gun makes a 6-dice attack that ignores smoke but not solid barriers.
- **Protection:** The throats are spread throughout the structure. Destroying one does not silence the Choir.
- **Openings:** Use hand signals; create sound somewhere else; speak through a long pipe; follow which throats answer first; use a donor memory already established in play to recognize and complete the Choir's phrase.
- **Defeat:** Sever the central vocal cord at Resistance 2 Engineering, drown the chambers, destroy the resonating room, or use its repeated commands to direct enemy defenders into the wrong position.

Hearing the Choir clearly may qualify for Humanity loss from perceiving the other side, but do not charge Humanity merely for hearing one unsettling voice.

Black-Root Ballista

A buried mass of Black Matter grows bone shafts and launches them toward vibration. It has no sight, crew, or allegiance.

- **Tell:** Parallel punctures through stone, bone splinters pointing backward toward one patch of earth, complete stillness among nearby creatures, or roots tightening beneath a footstep.
- **Coverage:** A Far line through connected earth. Deep water, suspended flooring, and broken ground interrupt it.
- **Trigger:** Repeated footsteps, digging, explosions, or a heavy impact touching the same earth.
- **Retaliation:** The root launches a 9-dice Far attack through the strongest vibration. The projectile can cross smoke and darkness but not disconnected ground.
- **Protection:** The buried organism cannot be targeted from the surface. Its firing pore has Defense 3 during the instant it opens.
- **Openings:** Move over debris without touching earth; create a stronger vibration elsewhere; flood or sever the soil; remain still until another creature draws the shot; expose the root through an existing crater.
- **Defeat:** Strike the open pore, sever three marked root junctions at Resistance 1 Engineering each, poison it with a prepared source, or lure it into repeatedly firing until it excavates its own core.

Touching an active root is contact with Black Matter and costs Humanity as normal.

Ossuary Gate

A passage has been sealed with interlocked bodies that tense when approached. The gate rebuilds itself from nearby remains and opens only for movements its borrowed nerves remember.

- **Tell:** Hands worn smooth at repeated gestures, uniform fragments from many armies, footprints ending at the wall, or faces turning toward familiar voices.
- **Coverage:** One doorway, trench throat, tunnel, or narrow route.
- **Trigger:** Touch, forced entry, an unfamiliar gait, or damage to the outer layer of bodies.
- **Retaliation:** The gate makes a 7-dice Close attack with grasping limbs. When its attack makes a sapper Dying or kills them, the gate holds them in place. A Dying sapper still receives their Last Action. Unless freed, the sapper is pulled into the structure at the end of the next sapper turn, after any Last Action.

- **Protection:** Ordinary attacks remove flesh that immediately regrows from nearby remains. It has no meaningful Defense while the rebuilding supply remains connected.
- **Openings:** Imitate a donor's remembered movement; present a matching body part; remove nearby remains; follow an enemy through; trigger the grasp elsewhere while a hidden sapper reaches the nerve knot.
- **Defeat:** Sever its supply of bodies, cut the central nerve knot at Resistance 2 Close Quarters or Engineering during an Opening, burn the established regrowth source, or teach it a new recognized gesture through repeated donor contact.

A sapper incorporated into the gate is recoverable until the next run unless the operation establishes that the structure moves or consumes its bodies sooner.

Building New Stationary Defenses

Start with a battlefield function rather than a weapon name:

- Deny a route
- Watch an area
- Separate the unit
- Prevent body recovery
- Protect a supply or reinforcement line
- Force movement into another hazard

Then give the defense:

1. One clear Tell before activation.
2. One specific Trigger.
3. One dangerous Retaliation.
4. One reason a frontal attack cannot work.
5. At least three Openings using different skills or pieces of terrain.
6. One permanent way to disable it and one way merely to bypass it.
7. One discovery that remains valuable after everyone dies.

Do not hide every solution behind checks. A plan that directly defeats the trigger should work. Roll when execution under danger remains uncertain, not to make the players prove that a solved puzzle is still solved.

Referee Principles

- **Show the killing field before the weapon.** Bodies, craters, silence, and altered terrain reveal coverage.
- **Let the defense be consistent.** A trigger that changes without cause turns a puzzle into a guess.
- **Attack the approach, not every turn.** The emplacement reacts when the sappers give it something to react to.
- **Reward divided roles.** One sapper distracts, one observes, one moves, and one exploits the opening.
- **Keep several answers alive.** Concealment, sabotage, terrain, equipment, donor memories, and violence should all matter.
- **Make bypass different from victory.** A route around the gun helps now; a silenced gun changes every later run.
- **Let death reveal procedure.** If the emplacement kills a sapper, the unit should learn where it looked, what woke it, or how long it remained open.

FIELD AIDS

Combat Checklist

Keep this page beside the local combat map. Consult [Combat and Movement](#) for the complete rules, [Death and Revival](#) for recovery, and [Field Doctrines](#) for each sapper's doctrine.

Start Combat

- Establish visible enemies, solid barriers, smoke, darkness, and dangerous ground.
- Group two to six ordinary soldiers into each formation.
- Identify which sappers and enemies are Exposed.
- Remind the table of Melee, Close, and Far range.
- If one side has not detected the other, mark the unaware side Surprised: -1 Defense, minimum 1, through the first round.

Each Round

Sapper Turn

- Every living sapper acts once, in any player-chosen order.
- Resolve any Dying sapper's Last Action; they die immediately afterward.
- Common actions: attack, move, use an item, attempt a task, cooperate, begin revival, or retreat.

Enemy Turn

- Every formation, independent enemy, and monster acts once.
- A formation uses the leader's attack pool and gains +1 die per supporting soldier, maximum +3.
- Enemies pursue objectives: suppress, flank, seize bodies, protect positions, call artillery, or retreat.

Resolve a Check or Attack

1. State the action, target, danger, and Resistance or Defense.
2. Build the pool: skill + one relevant item + modifiers.
3. For cooperation, add only each trained helper's checked skill ranks; leading and helping each consume an action.
4. Roll d6s; every 6 is one success.
5. Allow Borrowed Reflex immediately after any check or attack roll, before resolving its result.
6. Resistance 0 automatically succeeds; give the basic result and one additional finding per success, with no retaliation.
7. On success, complete the declared action.
8. During combat, failure does not add immediate retaliation unless a specific rule says otherwise.
9. Resolve Wounds, Dying or killing, equipment, Humanity, thresholds, then map changes.

Bought Knowledge applies automatically only outside combat. A failed combat action grants it only when an attack, hazard, emplacement, or operation explicitly says that failure reveals something. Visible enemy actions still reveal their ordinary positions and behavior.

Lethal Hits

- Empty Wound box: mark it; the sapper is Wounded.
- No empty Wound box: the sapper is Dying.
- Dying: one Last Action on their next sapper turn, then death.
- Another lethal hit or an explicit **killed** effect ends a Dying sapper immediately.
- Each marked Wound box removes 1 die; pools never fall below one die from wounds.
- Place one red paper clip at a gained Wound spot for each marked box; remove it when that wound clears. Ungained spots cannot absorb hits.

Multiple Targets

- An attack normally selects one target.

- If a rule lets one attack threaten several targets, roll once.
- Compare the successes separately with every target's Defense.
- Apply one lethal hit to each target whose Defense is met.

Field Revival

- The sapper must be Fallen, identifiable, and in the same or an adjacent square.
- No roll is required. The reviver spends their full turn and remains through the enemy turn.
- Death or forced movement interrupts the attempt. Becoming Dying does not interrupt an attempt already underway; it completes before the reviver's Last Action.
- The revived sapper returns at the beginning of the next sapper turn.
- Remove every Wound clip to clear the boxes; the revived sapper may act normally that turn.

Retreat

- Spend actions moving toward a known route, shelter, map edge, or position outside immediate attack.
- End combat when every survivor reaches it.
- If the enemy can pursue, continue exact movement or resolve one cooperative escape check.

Movement and Exploration Checklist

Use the shared map to preserve knowledge, not to count every quiet footstep. Consult [Core Game Loop](#) for map procedure, [Combat and Movement](#) for dangerous movement, and [Retaliation Tables](#) when failure changes the battlefield.

Outside Immediate Danger

- Ask where the unit is going and which marked route it follows.
- Move between meaningful locations, obstacles, or decisions.
- Do not count exact squares.
- Do not roll for a known safe route unless something has changed.
- Add discoveries, hazards, shelter, bodies, and equipment to the shared map.

When Exact Movement Begins

Count squares during:

- Combat
- Pursuit or escape
- Timed artillery, fire, gas, collapse, or flooding
- A dangerous crossing where every position changes exposure

A movement action crosses 2 + checked **Mobility** ranks squares, maximum 12. Dangerous ground may require a check. Solid barriers, smoke, and darkness may prevent attacks by blocking sight.

Calling for Checks

- State the Resistance and visible danger before commitment.
- Use Resistance 0 for safe analysis or searching when successes can reveal additional information, options, or resources.
- Give the basic Resistance 0 result automatically, then add one useful finding per success rolled. It never causes retaliation.
- Use Resistance 1 or higher only when failure can change the situation.
- On a Resistance 1+ failure outside combat, create one immediate retaliation and reveal one Bought Knowledge truth.
- Tie the truth to the consequence, mark it on the shared map, and make it point toward a new decision without solving the obstacle.
- On success, honor the route, shelter, information, or position gained.

Returning Across Known Ground

- Let the unit cross unchanged safe sections quickly.
- Stop only for pursuit, a changed hazard, enemy reaction, or a consequential unrecovered body.
- A fallen sapper must be revived before retreating with the unit. Equipment and specific recovery actions may reposition bodies, but ordinary retreat does not carry them back to the trench.

Run Cycle Checklist

Use this beside [Core Game Loop](#). Consult [Mission Construction](#) before the operation, [Equipment](#) during outfitting, and [Death and Revival](#) when resolving recovery and reconstruction.

Before the First Run

- Confirm safety boundaries and desired horror intensity.
- Give the unit its objective and incomplete map.
- Issue three level 1 items to each Private.
- Mark Humanity, Defense, Wound capacity, Borrowed Reflex, Burn, and consumables. Put red paper clips by the sheet's Wound spots only when wounds occur.
- Establish the Allied trench and the first visible landmark.

During Every Run

1. **Briefing:** Restate the objective and any new orders.
2. **Outfitting:** Assign each item to one bearer.
3. **Deployment:** Begin at the Allied trench and cross known safe ground quickly.
4. **Discovery:** Reveal essential facts freely; use Resistance 0 when a safe check measures additional findings.
5. **Retaliation:** Outside combat, resolve one immediate consequence for Resistance 1+ failure, then mark one Bought Knowledge truth. During combat, the enemy turn is the retaliation unless a specific rule says otherwise. Resistance 0 never retaliates.
6. **Recovery:** Field-revive fallen sappers or decide what bodies must be abandoned.
7. **Retreat or Objective:** Return to the trench or complete the operation.

Between Runs

- Preserve discoveries, cleared obstacles, destroyed positions, caches, and lost equipment.
- Remove temporary smoke, fire, and other short-lived effects.
- Resolve abandoned bodies and Butcher reconstruction.
- Remove Wound clips for every revived sapper; never add capacity beyond Humanity thresholds.
- Apply Humanity loss and identity erasure.
- Record replacement parts and donor sources, newly checked skill ranks, military rank, Wounds, and Burn.
- If a death was staged solely to gain ranks, grant no skill ranks, including no Black Matter bonus.
- Decide what the enemy observed and choose one or two logical reactions.
- Track any anti-Battleborn section already dispatched when the third Burn box was marked or a later death occurred; do not delay its dispatch until between runs.
- Replace and refill level 1 gear; account separately for scarce level 2 and priority level 3 items and consumables.
- Assign items to bearers and refresh per-run abilities. Players may add an optional donor memory to a replacement. Do not refill scarce consumables unless supply is available.
- Mark recoverable bodies, captives, enemy routes, and the next opportunity to bring them home.
- Show one new sign of Allied readiness. This creates obligation, not a hidden deadline.
- Begin the next run from the Allied trench.

End the Operation

End when the objective is unmistakably complete or every sapper is permanently dead. Record what command claims happened and what the map proves instead.

Example Sappers

These recruits demonstrate the six starting specialties and their [Field Doctrines](#). Each has 2 ranks from a specialty and 5 ranks from recruit training, no starting skill above 3, Defense 1, Humanity 100, and three level 1 equipment slots.

They may be used as ready-made characters or as guides when creating new sappers. Names, memories, appearance, and equipment can be changed without altering the starting package.

Private Elsie Ward, Scout

Specialty: Scout **Field Doctrine:** Read the Ground • **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 4 squares

Appearance: Short, narrow-shouldered, with cropped black hair and a pale birthmark covering her left ear. **Memory Before the War:** Falling asleep beneath a kitchen table while adults talked above her. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** Her younger brother's laugh.

Skill	Rank
Awareness	3
Stealth	2
Mobility	2
All others	0

Equipment: Field glasses, camouflage sheet, service revolver

Role: Ward observes routes from shelter, identifies patrol patterns, and marks dangers before the unit enters them. With field glasses she rolls 4 dice for Far Awareness. Her combat skills are untrained, so she depends on information and concealment rather than firepower.

Private Tomas Varga, Demolitionist

Specialty: Demolitionist **Field Doctrine:** Leave the Right Ruin • **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 4 squares

Appearance: Broad hands, missing two natural teeth, old powder burns across the chin. **Memory Before the War:** Splitting stone beside his father on a road above the sea. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** The sea was blue.

Skill	Rank
Demolitions	3
Ranged	2
Mobility	2
All others	0

Equipment: Satchel charges ○ ○ ○, fragmentation grenades ○ ○ ○, entrenching tool

Role: Varga breaches fortifications and attacks clustered enemies. He rolls 4 dice to place satchel charges and 3 dice when throwing grenades at Close range.

Private Mina Nowak, Mine-Clearer

Specialty: Mine-Clearer **Field Doctrine:** Follow My Steps • **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 4 squares

Appearance: Tall, shaved head, inked measurements running from each fingertip to the wrist. **Memory Before the War:** Snow melting around the first flowers outside a railway station. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** Her mother's handwriting.

Skill	Rank
Engineering	3
Awareness	2
Mobility	2
All others	0

Equipment: Mine probe and marking flags, field dressings ○ ○ ○, bolt-action rifle

Role: Nowak locates and clears routes through buried hazards. She rolls 4 dice with her mine probe and can treat wounds when the unit has time to risk a Mobility check.

Private Isaac Bell, Trench Fighter

Specialty: Trench Fighter **Field Doctrine:** Behind Me • **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 4 squares

Appearance: Heavy jaw, cauliflower ears, and regimental prayers written inside both sleeves. **Memory Before the War:** Dancing badly in a crowded room while someone stood on his boots. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** He once disliked violence.

Skill	Rank
Close Quarters	3
Strength	2
Mobility	2
All others	0

Equipment: Trench knife, trench shotgun, field dressings ○ ○ ○

Role: Bell protects specialists and clears confined positions. He attacks with 4 dice using the knife at Melee range. His untrained Ranged skill gives one base die, so the shotgun provides a modest 2-dice Close attack when he cannot reach the enemy.

Private Jean Mercer, Runner

Specialty: Runner **Field Doctrine:** No One Left • **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 5 squares

Appearance: Long-legged, freckled, with a surgical brace around the right knee even before first deployment.

Memory Before the War: Delivering a letter without reading the address because the road was already known. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** Someone is still waiting for a letter.

Skill	Rank
Mobility	3
Awareness	2
Strength	2
All others	0

Equipment: Rope and climbing hooks, Butcher's field roll, service revolver

Role: Mercer reaches objectives and bodies before the battlefield closes around them. The field roll reduces the normal Humanity cost of field revival by 1, making Mercer especially valuable when the other sappers die far from the trench.

Private Anja Roth, Rifleman

Specialty: Rifleman **Field Doctrine:** Wait for the Opening · **Defense:** 1 **Humanity:** 100 **Movement:** 2 squares

Appearance: Right eye clouded at the edge, three brass identification tags tied around the neck. **Memory Before the War:** Holding her breath while a deer crossed a field at dawn. **What Must Not Be Forgotten:** The deer was allowed to live.

Skill	Rank
Ranged	3
Awareness	2
Stealth	2
All others	0

Equipment: Bolt-action rifle, field glasses, camouflage sheet

Role: Roth observes and engages threats at Far range. She attacks with 4 dice using the rifle and rolls 3 dice when using the field glasses to search distant ground.

Using Example Sappers

These packages are deliberately uneven outside their specialties. Cooperation and equipment selection should matter, and no recruit can cover every danger.

After each eligible revival, assign 2 skill ranks among any skills during the next between-runs step, or 3 total if Black Matter was used. Black Matter also adds 2 Humanity to that revival's cost. Choose the replacement part from what killed the sapper and its source from available material; use the [fallback tables](#) only when needed. The number of checked boxes is the skill's current rank. Donor memories are optional roleplay details.

APPENDIX

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Background Map

The web reader background is adapted from *Battle of the Somme trench map*, catalogue reference **WO 95/2019**, held by The National Archives:

<https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/resources/medicine-on-the-western-front-part-two/battle-of-the-somme-trench-map/>

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